WEDNESDAY
November 11, 2026

INTERNATIONAL EDITION
18 Pages

THE HINDU

www.thehindu.com

INDIA'S NATIONAL NEWSPAPER SINCE 1878

Vol. 4 • No. 266

To subscribe, give a missed call at 9828331787 or scan QR code

Chennai » Coimbatore » Bengaluru » Hyderabad » Madurai » Noida » Visakhapatnam » Thiruvananthapuram » Kochi » Vijayawada » Mangaluru » Tiruchirapalli » Kolkata » Hubballi » Mohali » Malappuram » Mumbai » Lucknow » Cuttack » Patna



MEA DECLINES TO COMMENT

Russia behind arrest in India: U.S. citizen

NEWS » PAGE 4



'SHOCKING' ACCOUNTS

Sonia's memoir hits the stalls ahead of official launch

NEWS » PAGE 5



UNDERUTILISATION FLAGGED

PSU insurers dodge questions on TPA use

BUSINESS » PAGE 12

A ROBUST DEMOCRACY

Keralam at 70: holding a mirror to India

The State offers a vision of pluralism and secularism

OPINION » PAGE 9



RAIN RULES THE DAY

Third one-dayer at Hamilton abandoned

SPORT » PAGE 16

INSIDE



FBI probing spy angle in Huang's affair: Trump

WASHINGTON
U.S. President Donald Trump said on Monday that the FBI is investigating Nvidia CEO Jensen Huang's affair with an alleged Chinese government agent, after media reports said U.S. intelligence determined that the woman in question was gathering information for Beijing — a claim dismissed by China. » PAGE 14



'Hasina will be executed if she returns home'

DHAKA
Bangladeshi prosecutor Md Aminul Islam who secured the death sentence against ousted Prime Minister Sheikh Hasina said on Tuesday she will be executed if she returns home, amid reports that she planned to return from self-imposed exile in India. » PAGE 14

Opposition grows against dam plan in Arunachal

GUWAHATI
Communities that are living downstream of a hydropower project on the Dibang river have stepped up the heat on the governments of Assam and Arunachal Pradesh, with the latter already on the brink due to growing opposition to two other proposed mega dam projects. » PAGE 4

GNA power deal: Pinarayi calls for judicial probe

THIRUVANANTHAPURAM
Leader of the Opposition in the Keralam Assembly Pinarayi Vijayan has demanded a judicial inquiry headed by a High Court judge into the controversy surrounding the cancellation of the GNA power purchase deal. » PAGE 3



Barefoot College founder, Bunker Roy, passes away

NEW DELHI
One of the foundational figures of modern civil society in India and the founder of Barefoot College, Sanjit "Bunker" Roy, died at his home in Tilonia in Ajmer district of Rajasthan on Tuesday. He was 81. » PAGE 6

U.S. court allows suits on NSA Doval, RAW ex-chief

Order issued in civil plea by Khalistani separatist Pannun linked to an alleged assassination plot against him in New York in 2023; External Affairs Ministry rejects charges, calls lawsuit 'frivolous'

Suhasini Haidar
NEW DELHI

A U.S. court on Monday allowed Khalistani separatist and lawyer Gurpatwant Singh Pannun to serve his civil plea on National Security Adviser (NSA) Ajit Doval and former Research and Analysis Wing (RAW) chief Samant Goel through Indian judicial channels, after the State Department submitted that it had served the notice on the two officials at the Indian Embassy in Washington.

The External Affairs Ministry rejected the move, calling the lawsuit "frivolous" and saying such judicial documents must be sent to the Law and Justice Ministry in India. "We reject the fabricated and malicious attacks on our high officials, as also we reject the frivolous lawsuits. Request for serving of judicial documents in India can only be routed through India's designated central authority, that is the Ministry of Law and Justice," Ministry spokesperson Randhir Jaiswal said.

High-profile summons

The U.S. court order comes after its State Department served notice on the two officials at Indian Embassy in Washington

- Gurpatwant Singh Pannun, a U.S.-based lawyer, is wanted in India on terror charges
- Court asks him to prepare documents and the route by which the summons will be issued by November 30
- Notice delivered to Embassy only a 'legal obligation' and not 'taking a position', says U.S. State Department

> We reject the fabricated and malicious attacks on our high officials, as also we reject the frivolous lawsuits
>
> **RANDHIR JAISWAL**
> MEA spokesperson



The lawsuit filed by Mr. Pannun, wanted in India on terror charges, is separate but linked to the U.S. Federal Bureau of Investigation (FBI)'s findings of alleged Indian links to an assassination plot against him in June 2023.

Granting permission for the summons on Monday, U.S. District Judge Katherine Polk Failla directed Mr. Pannun to prepare documents on or before November 30, including the summons addressed to Mr. Doval and Mr. Goel, details of Indian law and procedure, and the route by which the summons would be issued, as well as records of previous attempts at serving the two officials under the Hague Convention. The certificate of submission delivered to the Indian Embassy by the State Department was signed by an official and dated October 9. The State Department said in a footnote that the delivery did not mean it was taking a "position" on the case and it was a "legal obligation".

An undercover Drug Enforcement Agency informant had pointed the FBI investigation into the lawyer's assassination plot to Indian businessman Nikhil Gupta, and to conversations with senior Indian intelligence officials, including Vikash Yadav, regarding a conspiracy to hire a hitman to kill Mr. Pannun in New York.

Mr. Gupta pleaded guilty to the charges, and the U.S. courts have scheduled the sentencing for November 20. Mr. Yadav was arrested in Delhi in December 2023 on separate charges by Indian authorities and was given bail in April 2024.

The FBI and Canadian officials, who are investigating a similar case involving the killing of separatist Harjeet Singh Nijjar in Vancouver in June 2023, appear to have dropped earlier claims of the involvement of more senior officials, including Mr. Doval, Mr. Goel, and Union Home Minister Amit Shah.

In February 2025, when Mr. Doval accompanied Prime Minister Narendra Modi to Washington for a bilateral visit and meeting with U.S. President Donald Trump, Mr. Pannun had tried to serve the NSA with a notice and failed.

Russia, Ukraine begin talks mediated by U.S. to end war

Associated Press
ABU DHABI



Key discussion: Members of the Russian and Ukrainian delegations meet in the presence of U.S. envoys in Abu Dhabi on Tuesday. AFP

Three-way talks between Russia, Ukraine, and the U.S. opened in the UAE on Tuesday, as Washington made another push to end the war in Europe which started nearly five years ago. The two-day session in Abu Dhabi is the first such meeting since February. It will focus on establishing future security guarantees for the warring countries, the White House said. While Russia sees the North Atlantic Treaty Organisation as a threat, Ukraine wants to prevent future Russian invasions.

The first day of talks concluded after nearly four hours, the RIA Novosti news agency said. They are expected to resume on Wednesday, according to the press office of the Foreign Intelligence Service of Ukraine.

U.S. President Donald Trump's son-in-law, Jared Kushner, who is trying to broker a settlement along with U.S. envoy Steve Witkoff, said he believed there were "some good ideas how to bridge" the differences between the two sides.

Rustem Umerov, the head of Ukraine's Foreign Intelligence Service who is leading Kyiv's delegation, thanked the U.S. for its efforts to end Russia's invasion. "Our people are waiting to end this war. And we hope that we will achieve the lasting peace for Ukraine," he said.

The head of the Russian delegation, Vladimir Medinsky, expressed hope the meeting "will allow us to advance on the path towards peace in the interests of the people of Russia and the people of Ukraine".

U.S. Secretary of State Marco Rubio called the meeting "very productive" while Ukrainian President Volodymyr Zelenskyy said the session was "constructive and quite substantive."

"It looks like the talks in Abu Dhabi were very productive," Mr. Rubio said in Paris at a G7 meeting. "There's a lot of work to be done in that regard. It's not like something that's on the verge of being solved in the next 24 hours or anything like that."

Mr. Zelenskyy said the talks were largely about humanitarian issues, including prisoner exchanges and returning Ukrainian civilians in captivity, as well as children taken from the country.

NATO commander U.S. Gen. Alexus Grynkewich pointed to "some great progress in the past in a military-to-military dialogue in a trilateral format."

There are no signs the fighting is abating, and the talks come against a backdrop of new long-range strikes by both Russia and Ukraine.

Roars and rhythms



Feline art: Artists from Keralam perform the Pulikali (tiger dance) as part of the inauguration of the Kerala Fest in Bhopal on Tuesday. Performers paint their bodies with detailed tiger motifs and take to the streets dancing to the rhythms of percussion instruments. PTI

SC flags crisis of vehicular emissions in Delhi-NCR

Krishnadas Rajagopal
NEW DELHI

On November 6, forty-eight hours before Deepavali, a Supreme Court Bench headed by Chief Justice of India Surya Kant said the people, and not the judiciary, must strike a blow against air pollution in the national capital. The court went beyond Deepavali to highlight a consistent danger that sustains and would worsen the toxic air: vehicular emissions.

FULL REPORT ON » PAGE 6

Will hold off on Iran strikes; blockade will continue, says Trump

Reuters
WASHINGTON/CAIRO/ABU DHABI

U.S. President Donald Trump has said he plans to hold off on new military strikes against Iran for the time being after appeals from countries in the region, including from Qatar's Prime Minister in White House talks.

"The United States of America is fully locked and loaded with the best equipment ever made, and we don't think there's going to be any reason to use it," Mr. Trump said on Monday. The President however, later said he plans to keep up a naval blockade in the Strait of Hormuz.



Donald Trump

'Fake news'

Iranian security council chief Mohsen Rezaei said on X the U.S. should "stop manufacturing fake news about imaginary talks" and that it was "time to surrender to the seven conditions Iran has repeatedly set out." Iran's proposal involves an end to the U.S. blockade and the lifting of some sanctions, with talks on its nuclear programme to follow. Foreign Ministry spokesperson Esmaeil Baghaei defended the plan as the most reasonable offer on the table.

The U.S. has repeatedly rejected Iran's plan, with Secretary of State Marco Rubio describing Tehran's conditions on Sunday as "outrageous and ridiculous and really not realistic."

Mr. Rubio said on Tuesday that he saw no need to attack Iran again as the U.S.'s squeezing of Iran's economy made further attacks unnecessary.

"The economic campaign (against Iran) is so devastating that right now there is no need for major combat operations," Mr. Rubio said after a G7 meeting in Paris. "That is what I told our allies here today."

Mr. Trump spoke on Monday after meeting with Qatari Prime Minister Sheikh Mohammed bin Abdulrahman Al-Thani, a key intermediary with Iran, as efforts to end the war ramped up following last week's U.S. midterm election.

He said he was acting "at the behest of countries that are their neighbours" and specifically cited Qatar, Saudi Arabia, the UAE, Bahrain, Kuwait, and others that prefer the U.S. not launch new attacks.

The End of Everything wins Booker for fiction

Associated Press
LONDON



Accolades galore: M. John Harrison poses with the trophy after winning the Booker Prize in London on Tuesday. AP

British writer M. John Harrison won the Booker Prize for fiction on Monday for *The End of Everything*, a satirical dystopian novel whose themes of "catastrophe and apocalypse" chime with our uneasy times. It is the first work of science fiction to take the prestigious $67,000 literary award, but 81-year-old Harrison said he doesn't want to be hemmed in by the sci-fi label.

He said Booker recognition after six decades as an author shows that the era of "genres as fences and boxes, pigeonholes, is over".

"I think this book shows, and the prize now shows, that it is very possible to write a book that mixes not just two genres, but three or four," Mr. Harrison said at a post-ceremony news conference.

Mr. Harrison beat five other finalists including previous winners Douglas Stuart and Marlon James, who had been the oddsmakers' favourites, and Pulitzer Prize laureate Elizabeth Strout.

Dystopian theme

The End of Everything is set on England's Channel coast in the near future, after an unspecified calamity has shattered society and brought an influx of enigmatic alien entities to Britain. It centres on a beachcomber who lives with his gun-toting aunt and discovers a puzzling, shape-shifting artifact on the shore.

Asked what he wanted to convey to readers, Mr. Harrison said: "It's a grim world, and it'll keep on being grim. And it's weird. But at the end of things there may be some kind of – I wouldn't say hope, or closure, but there might be some kind of relief."

Historian Mary Beard, who chaired the judging panel, said the book is "the politics of now seen through the lens of the future," and about a society "undergoing a catastrophe that they don't really understand."

Critics have praised the book's dark humour, though some have been confused by its elusive narrative.

INBRIEF



U.P. has to ensure undertrials granted bail are released: SC

The Supreme Court has said the onus rests on Uttar Pradesh to ensure that undertrial prisoners granted bail do not continue to languish in jail due to their inability to meet the conditions of their release such as furnishing bail bonds, providing cash security or offering local sureties. The order was passed by a Bench headed by Justice M.M. Sundresh on learning that of the 264 undertrial prisoners who were allowed bail in just 20 of the 75 districts in the State, only 158 could be released after satisfying the bail conditions imposed by trial courts. The remaining 106 had to continue behind bars for reasons such as their inability to provide financial security or a guarantor to back them.

Search operation called off at landslide-hit village in Odisha

The 11-day multi-agency search operation in a landslide-ravaged hilltop village in south Odisha was called off on Tuesday, even as six persons remained missing in the disaster triggered by Cyclone Arnab, which made landfall in Andhra Pradesh on October 28. According to officials, of the 13 people who went missing in Ghidipabali village on the border of Ganjam and Kandhamal districts, seven bodies, including those of three children, have been recovered. Kandhamal District Collector Vebhusan, who monitored the operation, obtained consent from the victims' families before calling off the search. PTI

In a setback for Congress, NCP's Rajesh Patil elected Gokul Dairy chairperson

Cong. MLC-led panel's Shashikant Chuyekar loses by 3 votes, says he's hopeful of getting justice in court; Fadnavis hits out at Rahul Gandhi for 'politicising' the election; Kolhapur back-stabbed: Raut

The Hindu Bureau
MUMBAI



NCP's Rajesh Patil paying tribute to Gokul Dairy founder Anandrao Patil-Chuyekar after winning the chairperson's post on Tuesday. PTI

Rajesh Patil of the Nationalist Congress Party (NCP) was on Tuesday elected the chairperson of the Kolhapur District Cooperative Milk Producers' Union, better known as Gokul Dairy. Mr. Patil bagged 16 votes – 12 of the Mahayuti panel and four of the State government-nominated directors. He defeated Shashikant Patil Chuyekar, the candidate fielded by Congress MLC Satej Patil-led panel, by three votes.

Power-sharing terms

Mahayuti sources told *The Hindu* that an "understanding" had been reached among the four Mahayuti constituents – the Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP), NCP, Shiv Sena and Jan Surajya Party – that the five-year tenure of the chairperson will be divided equally among them. "Each will get a 1.25-year term," said a Minister.

The result came as a setback to the Congress MLC a day after the Bombay High Court refused to intervene in the election process on his plea.

A panel backed by Mr. Satej had defeated the Mahayuti combine in the elections to the Gokul Dairy board on October 18, winning 13 of the 25 seats against the ruling alliance's 12. Mr. Satej moved the court against a recently promulgated ordinance giving the State government the power to appoint five directors to its board, four of them with voting rights, and fundamentally altering the balance of power in the cooperative.

Soon after the result, Shiv Sena (UBT) leader Sanjay Raut hit out at Chief Minister Devendra Fadnavis and Union Home Minister and senior BJP leader Amit Shah for "stabbing Kolhapur in the back".

Mr. Fadnavis accused Congress leader Rahul Gandhi of turning the elections for Gokul Dairy board into a political issue and asserted his faith in institutions and the rule of the Constitution.

"I support Gokul Dairy institution and the rule of law. I do not support any individual. This was a local issue which was made political by the Opposition leader. Even a gram panchayat has 6,000 voters. Gokul has 5,000 voters. And yet Rahul Gandhi talked about it," the CM told reporters at an informal interaction. He added, "We had earlier tried to find an amicable solution and appealed to Satej Patil and [State Minister and Mahayuti leader] Hasan Mushrif to come to a consensus. We would not have sent the nominated directors had they agreed."

Mr. Rajesh appealed to everyone to leave aside differences and to work together. Mr. Chuyekar said they had won "democratically" but the Mahayuti candidate had won due to "autocracy". "We trust the judiciary. We are fighting the battle in the court, and we know we will get justice there," he said.

Trinamool won't return to power in 100 years: Suvendu

Shiv Sahay Singh
KOLKATA



Suvendu Adhikari

West Bengal Chief Minister Suvendu Adhikari on Tuesday asserted that the Trinamool Congress has been politically wiped out in the State and will not return to power in the next 100 years.

"*Jora phool* and *ghas phool* (referring to the poll symbol of the Trinamool Congress, which has been frozen by the Election Commission of India), both have been uprooted. You will not see the TMC again, not even in the next 100 years," the Chief Minister said while addressing a gathering in Nandigram.

The event was held to mark the 19th anniversary of 'Operation Suryoday', when clashes broke out between supporters of the Trinamool-led Bhumi Uched Pratirodh Committee (BUPC) and the Communist Party of India (Marxist) on November 10, 2007.

After locals resisted an announcement of land acquisition in 2007, Nandigram witnessed months of violent clashes between CPI(M) supporters and the BUPC. Mr. Adhikari, who was a Trinamool leader at that time, was at the forefront of the agitation.

The Chief Minister asserted that the Trinamool had no role in the land movement. "The fight was between the people of Nandigram and the then Left government," he said, adding that people who were responsible for the violence have not been tried.

He said victims of the Nandigram violence did not get justice and added that Laxman Seth, a former CPI(M) MP, was jailed for 181 days. However, his trial was not concluded.

The Chief Minister said his government will reopen cases relating to the Nandigram violence. "I will reopen the crime files committed during the Left Front era in Nandigram and Chhoto Angaria. I will reopen the cases of those who went from the CPI(M) office with guns to create the bloody sunrise in Nandigram in 2007," he said.

BJD, Cong. accuse Majhi govt. of mishandling flood crisis, compounding people's woes

Satyasundar Barik
BHUBANESWAR



Relief work in progress in cyclone-affected districts of Odisha. FILE PHOTO

The Opposition Biju Janata Dal (BJD) and the Congress on Tuesday accused the Mohan Charan Majhi-led BJP government in Odisha of "mishandling disasters", particularly the floods in Ganjam district, alleging that its failure to manage the situation compounded people's suffering.

In a letter addressed to the Chief Minister, BJD chief and Leader of the Opposition Naveen Patnaik wrote, "A standard operating procedure in cyclone and flood management is to release adequate water from dams prior to rains. However, in the case of Ganjam, water from the dams was released by the Water Resources Department after the onset of heavy cyclonic rains. This compounded the floods and caused huge loss to life and property."

'Man-made crisis'

"People have complained that adequate warning was not given to them before the gates were opened. This gross negligence and man-made crisis raise serious issues of accountability. People are demanding strict action against those responsible for such serious lapses," he said.

'Poor management'

Odisha Pradesh Congress Committee president Bhakta Charan Das was equally scathing in his criticism of the BJP and the BJD. "The BJP government is as much responsible for the recent floods in Ganjam district due to faulty water management and its failure to open dam gates in time as the previous BJD government, which failed to take any lasting measures to prevent floods despite remaining in power for 24 years," Mr. Das said on Tuesday.

The Congress leader also questioned why relief distribution among the affected people was being carried out by BJP workers.

Cong. to begin public outreach drive today ahead of Punjab poll

The Hindu Bureau
CHANDIGARH



Congress leader Pargat Singh

In the run-up to the 2027 Assembly election, the Punjab Congress has announced that it will begin its public outreach campaign, '*Punjab Mangda Insaaf* (Punjab Demands Justice)', from Wednesday, seeking accountability from the Aam Aadmi Party (AAP) government over the "menace of drugs, deteriorating law and order, and corruption".

Punjab Pradesh Congress Committee president Pargat Singh said that through this initiative, the Congress will establish direct contact with the people of Punjab and understand their problems and expectations.

"The Congress will engage directly with stakeholders from the IT sector, agriculture, various industries and others. Senior party leaders will participate in different programmes to understand people's concerns across the State," he said during a press conference.

He said senior party leader and former Chief Minister Charanjit Singh Channi would also reach out to people through a 'cycle yatra'. Five to six senior Congress leaders will lead the campaign in different regions and take the party's message to every household, he added.

Bihar CM suspends 15 officers over failure to ensure timely disposal of public grievances

Amit Bhelari
PATNA



Bihar CM Samrat Choudhary during a State-level public grievance redressal event at the CM's Secretariat in Patna on Tuesday. ANI

Bihar Chief Minister Samrat Choudhary on Tuesday suspended 15 officers with immediate effect over "negligence and failure to ensure quality resolution" of applications under the Sahyog Programme. Departmental proceedings have been initiated against them for not processing applications in a timely manner.

The initiative is part of the State government's 'Ease of Living' drive under the Saat Nischay-3 programme aimed at delivering services at citizens' doorsteps. While launching the initiative on May 19, the CM announced that if a case is not resolved within 30 days of receiving the application, disciplinary action, including suspension, will be taken against the erring officers. Sahyog camps are organised on the first and third Tuesdays of every month to address complaints related to block offices, police stations, and revenue offices.

Of those suspended, nine were from the Revenue and Land Reforms Department, four from the Public Health Engineering Department, and one each from the Rural Development Department and the Urban Development Department. They include Block Development Officers and Circle Officers, assistant engineers, and junior engineers.

"All officers and personnel must extend their full cooperation in processing applications. It is our duty to address everyone's problems with sensitivity and promptness, and to ensure they receive justice," Mr. Choudhary said while holding the State-level Sahyog Programme.

Akhilesh's plan to visit Ram Temple bid to broaden PDA outreach

NEWS ANALYSIS

Mayank Kumar
LUCKNOW



SP chief Akhilesh Yadav has vowed to turn Ayodhya into 'the global capital of Sanatana pilgrimage', ahead of his Dec. 12 visit. FILE PHOTO

Last week's announcement by the Samajwadi Party (SP) that its president and former Uttar Pradesh Chief Minister Akhilesh Yadav will visit the Ram Temple in Ayodhya on December 12 has triggered sharp reactions from the Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP).

The ruling party has termed his visit, his first since the temple's consecration nearly three years ago and timed ahead of the 2027 Assembly election, "politically motivated".

On Tuesday, State BJP chief Pankaj Chaudhary hit out at Mr. Yadav, saying the senior Opposition leader should visit the temple on December 6, the anniversary of the Babri Masjid's demolition in 1992, instead of December 12 and apologise for the "killings of kar sevaks" under the SP dispensation. "Go to the temple on December 6. Hundreds of Ram devotees who were murdered... apologise for that sin," Mr. Chaudhary wrote on X.

Amid the uproar, the SP chief, who is looking to expand his 'PDA' (*Pichhda*, Dalit, *Alpsankhyak*) matrix to include Brahmins and fracture the BJP's core social base, has promised to turn Ayodhya into "the global capital of Sanatana pilgrimage". In a social media post on Monday night, Mr. Yadav promised to "restore Ayodhya's dignity and improve its local economy", which he claimed were hit by "donation theft".

Analysts see the proposed visit as an attempt by the SP chief to address key concerns of the priestly class while blunting the ruling party's rhetoric about the SP being "anti-Hindu".

Expanding voter base

"The SP is trying to broaden its PDA outreach beyond the Other Backward Classes (OBCs), Scheduled Castes (SCs) and Muslims. Akhilesh is aware that in the 2022 Assembly election, despite getting a sizeable vote share, he fell far short of forming the government," said Shashikant Pandey, a political scientist teaching at Babasaheb Bhimrao Ambedkar University in Lucknow.

He added, "In the 2024 Lok Sabha election, receiving sizeable votes from non-Yadav OBCs and SCs, along with Yadavs and Muslims, the SP-Congress alliance was in a tight contest with the BJP in U.P. Hence, through the Ram Temple outreach, the SP is trying not to leave any stone unturned in addressing castes across the State, including Brahmins."

Blunting BJP's rhetoric

Umakant Pandey, a political analyst based in Lucknow, said the visit could be viewed as an outreach to Brahmins, the traditional priestly class responsible for daily rituals at temples.

"The visit can also be seen as an attempt to blunt the BJP's anti-Hindu rhetoric against the Samajwadi Party, as the ruling party always attempts to target the late Mulayam Singh Yadav for ordering firing at *kar sevaks* in 1990, to protest against the Babri mosque," added Mr. Umakant.

Senior SP leader Sudhir Panwar said the BJP's "anxiety" over Mr. Yadav's proposed visit shows that the ruling party does not want to contest the Assembly election on the basis of its performance over the past decade.

"Akhilesh Yadav*ji* made it clear several times that religion and faith are personal issues, and he will visit [Lord] Ramlalla in Ayodhya after the completion of the Kedareshwar Temple dedicated to Lord Shiva and situated on the same latitude as the Kedarnath Dham. The BJP's anxiety and propaganda regarding his visit reinforce the belief that its leaders do not want to contest the U.P. election on their 10 years of achievements and governance," said Mr. Panwar.

Union Minister hits out at Karnataka govt. over E20 petrol claims

The Hindu Bureau
HUBBALLI

Union Minister Pralhad Joshi accused the Congress government in Karnataka of spreading misinformation on ethanol blending in petrol and attempting to undermine the Atmanirbhar Bharat initiative.

Addressing a press conference here on Monday, Mr. Joshi questioned the State government's claims that E20 petrol samples contained between 26% and 39% ethanol. The country did not produce enough ethanol to support such claims, he said, accusing Congress leaders of making irresponsible statements without adequate technical understanding.

Mr. Joshi said the State government had collected 63 fuel samples but released findings relating to only 14 samples. Of these, reports from six labs had been made public, with 11 samples allegedly showing ethanol content ranging from 21% to 39%.

Questioning the credibility of the exercise, the Union Minister said representatives of oil marketing companies and the Union government had not been invited.

He also questioned the accreditation of the Sri Ram Research Institute, which the State government had cited as having conducted the tests.

Published by Nirmala Lakshman at Kasturi Buildings, 859-860, Anna Salai, Chennai 600002 on behalf of THG PUBLISHING PVT.LTD. Editor: Suresh Nambath Chandrasekar (Responsible for selection of news under the PRP Act).

ISSN 0971 - 751X

INBRIEF



Telangana to host Bharat Summit on November 13, 14

The Telangana government will host the Bharat Summit 2026 in Hyderabad on November 13 and 14, bringing together political leaders, academics, policymakers, business representatives and civil society members from around 70 countries to discuss global challenges and international cooperation. While announcing this, chairman of the Congress party's Foreign Affairs Department Salman Khurshid said the deliberations would focus on democracy, social and economic justice, climate change, gender equality, foreign policy and the changing global order.

KPSC chairperson refuses to appear before Crime Branch

Kerala Public Service Commission chairperson M.R. Baiju declined to appear before the SIT of the Crime Branch for questioning in connection with alleged irregularities in examinations to senior posts in the State Planning Board again on Tuesday. He has reiterated his stance that he will appear for questioning only after the Kerala High Court delivers its order on the petition challenging the Crime Branch investigation.

Man arrested for allegedly assaulting woman on train

The police arrested one person for alleged sexual harassment and assault on a woman aboard a train on Tuesday. The accused, identified as Vijesh of Attingal, was arrested on the basis of a complaint by a woman who travelled on the Malabar Express in Keralam. The complainant boarded the train at Chirayinkeezhu. She also received treatment at a hospital as she lost consciousness after the accused punched her.

TVK MLA denies sending inappropriate messages to Collector

The Hindu Bureau
PUDUCHERRY/CHENNAI

C. Arul Vignesh, the TVK MLA representing Kallakurichi (Reserved) constituency, on Tuesday denied sending any inappropriate WhatsApp message to Kallakurichi Collector Padmaja, a charge that was levelled against him by some Opposition party leaders.

Speaking to reporters in Kallakurichi, the TVK MLA said the allegations made against him on social media were part of "dirty politics" being played by the Opposition. "Everyone came to know about the rumours spread through social media. I have always maintained high respect for government officers. False messages are being spread against me on social media," he said. He was responding to questions on DMK MP Kanimozhi's charge against him of sending obscene messages to the Collector and visiting her residence in an inebriated state. Dismissing the charge, the legislator said the Collector's bungalow was always guarded and under CCTV surveillance. "How could I enter such a place?" the MLA asked.

In a related development, party president and Chief Minister C. Joseph Vijay is expected to hold a key meeting with all MLAs on Wednesday. According to sources, the party has called a meeting at the party office in Panaiyur around 11 a.m.

Pinarayi alleges graft, seeks judicial probe into GNA power deal

He says Keralam govt. forced to withdraw pact after it was exposed; CM intervened to award a contract at high rate to private platform, he alleges

The Hindu Bureau
THIRUVANANTHAPURAM

Leader of the Opposition in the Keralam Assembly Pinarayi Vijayan has demanded a judicial inquiry headed by a High Court judge into the controversy surrounding the cancellation of the GNA power purchase deal.

He alleged that the government had attempted to impose a huge financial burden on consumers by creating an artificial power crisis in the State.

In a statement here, he claimed that the cancellation of the power purchase agreement was a vindication of the Opposition's stance that there was no power crisis in Keralam. The government was forced to withdraw from the power purchase agreement only because the Opposition and the media exposed alleged irregularities with supporting evidence, he said.

It may be recalled that Chief Minister V.D. Satheesan had earlier stated that the agreement with GNA, rather than power purchase from Himachal Pradesh, would save the State from an additional burden of some ₹2,200 crore.


Pinarayi Vijayan

KSEB report

However, the GNA power purchase deal, which was deemed necessary to pull the State from an impending power crisis, had fallen through following a report by the KSEB's commercial and tariff wing, which reportedly estimated that the GNA deal could cost the State an additional ₹903 crore.

A reassessment of the State's power requirement then led to the conclusion that additional power purchases were not necessary, raising questions about how the original assessment of the State's power requirements were made and the GNA's regulatory authorisation to undertake power trading activities, all of which had the Opposition train its guns on the Chief Minister now.

Mr. Vijayan alleged that it was "blatant corruption" that the Chief Minister personally intervened to award a contract at a high rate to a private intermediary platform which did not have power generation capacity of its own or was not even a power trader, bypassing all objections raised by the Kerala State Electricity Board (KSEB) and without following the tender process.

He said even the Electricity Minister had to learn about crucial decisions taken within his own department and about the cancellation of the purchase agreement through newspaper reports. This was a clear indication of the breakdown of the Cabinet's collective responsibility, he added.

Mr. Vijayan said the Chief Minister preferred to take decisions on his own, keeping the Electricity Minister, who is also the KPCC president, in the dark, which made the deal murkier.

CMO role

He also alleged that according to his information, it was the Chief Minister's Office which facilitated the purchase of 200 MW of electricity from a company named VEN Global in October at ₹11 per unit.

"This deal, allegedly conducted without a tender or approval from the Kerala Electricity Regulatory Commission, was also mysterious," he said. He said that the Chief Minister has to give clear answers to several serious questions.

File FIR in library book 'scam' case, court tells DVAC

The Hindu Bureau
MADURAI

Taking a serious view of the suspected scam in procurement of books for public libraries, the Madurai Bench of the Madras High Court on Tuesday directed the Directorate of Vigilance and Anti-Corruption (DVAC) to register an FIR and freeze the bank accounts of Agal Vilakku Publications, its proprietor Mohan, and others involved.


The Madurai Bench of the Madras HC has told the DVAC to freeze the bank accounts of Agal Vilakku Publications.

'Share officials' details'

Hearing a contempt petition filed in this regard, a Division Bench of Justices G.R. Swaminathan and M.D. Sumathi directed the Director of Public Libraries to make available the names and details of officials who were responsible for allegedly making fraudulent procurements of so-called books during the last two years and more, so that they could be impleaded as contemnors in the petition and dealt with appropriately. The government should immediately take disciplinary action, including the suspension of those involved.

The librarians concerned should forthwith take inventory of such suspect books and make them unavailable to the reading public, the court directed. The judges directed the authorities to apprise the court of the exact amount spent towards procurement of such books.

"Jean Dreze is a renowned economist. In Kalaignar Centenary Library in Madurai, one came across a book 'Democracy and People's Right in the Contemporary World' attributing authorship to Jean Dreze. The economist has been foxed and baffled. He has denounced the book as fake," the court said.

Even though the facts tumbled out of the closet last week, no FIR has been registered. The DVAC is said to be conducting a detailed enquiry. We wondered as to what prevented the DVAC from registering an FIR against unknown public servants, the court said.

Crores of rupees have gone out of the public exchequer. It was too obvious that a crime of this humongous proportion could not have taken place but for the active involvement of government servants. Not only the BNS provisions but also the provisions of the Prevention of Corruption Act stand attracted, the court said.

Questions raised over MLA-led co-op society

The Hindu Bureau
BELAGAVI

The Union Ministry of Co-operation has raised questions about the financial dealings of Vijayapura-based Siddhasiri Society, over audit, liquidity and an investment of ₹1,065 crore.

Basanagouda Patil Yatnal, MLA, is the president of the society. Mr. Yatnal, who was elected on a BJP ticket, has been expelled from the party.

The CRCS letter seeks detailed responses on at least 11 points. These questions are based on the information uploaded by the society on the CRCS portal.

Cyclone fury


Salvaging feed: A farmer drying rain-soaked fodder in a field in Kanaparthi, Andhra Pradesh, on Tuesday. Heavy rain triggered by Cyclone Murasu inundated large quantities of fodder, that had been stored for cattle, in coastal villages of Prakasam district. KOMMURI SRINIVAS

A.P. seeks investments in key sectors like AI, pharma

G.V.R. Subba Rao
VIJAYAWADA

The Andhra Pradesh Cabinet, chaired by Chief Minister N. Chandrababu Naidu on Tuesday, approved proposals aimed at attracting investments in AI, electronics, renewable energy, pharmaceuticals and manufacturing, besides taking decisions on infrastructure, education and administration.

Among the major investment proposals, the Cabinet approved an investment of ₹31,387 crore by AM Intelligence for a 512 MW green integrated AI data centre Amanaatm in Bheemunipatnam mandal of Visakhapatnam district. It also cleared a ₹4,000.20-crore Carbon Cosmo advanced materials manufacturing project at Naidupeta and land allotment to Dixon Technologies in Tirupati for an investment of ₹700 crore, sources said.


Big decisions: A.P. Chief Minister N. Chandrababu Naidu chairing the Cabinet meeting in Amaravati on Tuesday. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

The Cabinet approved allocation of 25 acres to Reliance Industries for a gigascale AI data centre at Bhogapuram. It cleared a proposal to establish a 30-acre industrial park exclusively for women entrepreneurs in NTR district.

UDF convener takes jibe at Keralam CM's 'style' of functioning

The Hindu Bureau
THIRUVANANTHAPURAM

United Democratic Front convener Adoor Prakash appears to have inadvertently found himself on the same page as the CPI(M), signalling that Chief Minister V.D. Satheesan's alleged tendency to concentrate power in his office has significantly jeopardised the collective responsibility of the Keralam Cabinet.

In a seemingly sarcastic remark, Mr. Prakash told presspersons here on Tuesday that "evidence of collective responsibility is trickling out into the open." Asked whether UDF Ministers were disgruntled that the CMO blindsided him on key governance matters, Mr. Prakash quipped: "You should ask the Cabinet Ministers."

When asked whether the UDF had convened to deliberate on key policy decisions,Mr. Prakash stated: "The convening of UDF meetings is the sole prerogative of the UDF chairperson (Mr. Satheesan)."

Mr. Prakash's statement came hours before CPI(M) State secretary M.V. Govindan said that Mr. Satheesan had significantly undermined the constitutional principle of the Council of Ministers' collective responsibility by concentrating power in a "shadowy coterie representing questionable private interests centred on the Chief Minister's Office (CMO).

Lensman Shaji Kumar passes away in Kochi

The Hindu Bureau
KOCHI

Noted cinematographer Shaji Kumar, who cranked the camera for several popular movies, including *Thudarum* and *Pulimurugan*, died in Kochi on Tuesday morning. He was 57.

He reportedly died after a cardiac failure.

Popular among filmmakers for his excellence in capturing mass action scenes, he had worked in nearly 50 movies in a career spanning over two decades. Condoling the death, Chief Minister V.D. Satheesan said, "Shaji was able to raise his creative prowess by infusing the technological advancements into his craft."

Soaring battle sequence in new *Ramayana* movie triggers global interest in Jatayu Center in Keralam

Navamy Sudhish
KOLLAM

The high-altitude battle where Jatayu attempts to wrest Sita from Ravana's soaring Pushpak Vimana serves as a visual centrepiece in director Nitesh Tiwari's *Ramayana: Part 1*.

The spectacular depiction of Ravana-Jatayu war in the film has sparked global interest, turning Chadayamangalam's Jatayu Earth's Center into a viral destination across social media and vlogs.

This unprecedented digital footprint is poised to trigger a major tourism surge and record footfalls at the site in Keralam during the upcoming season.

Spanning 200 feet across a giant rock hill in Chadayamangalam, the monumental structure crafted by Rajiv Anchal reigns as the world's largest bird sculpture.



Viral moment: The unprecedented digital footprint is poised to trigger a tourism surge at the site in Chadayamangalam. FILE PHOTO

Following the film's release, public figures from Chief Minister V.D. Satheesan to a multitude of prominent content creators have amplified the landmark's reach. Viral Instagram reels and YouTube memes comparing the film's visual effects with the real-life sculpture have captivated millions. National and international travel vloggers are broadcasting the site's cable car experience, panoramic sunset views, and impressive architecture, effectively transforming a regional cultural beacon into a global bucket-list attraction.

Unique phase

Despite the digital frenzy, management is navigating a unique transitional phase as bookings catch up with online interest.

"Nearly 90% of the destination's visitors traditionally originate from north India, with local footfall remaining relatively modest. While average daily attendance hovers around 2,500 and swells to 5,000 during peak seasons, immediate travel spikes following the release have been tempered by the necessity for long-term trip planning and high festival airfares. However, inquiry volumes have surged dramatically, signalling an impending wave of domestic and international arrivals as travel itineraries are finalised," says Deepak Sunil, CEO, earth center.

The management also admits they were caught unprepared for the sheer scale of exposure. Strategic planning sessions are currently under way to scale up proactive crowd management systems, address infrastructure gaps, and establish dedicated facilities to handle peak visitor flows seamlessly.

Beyond the immediate hilltop experience, the interest is creating substantial economic momentum for regional tourism ecosystem, boosting local hotels, resorts, transport providers, and tour guides.

J&K court releases 2 men after 6 years citing lack of proof

Peerzada Ashiq
SRINAGAR

A Jammu and Kashmir Court has released two youth from north Kashmir after six years, booked under provisions of Unlawful Activities Prevention Act (UAPA) and Arms Act, and held that "suspicion, however grave, cannot substitute proof".

"The prosecution must travel the entire distance from suspicion to legal proof. In the present case, that distance has not been traversed. The Court holds that the prosecution has not proved beyond reasonable doubt the essential ingredients of the offences charged against the accused persons.

The benefit of such doubt must necessarily go to the accused," held Feroz Ahmad Khan, Special Judge Designated under UAPA at Sopore, Baramulla.

The Court directed "immediate release" of the accused, Huzaif Firdous Bhat, a resident of Choora Sopore and Ajaz Ahmad Khan, a resident of Najibhat Kreeri. Both the accused were booked under Sections 7/25 of the Indian Arms Act and under Section 39 and under Section 23 of the UAPA from 2020.

"The seized property shall be dealt as per law after expiry of the appeal period," said the court.

The police had claimed that the duo were in a vehicle that was carrying two grenades and 100 live rounds of AK-47 packed in a polythene beneath the driver's seat. It said two Xerox copies of a letter pad with the writing of LeT on them were also recovered. "The recovered ammunition from the possession of the above said persons was illegally acquired and was being transported from Singhpora towards Baramulla town to carry out terrorist activities," the police has claimed.

However, the Court observed that the prosecution "must prove its case beyond reasonable doubt, the evidence on record, in the instant case falls short of this standard".

The Court observed that the foundation for the offences under Sections 18 and 23 of the UAPA and Section 7/25 of the Arms Act "is substantially weakened".

Van Dyke threatens to 'reveal shocking details' of jail time

Govt. declines comment on the U.S. national's online posts, says courts still hearing case; Van Dyke was arrested in March along with six Ukrainians, who illegally crossed from Myanmar to Mizoram

Suhasini Haidar
Devesh K. Pandey
NEW DELHI

The matter of United States citizen Mathew Aaron Van Dyke, who was arrested along with six Ukrainians for travelling from Myanmar to India without valid documents, is still in the courts, the External Affairs Ministry said on Tuesday.

Ministry spokesperson Randhir Jaiswal refused to comment on Mr. Van Dyke's claim that he had been arrested at Russia's behest, or his threat to "reveal shocking details" about his incarceration in Delhi's Tihar jail for six months.

Mr. Van Dyke, who was granted bail along with the others arrested with him, was allowed to leave the country last month. According to his mother Sharon Van Dyke, who campaigned for his release, U.S. Secretary of State Marco Rubio and U.S. Ambassador to India Sergio Gor had raised the issue with the Indian government.


To a question by *The Hindu*, Mathew Aaron Van Dyke said he would return to India in February 2027 to appear in court. GETTY IMAGES

"India threw me and several Ukrainians in prison for over six months. This was part of Russia's war against Ukraine," Mr. Van Dyke said in a post, without giving more details. He said he would "reveal shocking details about this story over the next few months in both posts and media interviews".

'Wait for court verdict'
Asked about Mr. Van Dyke's comments, Mr. Jaiswal said that the case was presently in the courts, adding that the government would "have to wait for what the courts have to say".

The government had come under criticism from Opposition parties for diluting the charges against Mr. Van Dyke and for allowing the National Investigation Agency (NIA) to say it had no objection to those accused of suspected mercenary activities leaving the country.

'No anti-Indian agenda'
In a series of responses to Indian social media users on Tuesday, Mr. Van Dyke said he was "innocent" of any "anti-Indian" agenda, accepting however that he had wrongly crossed over from Myanmar to Mizoram without valid permissions.

"Everyone going to non-junta areas in northwestern Myanmar goes through India. It happens every day," he claimed, calling for the case against him to be closed. Responding to a question on social media posed by *The Hindu*, Mr. Van Dyke said he would return to India in February 2027 to appear in court in person, although the court suggested that he could attend the hearing via video from the U.S.

The NIA had arrested Mr. Van Dyke and six Ukrainian nationals on March 13, 2026 at different Indian airports, in connection with an alleged cross-border conspiracy involving Myanmar-based ethnic armed groups.

The accused had entered India on tourist visas and travelled to the northeastern region without obtaining mandatory permits.

They crossed illegally from Mizoram into Myanmar, where they allegedly trained ethnic armed organisations in drone warfare, drone operations, and jamming technology.

Initially, the NIA also invoked provisions of the Unlawful Activities (Prevention) Act (UAPA). However, its chargesheet dated September 8 did not include terror charges.

NC plans advisory councils of MLAs to address dissent

Peerzada Ashiq
SRINAGAR


Farooq Abdullah

To address internal dissent in the party, ruling National Conference (NC) president Farooq Abdullah on Tuesday started reaching out to party legislators, offering them places in advisory councils that will work with Ministers in Jammu and Kashmir.

An NC leader, on the condition of anonymity, confirmed to *The Hindu* that Dr. Abdullah, who chaired a meeting of 17 dissenting legislators on November 6, has decided to constitute the councils. The NC has 42 legislators in the 90-member Assembly, while the Omar Abdullah government is also supported by four Independent MLAs in the Union Territory.

Bridging the divide
In letters to legislators, Dr. Abdullah described the proposed councils as "a bridge between the party and the government". Party sources said the mandate of these advisory councils will be to hold "regular meetings with Ministers on policy decisions and to take stock of the functioning of the departments".

The move seems to be aimed at addressing the concerns within the party that Chief Minister Omar Abdullah is surrounded by only a small group of individuals. It will also give the legislators, who could not be inducted into the Cabinet on October 27, a role in the government's decision-making process. The MLAs will get to choose the Ministers they intend to work with and cannot be members of more than two advisory councils, party sources said.

Another NC leader, who did not wish to disclose his name, said letters have not yet been sent to all legislators. "Not all MLAs have been informed about the composition of the councils. However, we expect it soon," the leader said.

Waiting to bloom


All set: Gardeners sow tulip bulbs at Srinagar's Tulip Garden on Tuesday. About 20 lakh bulbs are likely to be planted, spanning at least 70 varieties. The annual tulip festival, which begins in late March or early April, promises a spectacular display in spring next year. IMRAN NISSAR

Ladakh announces hill council polls, but civil society groups don't budge

Peerzada Ashiq
SRINAGAR

The Ladakh administration's move on Tuesday to announce hill council elections in the Union Territory, in addition to panchayat and municipal elections, failed to assuage the growing anxiety over the Centre's handling of the region, which has witnessed frequent protests over demands for Statehood and Sixth Schedule status.

The announcement came even as a shutdown was observed in Kargil to protest the timing of the elections, given the harsh winter conditions in the region.

"Elections to all eight Ladakh Autonomous Hill Development Councils (LAHDCs), covering 100 constituencies across Ladakh, will be held on December 4. Following the creation of eight districts from the erstwhile two districts of Kargil and Leh, the number of LAHDC constituencies has increased from 26 each in Leh and Kargil to 100 for whole Ladakh," Ladakh Chief Secretary Ashish Kundra said.


Ashish Kundra

He said November 17 was the last date for filing nominations, November 18 for scrutiny, and November 20 for the withdrawal of candidature. The entire election process is scheduled to be completed before December 8, he added.

"For the first time, 36 out of the 100 LAHDC seats have been reserved for women, marking a significant step towards strengthening women's representation in grassroots democratic institutions," Mr. Kundra said.

Putting all speculation to rest, Mr. Kundra clarified that the newly elected LAHDCs "would retain all powers vested in them under the existing law".

Against polls in winter
Mr. Kundra's announcement on the hill council elections coincided with a shutdown in Kargil to protest the delimitation and demand that panchayat and municipal elections be postponed to next year due to the approach of winter in the region.

"Protests and shutdowns are symbolic. People in a democracy have the right to express themselves through such protests," Mr. Kundra said.

The shutdown call was issued by the Kargil Democratic Alliance (KDA), a socio-politico-religious grouping which has been holding talks with the Union government on the demands for Statehood and Sixth Schedule status. However, this process hit a wall on October 22 after the Centre decided not to resume talks with the KDA and the Leh Apex Body for unknown reasons.

'Travel document is needed for Hasina's return to Bangladesh'

Kallol Bhattacherjee
NEW DELHI

A day after Acting Foreign Minister of Bangladesh Humayun Kabir stressed that Dhaka would not issue a passport to deposed Prime Minister Sheikh Hasina and insisted on getting her extradited from India under an "acceptable prisoner exchange", the External Affairs Ministry said on Tuesday that a "travel document" was needed for international travel.

"Extradition of former Prime Minister of Bangladesh Sheikh Hasina is a legal matter and it will be dealt with accordingly," said Ministry spokesperson Randhir Jaiswal in response to a question about Ms. Hasina's presence in India. He described the passport's requirement for extradition as a "technical issue" and said, "Obviously, for the travel of people, you need a travel document." Officials said Ms. Hasina can be extradited either on a Bangladeshi passport or an Emergency Certificate that would prove that she has Bangladeshi citizenship.

On Monday, Mr. Kabir cited the extradition treaty between India and Bangladesh, which was signed during the Hasina era in 2013, and said, "Bangladesh will not issue a passport to any terrorist; there is no provision for such an action. Bangladesh will seek the return of Sheikh Hasina through an acceptable prisoner exchange process."

An official dealing with the matter told *The Hindu* on Monday that a passport was required for extradition. The deposed Prime Minister has sought a new passport and a national identity document.

RELATED REPORT
» WORLD PAGE

Opposition builds over third mega dam project in Arunachal Pradesh

The Hindu Bureau
GUWAHATI

Communities living downstream of a hydropower project on the Dibang river have stepped up the heat on the governments of Assam and Arunachal Pradesh, with the latter already burning due to opposition to two other proposed mega dams.

The 2,880-megawatt Dibang Multipurpose Project on the Dibang river, one of three that form the Brahmaputra in adjoining Assam, is located in Arunachal Pradesh's Lower Dibang Valley. Developed by NHPC Limited at an estimated cost of ₹31,875 crore, the project had been hanging fire until a renewed push for its completion commenced in March 2024.


The under-construction 2,880 MW Dibang Multipurpose Project on Dibang river is located in Lower Dibang Valley district. FILE PHOTO

10-day deadline
An alliance representing downstream communities in Arunachal Pradesh and Assam on Monday set a 10-day deadline for the two State governments to fulfil their demands.

These include rehabilitation, flood protection and other safeguards linked to the mega dam, scheduled to be commissioned by February 2032.

Seeking immediate intervention by both governments, the Dibang Dam Assam-Arunachal Downstream Action Alliance wants Project Affected Family status for each family living downstream of the dam.

The alliance also demanded public hearings in Assam, specifically in Dibrugarh and Tinsukia districts, and construction of guide walls, embankments and protection walls from the dam site along the Dibang river.

It cited an August 2024 communication from the Arunachal Pradesh government to underline its demand for the downstream protection measures.

The alliance said the government should fulfil the demands before it commissions the project. "The demands are justified as Assam is exposed to downstream flooding and potential dam-break risks. Assam's territory is also used to transport construction materials and machinery to the project site," an alliance spokesperson said.

The alliance threatened to block the movement of construction material, tools, machinery and plant equipment to the Dibang dam site if its demands are ignored. At 278 metres, this dam is set to become India's tallest.

Meanwhile, people in the Mepsoro area of Arunachal Pradesh's Papum Pare district have opposed a proposal to establish an Indian Army field ammunition depot on 1,200 acres of land. A joint land survey, involving the district authorities, Army officials, police and local leaders, scheduled for Tuesday, triggered the protest.

Officials said efforts to resolve local issues were ongoing.

CISCE announces Class 10, 12 exam timetables for 2027

The Hindu Bureau
HYDERABAD

The Council for the Indian School Certificate Examinations (CISCE) on Tuesday announced the examination schedules for the ICSE (Class 10) and ISC (Class 12) examinations in 2027.

The ICSE examination will commence on February 15 and conclude on March 31 next year. The ISC examination will begin on February 9 and conclude on April 8.

The distribution of admission cards for examinations will begin in mid-December. Candidates can access the subject-wise timetables through the official CISCE website cisce.org.

According to CISCE, a total of 3,79,980 candidates (about 2.70 lakh for ICSE and over 1.1 lakh for ISC) are expected to appear across 2,835 examination centres in India and overseas.

A major operational change for the ICSE 2027 examinations concerns the examination timings. The reading time will begin at 10 a.m., followed by the writing examination at 10.15 a.m. Previously, these timings were 10.45 a.m. and 11 a.m., respectively. Candidates must be seated in their examination halls by 9.45 a.m.

The Class 10 examination will cover 76 subjects, while the Class 12 examination will cover 60 subjects.

CISCE Chief Executive and Secretary Joseph Emmanuel highlighted the importance of competency-oriented assessment in encouraging students to apply their knowledge, think critically, solve problems and respond creatively to real-world situations, in line with the National Education Policy (NEP) 2020.

Pranab Mukherjee hinted at desire to become PM: Sonia

In her memoir, she recalls 2010 conversation when Mukherjee suggested that perhaps 'it was time for a change at the top'; Congress leader also describes her strained relationship with Maneka

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

Former President Pranab Mukherjee had "shocked" Sonia Gandhi by hinting at his "long-held desire" to become Prime Minister during a conversation with her in 2010, suggesting that perhaps it was time for a "change at the top", the former Congress president has written in her memoir, *Belonging: A Journey of Love*.


A man leaves after purchasing Sonia Gandhi's newly released memoir, at a bookstore in New Delhi on Tuesday. SHASHI SHEKHAR KASHYAP

The book, published by HarperCollins, was made available in bookstores on Tuesday, but the official launch is likely to take place on November 16.

Mukherjee, then a senior member of the Manmohan Singh Cabinet, had developed serious differences with the then Finance Minister P. Chidambaram. He would at times stay back for conversations with Ms. Gandhi after meetings of the Congress Strategy Group, which was set up to discuss parliamentary business.

"On one occasion, in 2010, I think after expressing his frustration, he shocked me with the suggestion that perhaps it was time for a change at the top, which I understood as a hint of his long-held desire to become Prime Minister," she wrote. "I gently changed the subject, and though he may have been disappointed, he never made me feel he held it against me," she added.

The late Pranab Mukherjee, who had served in Indira Gandhi's Cabinet in the 1970s, was part of a core group that met weekly with Singh to coordinate the functioning of the government and the party. Other members included Arjun Singh, A.K. Antony, and Ahmed Patel.

Ms. Gandhi says she often called on Mukherjee after he became President in 2012, largely to converse with the "erudite and knowledgeable politician that he always remained".

'Not a crime'

Hitting back at Ms. Gandhi, Sharmistha Mukherjee, the late President's daughter, said it was not a crime to be ambitious.

"What's there to be shocked about?" she asked in a post on X in response to Ms. Gandhi's remarks.

"Is it a crime to be ambitious, especially when that 'ambition' was supported by decades of experience in politics and governance, hard work and a brilliant mind? Once, when asked by me whether he wanted to become PM, he very candidly answered that 'any politician worth his salt has this ambition'," she wrote.

On relations with Modi

On her relationship with Prime Minister Narendra Modi, Ms. Gandhi said she had "practically no real contact" with him. At semi-official gatherings, they exchange formal *namastes*, but "he tends to look away, avoiding eye contact", she wrote.

The memoir also recounted her strained relationship with Maneka Gandhi, describing how domestic differences following her marriage to Sanjay Gandhi gradually spilled into politics.

She recalled Indira Gandhi's displeasure with Ms. Maneka's political activities, particularly after the Emergency, and the eventual break in ties, with the younger daughter-in-law walking out of the family home.

Sonia's book tries to give her family clean chit over 1984 Sikh massacre: BJP

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

The Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) on Tuesday alleged that former Congress president Sonia Gandhi, through her book, attempted to shield former Prime Minister Rajiv Gandhi and the Congress leadership from responsibility for the 1984 anti-Sikh massacre.

At a press briefing, senior BJP leader Harvinder Singh Phoolka said: "In the book that Sonia Gandhi has published, she has tried to give her family a clean chit over the massacre of Sikhs." He alleged that the book's account, which was in "complete contradiction of the official record", wrongly attributed the delay in deploying the Army to General A.S. Vaidya.

"First, as per the Misra Commission's report, 6,100 soldiers were available in Delhi on the night of October 31 and the morning of November 1, but they were not deployed in time. The Commission also wrote that if 5,000 of these soldiers had been made to march through Delhi's streets on the morning of November 1, at least 2,000 Sikhs could have been saved. Both the Misra Commission and the Nanavati Commission made the same point in their reports," he said.

> Rajiv Gandhi was the country's Prime Minister at the time. If he was not directly responsible himself, what action did he take against those who failed to mobilise the Army present in Delhi on the morning of November 1? Instead, at his first public rally, Rajiv Gandhi said: 'When a big tree falls, the earth shakes a little.' In this way, he tried to justify the entire massacre
> **HARVINDER SINGH PHOOLKA**
> BJP leader



"The Misra Commission says that even if Rajiv Gandhi had alerted General Vaidya, the Army Chief's job is only to keep the Army ready, while administrative officials are responsible for calling in the Army and deploying it in the field. The administrative machinery neither called in the Army in time nor deployed it," said Mr. Phoolka.

"Rajiv Gandhi was the country's Prime Minister at the time. If he was not directly responsible himself, what action did he take against those who failed to mobilise the Army present in Delhi on the morning of November 1? Instead, at his first public rally, Rajiv Gandhi said: 'When a big tree falls, the earth shakes a little.' In this way, he tried to justify the entire massacre," he said.

Union Minister Giriraj Singh accused Ms. Gandhi of being selective in expressing grief over incidents such as Babri and Batla House, but not over Godhra and Pahalgam incidents. He said her book should have addressed what he described as former Prime Minister Jawaharlal Nehru's mistakes, including Tibet and Articles 370 and 35A.

MCC curbs will apply to retired officials engaged by States: ECI

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

Retired government officials who are re-employed or re-engaged by State or Union Territory governments should not take part in any election campaign or lend their names to any political party or individuals during the poll season, just as in the case of government servants, the Election Commission of India directed on Tuesday.

After complaints of misuse of official positions, the ECI has decided to extend the rules applicable for government officials during the period when the Model Code of Conduct is in force to those who are working with the government after retirement as well, a senior ECI official said.

The directives came in a letter addressed to the Chief Secretaries and CEOs of poll-bound Goa, Manipur, Punjab, Uttar Pradesh, and Uttarakhand.

Strict compliance

The letter said that such retired officials who have been re-engaged must maintain political neutrality and refrain from participating in election campaigns.

The ECI cautioned that any act in violation of these directions would be viewed seriously.

It added that they must not summon any election-related officer of a constituency or district where elections have been announced for official discussions or meetings. They are also barred from holding video conferences or meetings with such officers.

Asking the States to ensure strict compliance, the Election Commission cautioned that any act or omission in violation of these directions would be viewed seriously.

The poll body also reiterated that Model Code of Conduct provisions apply to organisations, committees, corporations, and commissions funded wholly or partly by the government.

A year on, Delhi blast victims' kin struggle with grief, hardships

Shrimansi Kaushik
NEW DELHI

A year after 38-year-old Amar Kataria was killed in a car explosion near Red Fort, his wife, Kriti, has barely stepped out of their house. "It has been a year, and she refuses to step out of her house. It feels as though the incident happened only yesterday," her father, Sudesh Sethi, said.

Thirteen civilians were killed and 20 injured in the terror incident near Red Fort on November 10, 2025. The bomber was also killed in the explosion.

Ashok Randhawa, a survivor of the 2005 serial bomb blasts in Delhi and president of the South Asian Forum for People Against Terror, organised a tribute meeting near the Lal Quila metro station on Tuesday to mark the first anniversary of the blast. The meeting was attended by family members of the deceased, many of whom could not hold back tears while offering tributes.

The families continue to struggle with grief, health problems and financial difficulties.


A relative of a terror victim at a memorial event on Tuesday to mark the first anniversary of the incident. ANI

Raising child alone

Kataria, who ran a pharmaceutical shop, was returning to his home in Sriniwaspuri when he was killed in the blast. Since his death, Ms. Kriti has devoted herself to raising their three-year-old son. "She has been mustering the strength to bring him up. He is too young to understand what is happening. Apart from him, she takes no interest in any aspect of her life," Mr. Sethi said.

Bhawani Shankar Sharma, 34, who suffered a head injury in the blast, continues to experience intermittent memory problems, his elder brother, Vishnu Sharma, said. Mr. Bhawani was dropping off a customer in his taxi when the explosion occurred. "We remember the blast like a nightmare. My brother had an extremely happy life before the blast. He lost his car, his only source of livelihood, and has faced financial difficulties in addition to his injuries," Mr. Vishnu said.

"We like to believe he was saved by his daughter, who was only a year old at the time. The hope of seeing her again kept him alive," added his brother.

The family of 18-year-old Nouman Ansari from Shamli, Uttar Pradesh, who was killed in the blast, is also facing financial difficulties and health-related problems. "Nouman was the only earning member of his family and wanted to get his brother treated at a private hospital. He was a cheerful young man and a source of happiness for everyone, especially his ageing parents," his uncle, Mehbub Ansari, said.

Families seek support

The Delhi government had announced an *ex gratia* of ₹10 lakh each to the families of those killed, ₹5 lakh to those rendered permanently disabled, ₹2 lakh to the seriously injured and ₹20,000 to those with minor injuries.

However, some families said the assistance did not address issues such as loss of livelihood and medical expenses.

Mr. Sethi said his family had sought job assistance for his daughter but got no favourable response.

Mr. Vishnu said the government should have considered the financial and emotional impact of the blast on the affected families. "We received ₹2 lakh despite suffering much greater losses, including the loss of his car, treatment expenses and income lost during his recovery. The government did not acknowledge these losses," he said.

Mr. Randhawa said several injured victims had received only ₹20,000 despite spending days in hospital.

BJP BLAs' Form 7 applications in Mustafabad focused on three localities

Suruchi Kumari
NEW DELHI

The 796 applications seeking deletion of names from the voter list filed by 20 Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP)-appointed Booth Level Agents (BLAs) in Delhi's Mustafabad were mostly concentrated on just 25 of the Assembly constituency's 294 polling booths, *The Hindu* has found.

The Form 7 applications were all against Muslim electors, and the 25 booths, spread across three neighbourhoods, appeared to have been selected because they had a sizeable Muslim population with claims of few deletions when the draft electoral roll was published as part of the Special Intensive Revision (SIR) of electoral rolls, an analysis of records and interviews with local BJP workers showed. The three neighbourhoods are Nehru Vihar, Dayalpur, and Chandu Nagar.

The BJP has said that it has not directed the filing of Form 7 applications. Delhi BJP spokesperson Praveen Shankar Kapoor said, "Our BLAs have not filed any Form 7s in Mustafabad. If there are objections being filled, then BLOs (Booth Level Officers) and the Election Commission will act on them as per rules. The party has not directed for any forms to be filled."

However, the 796 Form 7s named BJP BLAs as the 'objector'.

The Hindu has also found that at least 87 of the electors against whom Form 7s were filed are living at their registered addresses in these neighbourhoods.

These 796 applications make up over 76% of the total 1,044 deletion applications received in the constituency till November 4 as part of the ongoing claims and objections phase of the SIR, an analysis of publicly available data shows.

Large Muslim presence

This means that three out of every four Form 7 applications filed in Mustafabad are against those in the three neighbourhoods that have a large Muslim presence. According to residents, the neighbourhoods were also among the worst-affected during the 2020 Delhi riots.

The 25 polling booths in these neighbourhoods did not appear to be randomly selected.

The Hindu found sets of the voter lists of these polling booths, with the names of Muslim electors marked on them, in possession of BJP workers in the area. Multiple BJP leaders and party workers said that "Muslim-majority" booths in the constituency had seen fewer deletions in the draft roll prepared during the SIR. They claimed that there were a larger number of absent or shifted electors under these booths than the number of deletions.

This was why, they said, Form 7 applications were filed against names in these booths as per the lists available with them.


Asharaf and Heena Parvin, whose names were deleted from the electoral rolls. SURUCHI KUMARI

'Here for two decades'

In the narrow lanes of C-block's 25 Futa Road in the Nehru Vihar neighbourhood, two-storey, unnumbered houses stand close together, blocking much of the sunlight. Open drains run outside their doors, a familiar sight across Mustafabad.

Nehru Vihar's Samima Begum, in her 60s, was furious to learn that deletion requests had been filed against her, her husband Mohd. Saleem Ansari, their three sons, and daughter Rukhsar, despite the family having lived there for over two decades. She was quick to show their identity documents.

"We have already received a notice. The BLO said it was because I had more than six children. She collected the documents and left. We bought this house before 2000, but what proof do they have that we have shifted?" Ms. Begum asked.

She said she did not know Robin Singh Dhama, the BJP-appointed BLA named as the "objector" in the Form 7 application against them.

The Hindu spoke to 10 other voters facing objections from Mr. Dhama, who is named as an objector in 57 cases.

On November 5, *The Hindu* reported that 16 of 17 BJP BLAs who responded to queries denied that they had filed Form 7s, even though their names were listed as objectors. Mr. Dhama, however, said he had been filing the applications himself for a month, alleging that the electors against whom he was objecting had shifted from the area. "If these people lived in the area and I knew of them, I wouldn't have sought their deletions," he said. Three other BJP BLAs could not be reached.

The applications cited "absent/permanently shifted" or "death" as reasons for seeking deletion. One such application was against Fatama, an elderly voter in Chandu Nagar's B-block, who was listed as dead despite still living at her registered address.

According to BJP leaders who spoke on condition of anonymity, after Delhi's draft electoral rolls were published on August 31, party workers compared the number of names deleted from them due to being in the Absent, Shifted, Dead and Duplicate (ASDD) category in polling booths that had a majority of Muslim electors and booths with a majority of Hindu electors. They also prepared separate lists, which were seen by *The Hindu*, with names of Muslim electors.

After this, they purportedly focused on 25 polling booths in the Nehru Vihar, Dayalpur, and Chandu Nagar neighbourhoods, where BJP BLAs began filling form 7s from the first week of October. "We have also found that booths where Muslim BLOs worked in a Muslim neighbourhood, the deletions were lower even though people don't live there," a BJP leader claimed.

The Election Commission of India (ECI)'s booth-wise data from the constituency, however, does not corroborate this claim. Officials maintain that religious identity has no role in the verification process.

Data analysed by *The Hindu* showed that while the highest deletion in one booth in Mustafabad was 538, the average was 274 per booth. In most of the 25 booths where as many as 60 deletion applications were filed by BJP BLAs against Muslim electors, draft-stage deletions were closer to the average.

Selective identification

However, data also showed how booths that workers claimed were Muslim-majority were selectively identified from among booths with lower deletions. In polling part no. 108, 585 electors are on the draft roll, while 50 have been removed and placed under ASDD. Here, 35 Form 7s have been filed – all by BJP BLA Deshraj against Muslim names marked on the list.

Similarly, in polling part 129, 508 electors remained on the draft roll after 106 names had been removed. Another 37 deletion applications were filed against Muslim electors, with BJP BLA Chandra Shekhar Nainwal named as the objector.

Field election officers found 36 of 37 applications filed by Mr. Nainwal to be false/fabricated on November 6 and sought a first information report (FIR) against him.

These two booths are among the top five booths with the fewest draft-stage deletions. However, no objections have been filed by BJP BLAs in the three other booths that were in the top five, despite draft-stage deletions of fewer than 100. These booths, BJP workers said, had a predominantly Hindu population.

'Some discrepancy'

The Hindu contacted the local councillor of Nehru Vihar, which has seen the highest Form 7 applications, with 496. BJP councillor Arun Bhati said he is not authorised to speak about deletion applications. However, he said, "In Mustafabad, there are some booths where over 300-500 votes were deleted, which are coincidentally Hindu voters, and then there are booths where fewer than 100 have been deleted."

"Both cannot be genuine. Either some discrepancy has happened in booths with higher deletions or on those with lower," he said.

His brother, BJP BLA Ajay Singh Bhati, is also named as the objector in 37 applications but has denied to *The Hindu* that he filed them. None of the Form 7s recieved in Mustafabad accompanied a mandatory BLA undertaking.

INBRIEF



39 Naga ancestral remains return home from Oxford

After more than a century in England, 39 Naga ancestral remains are returning home to India. On Monday, the University of Oxford transferred the custodianship of 39 Naga artefacts, including human remains, to a team comprising members of the Forum for Naga Reconciliation (FNR) and the Naga Tribe Hoho (NTH), the apex body of all Naga communities. It marked a milestone in the Naga community's efforts to reclaim ancestral remains held in museums abroad. In a statement, the FNR and NTH said the university's Pitt Rivers Museum hosted the handover ceremony. Established in 1884, the museum received the artefacts from various collectors.

Union Minister inaugurates Yamuna cruise service in Delhi

Union Minister for Ports, Shipping and Waterways Sarbananda Sonowal on Tuesday inaugurated a cruise service on the Yamuna at Sonia Vihar. The project is being developed to promote river-based tourism along the Yamuna stretch upstream of the Wazirabad barrage. The cruise will operate between Sonia Vihar and Jagatpur, covering a stretch of around 4-5 km, with each ride lasting approximately 40 minutes. The ticket has been priced at ₹500 per person. Chief Minister Rekha Gupta said the cruise would bring people closer to the Yamuna, giving Delhi residents an opportunity to enjoy experiences for which they often travel to other cities. PTI

Sanjit 'Bunker' Roy, social activist and Barefoot College founder, passes away

He founded Barefoot College in Tilonia, Rajasthan as 'a place for cop-outs, drop-outs and wash-outs' and not for certificate chasers; it enabled villagers to identify their own challenges, develop local solutions and manage resources independently

Sobhana K. Nair
NEW DELHI

One of the foundational figures of modern civil society in India and the founder of Barefoot College, Sanjit "Bunker" Roy, died at his home in Tilonia in Ajmer district of Rajasthan on Tuesday morning. He was 81.

"He went peacefully as he wanted to in his own home in Tilonia, surrounded by Aruna [prominent activist Aruna Roy, his wife] and some of the countless people who loved and cared for him deeply, passionately," the Social Work and Research Centre (SWRC), also known as Barefoot College, said in a statement.

Roy's activism began at a time when social work was often viewed with disdain. Ms. Roy recalls in her memoir, *The Personal is Political*, that when she was serving as a sub-divisional magistrate (SDM) in Delhi, a chief metropolitan magistrate reacted dismissively after learning that Bunker Roy was a social worker. "*Kahin naukri nahin mili hogi* (He must not have landed a job anywhere)," her colleague quipped. The magistrate's attitude changed dramatically, however, when he later discovered that Bunker Roy was the national squash champion, and promptly sought Roy's help in securing membership to the prestigious Delhi Gymkhana Club.



Sanjit Roy founded the Social Work and Research Centre in Tilonia in 1972. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

Early education

Roy studied at the Doon School alongside Rajiv Gandhi and attended St. Stephen's College, Delhi, between 1962 and 1967. He won the national squash championship in 1965 and represented India in three world championships. In a TED Talk posted online 15 years ago, he described his elite education as "snobbish" and "expensive", saying it had "almost destroyed" him.

He was 21 when famine struck Bihar in 1966. Consecutive monsoons had failed. The horrors of extreme poverty, with people dying of starvation, changed the course of his life, and he decided to spurn the "whole world laid out for him".

In 1972, Roy founded the Social Work and Research Centre in Tilonia. In the same TED Talk, he described it as "a place for cop-outs, drop-outs and wash-outs" and not for certificate chasers. It had a bottom-up approach, enabling the villagers to "identify their own challenges, develop local solutions and manage their resources independently", working towards community-based water management and renewable energy initiatives.

Paying tribute, Congress MP Shashi Tharoor said Roy's vision of training rural grandmothers as "Barefoot Solar Engineers" had helped bring electricity to thousands of off-grid homes across India and other developing countries, while advancing community empowerment and environmental stewardship.

'Institution builder'

Congress general secretary (communication) Jairam Ramesh said Roy believed that civil society "must cooperate where they can, collaborate where they should, and confront where they must". Roy, he said, worked closely with the Rajiv Gandhi government in areas such as drinking water, immunisation, and adult literacy.

Sam Pitroda, who served as an adviser to Rajiv Gandhi and worked with Roy, remembered him as an "institution-builder" whose impact extended far beyond the communities he served. Former Rajasthan Chief Minister Ashok Gehlot said Roy made significant contributions to rural self-reliance, education, and development.

CPI general secretary D. Raja described Roy as a pioneering social activist and educationist whose work would continue to inspire those committed to equality, dignity, and social justice.

Writer Amitav Ghosh noted that despite opportunities to pursue a distinguished career in diplomacy or bureaucracy, Roy chose instead to dedicate his life to addressing rural poverty, calling him "a true hero".

Among the many honours Roy received were the Padma Shri in 1986, the Jamnalal Bajaj Award for Application of Science and Technology for Rural Development in 1985, the Tyler Prize for Environmental Achievement in 2004, the Skoll Award for Social Entrepreneurship in 2005, and the Blue Planet Prize in 2011. In 2010, *TIME* magazine named him among the world's 100 most influential people.

Kharge seeks account of anti-pollution measures

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

Congress president Mallikarjun Kharge on Tuesday accused the Bharatiya Janata Party government of taking piecemeal measures to tackle air pollution, asking why India was becoming a "Vishwaguru" in pollution.

In a post on X, Mr. Kharge asked whether Prime Minister Narendra Modi would give the country an account of the measures taken to ensure clean air. "Piecemeal measures, PR stunts, broken promises and blame games have become the hallmark of the BJP," the Congress president said, adding that clean air was a fundamental right and not a privilege.

He alleged that PM2.5 readings had disappeared from 36 of Delhi's 59 monitoring stations. He also cited unspent environmental compensation collections of ₹1,154 crore.

Referring to the Supreme Court's direction to Delhi, Haryana, Uttar Pradesh, and Rajasthan to submit responses and proposed measures, Mr. Kharge asked: "Will Modi*ji* dare to give the nation '*Hawa Ka Hisaab*' (An Account of the Air)?"

Supreme Court goes beyond Deepavali AQI, flags vehicular emissions polluting Delhi air

Krishnadas Rajagopal
NEW DELHI

Forty-eight hours before Deepavali, amidst the rising crescendo of crackers heralding the festivities, a Supreme Court Bench headed by Chief Justice of India Surya Kant said the people, and not the judiciary, must strike a blow against air pollution in the national capital.

The court went beyond Deepavali to highlight a consistent danger that sustains and would worsen the toxic air: vehicular emissions. On November 6, the court detected a sharp increase in issues attributable to vehicular emissions.

"It must be borne in mind that Delhi and the National Capital Region (NCR), by virtue of their geographical and economic interconnectedness, bear the cumulative burden of vehicular traffic originating not merely within their own boundaries but also from the neighbouring States of Uttar Pradesh, Haryana and Rajasthan," the Supreme Court reminded the authorities in its latest order. The issue warranted urgent intervention, the court said, directing the Municipal Corporation of Delhi (MCD), the Delhi government, the Delhi Police (Traffic department), as well as the neighbouring States of Haryana, Rajasthan, and Uttar Pradesh to file their responses on what they have done to regulate the plying of commercial and non-commercial vehicles. The court wanted to know about measures to regulate traffic originating from outside the national capital.



The Court said it had detected sharp increase in vehicular emissions. FILE PHOTO

These include steps taken to identify, monitor, and regulate vehicles that do not conform to prescribed emission standards, and measures to prevent the entry and operation of overage, end-of-life, or non-compliant vehicles.

The Bench has specifically sought information on the measures undertaken against violations, including the number of vehicles inspected, challaned, denied entry, and the coordination mechanisms between the authorities of Delhi and the neighbouring States for regulating inter-State vehicular movement.

No compliance

Incidentally, two separate orders passed several months ago, on January 21 and February 23 this year, had contained detailed long-term and short-term measures recommended by the Commission for Air Quality Management (CAQM) to mitigate air pollution, especially caused by vehicular emissions, in Delhi.

The January 21 order had listed various CAQM recommendations, including phasing out polluting vehicles from Delhi-NCR, fortifying the pollution-under-check regime, augmentation of rail transport and metro models, revised electric vehicle policy, among others.

Subsequently, on February 23, the court directed the Delhi government and three Ministries - Environment, Petroleum and Natural Gas, and Commerce and Industry - to submit a joint proposal for shifting coal-based industries out of Delhi NCR. This direction was based on a CAQM recommendation to ban the establishment of new coal-based thermal power plants within a 300 km radius from Delhi.

However, on November 6, the court was told by its *amici curiae* that the compliance of its orders was "yet to be properly reported to this court".

The court has listed four *suo moto* cases - vehicular emissions, enhancement of green cover, construction activities/power plants, waste management/stubble-burning /firecrackers - from November 23 to November 30.

Cong. MP objects to panel omitting pollution hearing

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

Questioning decision of the Parliamentary Standing Committee on Home Affairs to drop "air pollution" in the Delhi-National Capital Region (NCR) from the agenda for its November 17 meeting, senior Congress leader and panel member Ajay Maken, in a letter to panel chairperson and Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) leader Radha Mohan Das Agarwal, urged him to reconsider bringing it back on the agenda, describing the situation as a "public health emergency."

The committee had earlier scheduled a hearing with the Union Ministry of Home Affairs and other concerned agencies on the subject. An agenda circulated on November 5 included a discussion on 'Air pollution in Delhi-NCR: Enforcement of regulatory measures, effective implementation of GRAP measures, protection of vulnerable sections and coordination among law enforcement and government agencies".



Ajay Maken

However, the revised agenda omitted the subject. "I wish to register my objection to the omission of the air pollution hearing from the revised agenda for 17 November 2026. Given the urgency of the health risks, I request that this change be reconsidered and the hearing restored to that date," Mr. Maken said in a letter to Mr. Agarwal.

Noting that no alternative date had been announced, Mr. Maken sought either restoration of the November 17 hearing or communication of the earliest possible date for discussion along with an explanation for the change.

Describing Delhi's air pollution as a "public health emergency", Mr. Maken said the protection of vulnerable groups, enforcement of regulations and coordination among agencies required immediate attention.

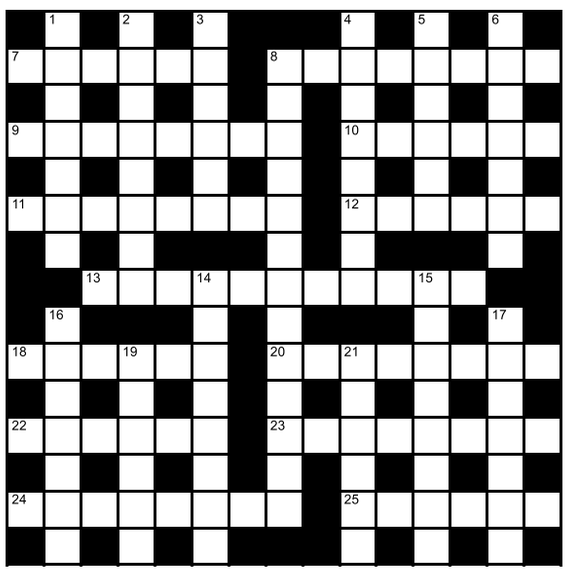
"A prompt hearing would allow the Committee to examine what the responsible agencies are doing, whether implementation is falling short and what immediate corrective action is needed," he said.

TH CROSSWORD + 14945

(set by Pixie Dust)

Solve this puzzle online and access more puzzles at *https://thehindu.com/crosswords*

SCAN TO PLAY



Across

7 Bit of torn slip leads to panic (6)
8 Does this rigged deal upset Poet Judo's Pub? (3-2,3)
9 One key? (8)
10 Section of Noble Antony's outhouse (4-2)
11 Say 25 sheets describing early signs of a General Manager's predicament (8)
12 A teen behind every other Roman Epic? (6)
13 Option via net? (11)
18 Fabricate greasepaint (4-2)
20 Witness (butler) led by old bishop (8)
22 Evil spirit consuming Rector's soulmate (6)
23 Ancient history about the sly one in flood (8)
24 Begad! Get rye sandwiches! Works? (8)
25 Some nickname citizens circulating for thief (6)

Down

1 Control extremely ambiguous American spyware (7)
2 Reckless champ like Pacino, for one (8)
3 Urbanite mysteriously losing a Tesla in country (6)
4 Dependable celebrity going around breaking law, finally caught (8)
5 Hurt after model left of capital of Portugal in anxiety (6)
6 Buffalo! I cannot accommodate (7)
8 Openly tag repeatedly to find Friend Geller's interest? (13)
14 Hurry! Shortly reject horrible diet (8)
15 Truly curt, I fire criminal checker (8)
16 The Reverend asks for Pixie in part of golf course? (7)
17 Female adores fancy headwear (7)
19 Come out and enjoy moonlit evenings, romantic, gloriously enchanting to begin with (6)
21 Bet that is small change (6)

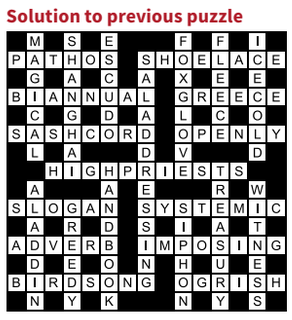
SUDOKU

3	7		6		9			
	1			2		7		6
	5							
5	8							
7	6		2		4		1	8
							5	2
							7	
1		3		7			8	
			8		1		2	4

DIFFICULTY RATING: ★★☆☆☆

No.SS7057 Distribution: www.knightfeatures.com

Solution to previous puzzle



Solution to yesterday's Sudoku

3	8	2	5	1	4	9	7	6
4	6	9	7	3	8	1	2	5
1	5	7	2	9	6	4	8	3
5	4	3	8	2	1	7	6	9
6	9	8	3	7	5	2	1	4
2	7	1	6	4	9	5	3	8
8	1	6	9	5	7	3	4	2
9	2	4	1	8	3	6	5	7
7	3	5	4	6	2	8	9	1

FAITH

Devotion, Dikshitar's way

Music as a way to reach God is one of the easiest bhakti marga in the Kali Yuga. Muthuswami Dikshitar, one of the musical trinities, was a guiding light in this field. Fully blessed by the Supreme Being, he composed numerous kritis in Tamil, Telugu and Sanskrit, which continue to show the way forward for devotees, said P. Swaminathan.

A deeply devout man, well-versed in Vedas, his music is a lasting legacy for the faithful. Born in the Tamil month of Panguni, his parents considered his birth a miracle: childless for long, they proceeded to Vaitheeswaran temple for a month and performed various penances. Soon, they were blessed with a male child. His father Ramaswami was his musical guru and the son distinguished himself, composing music that continues to inspire generations. He visited various shrines, travelling as far as Badrinath and Kathmandu, composing songs on many deities. At Kasi, where he stayed for five years as a sishya of Chidambara Yogi, he experienced a defining moment when he was gifted a veena by Goddess Saraswati when he was meditating upon Her in the Ganga.

Dikshitar composed numerous kritis on Lord Muruga during his sojourn in Tiruttani. Legend has it that one day Lord Subrahmanya appeared before him in the garb of an old man, fed him a piece of sugar candy and merged with the idol. The songs he rendered on this occasion are the Guruguha kritis, which are rendered with soulful devotion by all. On Deepavali day, he asked his sishyas to sing his kriti, *Meenakshi Memudam Dehi* and when the refrain of the kritis, *Meenalochani Pasamosani* came, he lifted his arms high and his life merged with flame of Ambal's lamp.

India's efforts to clean its air need not slow its economic growth

The best interventions must address air pollution while supporting development priorities; cleaner industrial processes may reduce emissions while improving efficiency; clean cooking can reduce household smoke; better waste management can reduce open burning, improving urban services

Ajay Singh Nagpure

India ranked 176 out of 177 countries in the 2026 Environmental Performance Index (EPI), published by the Yale and Columbia Universities in the U.S. The index assesses 47 indicators across 12 categories. Of them, India performed the worst on air quality, where it ranked 175, yet it did considerably better on air pollution, ranking 88.

This contrast is illustrative because only the latter matters for India's health burden. The State of Global Air 2025 report estimated that more than 20 lakh deaths in India in 2023 could be attributed to air pollution.

Many activities that contribute to air pollution are also central to India's development. Industries create jobs, power plants supply electricity, transport moves people and goods, and agriculture supports livelihoods and feeds the population. So cutting emissions from these sources involves choices about technology, investment, affordability, and the ability to implement change.

The Chinese example

China offers a useful example on whether mitigation can keep pace as economic activity expands. It began strengthening industrial emissions controls while its economy was still expanding rapidly. Between 2005 and 2010, sulphur dioxide (SO_2) emissions dropped 14% as a result. China later introduced a broader clean-air campaign that yielded substantial drops in fine-particle pollution. Research in Beijing attributed most of the PM2.5 decline during 2013-2017 to emission controls rather than weather alone.

China's institutions, economy, and energy systems differ from India's, so India cannot simply copy its approach. Nevertheless, its experience shows that bringing pollution under control does not have to wait until economic growth is complete.

For India, the first question is therefore whether pollution can reduce fast enough while the economy continues to grow. India is already adding renewable power, electric vehicles, cleaner cooking fuels, and pollution-control programmes.

Judging progress

The International Energy Agency expects India's electricity demand to grow by 6.4% a year on average through 2030, with industry accounting for roughly a third of the additional demand. Solar power is expected to meet around half of that growth, while coal supplies about one-quarter.

While these projections do not say whether air pollution will rise or fall, they indicate why the number of cleaner technologies introduced is not enough to judge progress. What matters is whether their combined effect is large enough to offset the growth in emissive activities.

The difficulty of balancing these objectives is visible in the thermal power sector. In July 2025, the Union government revised SO_2 requirements for coal- and lignite-fired power plants. Mandatory standards were retained for one category of plants, another category became subject to case-by-case assessments, and a third received exemptions subject to conditions.

The government cited issues such as technical feasibility, electricity prices, water and auxiliary-power requirements, limestone consumption, and associated carbon emissions. These are legitimate considerations in infrastructure policy. However, SO_2 also contributes to secondary, fine-particle pollution. This example captures a larger dilemma: the immediate cost of pollution control is visible and concentrated while some of its health and environmental benefits are distributed across a wider population and may emerge over time. Yet both need to inform decision-making.

India has nevertheless made progress. Official figures show that 108 of the 130 cities covered by the National Clean Air Programme (NCAP) recorded lower annual PM10 concentrations in 2025-26 than in 2017-18. This does not necessarily indicate a similar trend in PM2.5 – nor can an observed decline in pollution after a policy is introduced be attributed to that policy alone. Some confounding factors include the weather and changes in emission profiles.

Between 2019-20 and 2025-26, the government provided ₹16,423.55 crore in performance-linked funds to 130 NCAP cities for air pollution control. National programmes such as the Pradhan Mantri Ujjwala Yojana, PM E-DRIVE, PM Surya Ghar, and solid-waste management initiatives can also provide benefits by nudging household fuel use, transport emissions, electricity generation, and waste-burning. But cleaner air is not their only objective, and the programmes cover different periods and financial arrangements. Put another way, what matters for policymakers should be the connection between investment and outcome: how much pollution a measure is expected to prevent, how much exposure it actually reduces, what it costs and whether the benefits justify those resources. Without that connection, a larger budget may indicate greater activity without necessarily showing that mitigation is keeping pace with the problem.

Practical questions

That brings the discussion to the question: how does scientific knowledge become action in real economic and social conditions? For instance, giving a household access to LPG creates an opportunity to reduce smoke from traditional fuels, but access does not guarantee sustained use. Fuel prices, household income, and the availability of alternatives influence what families actually use. And just being aware of the health risk alone does not remove these constraints.

So the strongest interventions may be those that address air pollution while also supporting other development priorities. Cleaner industrial processes may reduce emissions while improving energy efficiency. Reliable clean cooking can reduce household smoke while improving convenience and health. Better waste management can reduce open burning while improving urban services. Such co-benefits should be demonstrated explicitly.

That approach also changes how success should be judged. Instead of asking only whether a new programme has been launched, a technology installed or funds allocated, each new intervention needs to be examined with practical questions: what pollution is it expected to reduce, what will it cost, who can realistically implement it, what other benefits or burdens will it create, and did exposure actually decline afterwards?

Such an approach will not eliminate the political and economic choices involved in pollution control but it will make those choices more transparent and give decision-makers a clearer basis for expanding measures that work.

(Ajay Singh Nagpure is an environmental systems scientist at the World Emissions Network. an3173@princeton.edu)



A man sweeps near the India Gate in New Delhi that was shrouded in thick smog on Monday. Many activities that contribute to air pollution are also key to India's development and cutting emissions from these sources involves choices about affordability and the ability to implement change. SHASHI SHEKHAR KASHYAP

THE GIST

For India, the first question is whether pollution can reduce fast enough while the economy continues to grow

India is already adding renewable power, electric vehicles, cleaner cooking fuels, and pollution-control programmes

China, which began strengthening industrial emissions controls while its economy was still expanding rapidly, offers a useful example on whether mitigation can keep pace as economic activity expands

China's institutions, economy, and energy systems differ from India's, so India cannot simply copy its approach

Nevertheless, China's experience shows that bringing pollution under control does not have to wait until economic growth is complete

BIG SHOT



A participant dressed as a dinosaur performs as part of the 'Fossil Of The Day award' on the sidelines of the COP31 in Antalya, Turkiye, on Monday. Organised by the Climate Action Network International during the annual climate conference to call out countries they say fall short on climate action, the demonstration identified New Zealand as this year's 'fossil' for 'dismantling its own climate commitments' by gutting methane targets and changing the law to 'shield corporations from climate litigation'. AFP

WHAT IS IT?

Meson to muons: ultra-rare decay

Vasudevan Mukunth

You know that matter is made of protons, neutrons, and electrons. Technically, matter is made of many, many more subatomic particles — so many that physicists refer to them all as the particle zoo.

Now, scientists at the European nuclear research facility CERN have reported evidence of an extremely rare phenomenon in which one kind of subatomic particle transforms into two other particles. The finding could offer a more precise way to test our understanding of how our universe and its particles work.

The team studied a particle called the B^0 meson. Mesons survive for a small fraction of a second before transforming into other particles. The B^0 meson can decay into two particles called muons, one positively charged and the other negatively charged. Muons are like electrons but around 200-times heavier.

But this transformation is rare. The Standard Model is the theory that describes how these particles behave and three of the forces that act between them. And it predicts only around 1 in 10 billion B^0 mesons will decay into two muons. The researchers found evidence for the decay at the CERN supercollider at a significance of 3.2 sigma — meaning the signal is unlikely to be arbitrary data mimicking the real thing.



Scientists have found evidence of an unusual subatomic phenomenon in data collected by the Large Hadron Collider (shown). AFP

The finding matters because scientists know the Standard Model is incomplete: it can't explain phenomena like dark matter. So scientists have proposed extensions to the theory that invoke new particles, and these could change the frequency of rare particle decays.

In this instance, the team found the B^0 meson decay's properties matched the Model's predictions, which could rule out certain extensions.

For feedback and suggestions for 'Science', please write to **science@thehindu.co.in** with the subject 'Daily page'

Caste and class

Exclusion of creamy layer is essential, but must be done consistently

If public resources are to dismantle both caste hierarchy and class inequality, OBC reservation should resist the notion that caste disadvantage makes economic differences among OBC families irrelevant. The 'creamy layer' rules are responsible for identifying those OBC members who have advanced sufficiently to no longer require affirmative action. However, the government has implemented them inconsistently. The Supreme Court in March corrected one inconsistency, that the government cannot hold the salary alone of an OBC candidate's parent as evidence of social advancement. In *Indra Sawhney* (1992), the Court upheld the government's 27% reservation for OBC candidates in central government services if it also excluded economically advanced sections, i.e., the creamy layer, among OBCs. Following the equivalence requirement issued in 1993, the Department of Personnel & Training (DoPT) issued a "clarification" in 2004 that the government used, from around 2015, to deny dozens of OBC candidates who had cleared the Civil Services Examination their benefits because their parents' salaries exceeded the official threshold due to pay revisions that did not always reflect changes in occupational status. The Cabinet also approved equivalence guidelines in 2017 but a parliamentary committee criticised it over a number of issues.

In *Rohith Nathan* (2026), the Court rightly rejected the government's use of the 2004 "clarification" to arbitrarily exclude OBC candidates based on their parents' salaries alone. However, the government stalled service allocations following the 2025 examination and appealed that retrospectively applying the ruling would create administrative chaos. On November 6, the Court conceded that it had not asked the government to reopen completed selections, as it could set workers against one another while leaving government misapplication unaddressed. A proactive policy is essential now as the government must create supernumerary posts for legitimate claimants and apply the 1993 rules to pending allocations without vouchsafing these remedies for only those who can afford litigation. Access to public employment continues to be grossly unequal: per the 2024-25 DoPT Annual Report, OBC representation in central government employment was 26.3% but declined steadily towards higher positions. As the Justice G. Rohini Commission also indicated, the benefits of reservation are distributed unevenly among OBC communities. However, the report, submitted in 2023, is still not in the public domain. The coming Census includes caste enumeration but policymakers also need data on each caste's education, occupations, assets, and landholdings. Defending redistribution among caste groups while ignoring major inequalities within them, and constraining OBC reservation assuming relatively more high-income families capture the benefits without first establishing the extent and the causes are equally difficult to justify.

Without rationale

India's federal structure could have benefited from the Kurian Committee

By abruptly disbanding the Justice Kurian Joseph Committee on Union-State Relations and handing over its task to the Tamil Nadu State Law Commission, the C. Joseph Vijay government appears to have succumbed to the political impulse to reverse earlier decisions rather than being guided by any compelling rationale or necessity. This gains credence from the very grounds cited. The committee executed its mandate with scholarly rigour, seen in Part I of its report that was submitted to the then M.K. Stalin government in February. Citing the Committee's basic character of being a "non-statutory body" is unconvincing, particularly when the Law Commission itself is established only through "executive order". There is also no public evidence of State Law Commissions having examined or addressed issues concerning Union-State relations. The mandate "to suggest ways and means for the inter-State relations and Centre-State relations", constitutes only one part of the broader terms of reference of the State Law Commission, reconstituted in August. Given the commission's wider responsibilities, successive State governments had constituted high-level committees to examine conflicts involving Concurrent List subjects and recommend specific remedies. It is through such recommendations that Tamil Nadu enacted certain pieces of legislation to overcome limitations imposed by central laws, including the provision of horizontal reservation in professional course admissions for disadvantaged students. Therefore, the State's other argument of "similarity or overlap" in the "nature and scope of the functions" entrusted to the Committee and the Commission, does not withstand close scrutiny.

In September, Leader of the Opposition Udhayanidhi Stalin, had flagged an attempt to "paralyse" the Committee's functioning. A fair assessment of the Committee's Part I Report reveals the breadth and depth of its dispassionate examination of issues, including State autonomy, delimitation, and the office of the Governor. Parties, barring the BJP, had largely welcomed the report. Interestingly, its contents are not even remotely at odds with the broad public ideological positioning of Mr. Vijay's Tamilaga Vettri Kazhagam on State rights. Besides, Prof. M. Naganathan, the Committee's only member with an overt political association, had already resigned. The government would do well to rethink and allow it to complete its work. This would strengthen the political endeavour towards evolving a more balanced federal governance structure, facilitating harmonious Centre-State relations.

Transparency is essential to institutional credibility



Clement Arockiasamy

A public and social policy analyst, a British Chevening Scholar, and a Master's graduate in Development Studies from the Institute of Development Studies (IDS), University of Sussex, U.K.. He is the author of the book, 'Dalit Christians – Exclusion by State, Church and Society'

The proposed amendments to the Foreign Contribution (Regulation) Act, 2010, have triggered strong reactions from civil society organisations, Opposition parties and Christian institutions. The concerns are not without substance. What it seeks is tighter regulation of foreign-funded organisations, including provisions concerning assets created or acquired through foreign contributions. The Government maintains that the objective is greater transparency, accountability and prevention of misuse of foreign funds, while critics fear possible restrictions on legitimate civil society activity and minority institutions being disproportionately affected. With the Bill referred to a Joint Parliamentary Committee for further scrutiny, there is an opportunity for a reasoned debate.

Foreign contribution cannot become a pretext for suppressing legitimate charitable, educational, health care or social-service activity. At the same time, the receipt and utilisation of foreign funds cannot be placed beyond scrutiny.

Transparency is not an assault on minority rights; it is a condition of public trust. This raises a question for minority institutions opposing the proposed amendments: are they prepared to put their own houses in order? This is not about greater state interference, but about voluntary transparency and accountability to those they claim to serve.

Consider the Catholic Church in Tamil Nadu. The dioceses have established numerous social-service structures and societies dedicated to the poor, vulnerable and marginalised. Their contribution to social development is substantial, but how many ordinary faithful have meaningful access to even the basic financial picture of these institutions? How many can readily see annual income-and-expenditure statements, audited accounts, major sources of funding and the broad utilisation of resources? The more fundamental question is this: should institutions that speak forcefully about accountability to the state, not voluntarily practise an equally high, if not higher, standard of accountability to their faithful, beneficiaries and stakeholders?

Institutional power, financial accountability

The question becomes even more pertinent when one considers the enormous educational and social footprint of popular religious orders such as the Society of Jesus and the Salesians of Don Bosco, as well as the many premier institutions run by dioceses, including medical colleges, and numerous congregations of women religious. Their contribution to education and public life is undeniable. Yet, influence carries responsibility.

> Minority institutions opposing the FCRA amendments must demonstrate transparency and accountability themselves

Across the educational sector, there have long been allegations and public concerns regarding admission-related donations, capitation and other payments in institutions offering sought-after courses. Such allegations must not be treated as established facts against particular institutions without evidence. But where institutions receive substantial fees, donations, grants or other contributions, a legitimate question remains, a demand for transparency is not an accusation of wrongdoing. On the contrary, the most effective answer to allegations of financial mismanagement or diversion is transparent, independently audited and accessible accounting.

The same principle should apply to religious and social-service organisations. If institutions appeal to the faithful and the public for donations in the name of the poor, education, health care and social development, their stakeholders should reasonably expect a clear picture of how those resources are utilised. Transparency need not mean exposing confidential individual transactions or compromising institutional autonomy. It can simply mean publishing audited annual accounts, broad income-and-expenditure statements, major funding sources and the purposes for which resources are deployed. Such voluntary disclosure would strengthen the moral authority of organisations that are now demanding greater accountability from the state.

The unfinished question of Dalit Christians

The issue becomes particularly compelling in the context of the Church's advocacy for Dalit Christians. The Catholic Bishops' Conference of India (CBCI) has raised concerns over the FCRA Amendment Bill with the Union Government. Its memorandum has also raised the continuing denial of Scheduled Caste (SC) status to Christians of SC origin and sought an early resolution of the matter pending before the Supreme Court. The CBCI has undertaken initiatives on the issue and its policy documents have acknowledged the persistence of caste discrimination within Indian society and, importantly, within the Church.

For decades, Dalit Christians have awaited a resolution of their claim to SC status. The Church possesses considerable institutional influence, extensive organisational reach and substantial financial resources. Has that influence and capacity been mobilised with the same sustained intensity for the constitutional rights of its most marginalised faithful as it is now being mobilised when the regulatory framework governing its institutions is threatened?

There is an inherent irony here. The Church rightly argues that caste does not disappear when a Dalit becomes a Christian. If that is so, and if caste-based exclusion continues beyond conversion, then the constitutional marginalisation of Dalit Christians should occupy a central place in the Church's public advocacy. It is difficult, therefore, to avoid asking what institutional accountability means if the voices of the most disadvantaged members of the institution remain comparatively weak.

Accountable autonomy

The answer should lie neither in unchecked state power nor in unchecked institutional autonomy, but in accountable autonomy. Minority institutions have made an invaluable contribution to India's educational, healthcare and social landscape, and their right to function freely must be protected.

But institutional freedom carries institutional responsibility. The credibility of their opposition to excessive FCRA regulation will ultimately depend not merely on what they demand from the government, but on what they are willing to disclose to the people who sustain and depend upon their institutions.

Perhaps the most important test of an institution is not how loudly it protests when its own autonomy is threatened, but how openly it answers questions from the poor, the faithful, the beneficiaries, parents, students and the communities it serves. Minority rights and institutional accountability are not opposing principles; they are complementary ones. The state must not use transparency as a pretext to weaken legitimate minority institutions. But minority institutions, in turn, cannot demand transparency from the state while treating transparency to their own stakeholders as optional.

Before asking the state to put its house in order, minority institutions should be willing to open their own doors and demonstrate that their houses are in order.

Strategic autonomy must guide India's Starlink policy



Ashwin Prasad Rao

Staff Research Analyst with the Advanced Military Technologies and Outer Space Programme at the Takshashila Institution

Recently, Elon Musk unleashed a volley of social media posts, accusing Indian "oligarchs" of impeding Starlink's entry into India. The government rejected the accusation and clarified that all satellite operators must go through the same regulatory process. The ensuing public debate has centred on Mr. Musk, Mukesh Ambani, protectionism and telecom competition. All this obscures important questions of how much control India will have over Starlink once it operates here.

In its current form, Starlink is unlikely to replace fibre and mobile networks because they have almost opposite strengths. Fibre and mobile networks take time and money to set up, but can serve many people in one area. Starlink reaches remote places without towers or cables but is limited by how many users it can serve in one region. While fibre and mobile networks are optimised for density, Starlink is optimised for reach. Starlink has previously stopped taking new residential customers in areas where it ran out of capacity.

Starlink is well-suited for isolated settlements, border regions, ships, and disaster affected areas. Governments and the military require reliable connectivity in such areas. Starlink can connect soldiers, drones, sensors and command centres without traditional connectivity. Therefore, its operation in India goes beyond retail customer choices and has national security implications.

The risks for India

India has very limited control over Starlink. The network could remain usable in an area where Indian authorities have ordered it switched off. Conversely, it could be disabled when India needs it most. India can licence and penalise Starlink, but SpaceX retains direct control over its satellites, software and terminal access.

The government has recognised these risks and imposed stringent security requirements on satellite Internet providers. Operators must route Indian user traffic through ground stations, called gateways, located in India. They cannot use inter-satellite links to bypass Indian gateways or route Indian traffic through gateways abroad. They must also provide monitoring facilities to Indian security agencies and restrict connectivity when authorities issue security-related orders.

> India must balance Starlink's benefits with national security and strategic autonomy

Starlink has indicated willingness to comply. It announced Indian gateway sites and introduced India-specific data controls.

Some of these conditions are difficult to enforce independently. Indian authorities can inspect domestic gateways, but verifying whether Indian traffic has been routed through foreign gateways or mirrored abroad through satellite links is more difficult and depends partly on information provided by SpaceX.

There is also a trade-off. Starlink's advantage is that its satellites can pass traffic between themselves when a ground station is unavailable. If Indian gateways fail, however, these restrictions prevent Starlink from rerouting Indian traffic through gateways abroad, reducing one source of redundancy.

Global experiences

Iran's experience is also a valuable demonstration of the enforcement problem. Since 2023, Iran has complained to the International Telecommunication Union (ITU) about Starlink terminals illegally operating on its soil without authorisation. The ITU's Radio Regulations Board has repeatedly called for Starlink transmissions to be stopped over Iran.

At its October 2026 meeting, the Board again noted that unauthorised Starlink transmissions in Iran were continuing. It reiterated its earlier decisions calling for the transmissions to stop and its conclusion that it lacked the authority to suspend the relevant satellite frequency assignments.

Ukraine provides an interesting contrast. In February, Ukrainian authorities worked with SpaceX to identify authorised Starlink terminals and block those used by Russian forces. In Ukraine, SpaceX acted on the government's requests. In Iran, years of appeals have failed to achieve the same result.

Conversely, on October 14, Ukrainian officials reported that Starshield, the military service built on Starlink technology, began losing connectivity on terminals travelling faster than about 160 km/h, disrupting drone missions and frontline logistics. Zelenskyy said the restrictions applied in Ukraine but not in EU countries. Ukraine said normal service was restored on October 24. The reason and responsibility remain contested. Reuters reported, citing officials, that an order came from within the White House, although Trump denied personally issuing it. The disruption coincided with Washington's pressure on Ukraine to stop striking Russian oil refineries.

For an ordinary user, losing Internet access can be an inconvenience. For armed forces, emergency responders and other essential services, it can have far more serious consequences.

SpaceX also depends on American regulatory approvals and government contracts, giving Washington considerable leverage over the company. If American interests diverge from India's during a crisis, this dependence could become a strategic vulnerability.

India needs alternatives

Keeping Starlink out entirely would sacrifice valuable connectivity, particularly in remote regions. India should retain its strict licensing conditions while improving its ability to check compliance. Starlink continues to evolve and regulation will have new challenges to contend with.

Therefore, a more effective way to reduce the dependency risks is to have alternatives to Starlink. Military and other essential users should maintain backup connections and tested procedures for switching between them. Using more than one satellite internet provider, from countries under different jurisdictions, would reduce dependence on the decisions of a single entity. Expanding ground coverage would reduce the number of communities for whom Starlink will be the only practical option. A parliamentary review found that only 30% of gram panchayats had a functional BharatNet connection as of February 2026.

But fibre and mobile towers cannot cover every ocean, mountain region or remote frontier. India will also need satellite alternatives of its own. India should encourage more domestic constellations and use their demand for satellites and rockets to build Indian industry. Industrial capacity and satellite Internet capacity go hand-in-hand.

India needs enough alternatives to keep essential communications working even when Starlink is unwilling or unable to.

LETTERS TO THE EDITOR

Firecrackers, half measures

It is not surprising that the air quality in New Delhi deteriorated significantly after Deepavali celebrations. The Supreme Court's advice to limit celebrations to specific hours and use only 'green crackers' appears to have found few takers. The government was hesitant to impose a ban, fearing public resentment. Unless the authorities demonstrate a strong resolve to tackle this recurring menace through an integrated approach, most Indian cities cannot be expected to become pollution free.

D.V.G. Sankara Rao,
Vizianagaram, Andhra Pradesh

After granting permission and licences to manufacture firecrackers, what is the point of imposing restrictions on bursting them? Indian rules and regulations often reflect double standards. The government should formulate a clear and consistent policy (Editorial, November 10).

K.V. Sundaravelu,
Bengaluru

It is clear that the debate over whether to restrict or ban fireworks is far from settled. We must accept that, as a society, we are unable to self-regulate. We have tried "green crackers" — whatever that means — but the experiment has not worked. The signals from the judiciary are also that it does not favour an outright ban on firecrackers. I fail to understand why. Why not impose a complete ban for one year and assess the results?

Devika Verma,
Gangol Panditwari, Uttarakhand

Library scam

The discovery that a ₹300-crore state-of-the-art public repository has been stocked with suspected AI-generated garbage, phantom authors, factual errors, and falsified ISBNs is a severe blow to Tamil Nadu's intellectual legacy. Worse, standard books were allegedly billed at hyper-inflated prices, pointing to an institutional scam of public funds. A massive library infrastructure must never become a playground for corporate graft or partisan mudslinging. The ruling TVK must form an independent committee of reputed academics to purge the shelves of substandard books, audit the financial ledgers, and hold corrupt publishers accountable.

R. Sivakumar,
Chennai

Letters emailed to letters@thehindu.co.in must carry the postal address.

World Wars and India's sacrifice



Priyanjali Malik

writes on politics and international relations. In the interest of full disclosure, the three Bhagat brothers were her father's cousins

On the 11th hour of the 11th day of the 11th month, most Commonwealth and other allied nations fall silent for two minutes to honour the fallen of the two World Wars. Not so much in India: wreaths are laid in cantonments, but for most, this is just another day. India has an uneasy relationship with Remembrance Day. However, the idea that the World Wars were something that happened to someone else, somewhere else, could not be further from the truth.

Indian ambivalence over the two World Wars belies its enormous contribution to fighting fascism. Undivided (British) India sent 1.5 million men to fight in World War I, 74,000 of whom never returned home. For WWII, India produced the largest volunteer army of 2.5 million soldiers, with 87,00–89,000 making the ultimate sacrifice. The princely states also sent significant troops. Whereas the Indians who fought in the Great War were mostly sent to distant lands, in WWII, about 7,00,000 of them were defending Indian territory. The war came home to India when Japan invaded the country in March 1944.

The argument that the Indian soldiers who fought under British command were defending freedom for the British while their country's aspirations for the same freedoms remained suppressed under colonial rule is legitimate. Yet independent India's ambivalence over WWII goes deeper. The fact that the adversary in this case included an Asian power claiming Asian solidarity has sometimes obscured the fact that imperial Japan was pushing into India in a brutal campaign of expansion.

And then there is the complicated history of the Indian National Army (INA), led by Subhas Chandra Bose.

The INA, which was initially formed under Captain Mohan Singh in 1942, comprised mainly 40,000 Indian Prisoners of War (PoWs) who were captured and tortured by Japan when Singapore fell in 1942. It was re-formed by Bose when he joined the Japanese in Singapore in July 1943. Bose expanded the INA, or the Azad Hind Fauj, setting up a government in exile. However, nothing about the provisional government of free India could disguise the fact that several of the men who joined the INA did so under duress. Bose teaming up with the Japanese pitted Indian against Indian.

> We owe it to ourselves to be honest with our past, just as we owe it to our armed forces to honour the sacrifices of those who went before them

Fallen heroes

On April 6, 1942, the war came to India with Japanese aircraft bombing ships entering the Vizag harbour and the port. In December of that year, Kolkata was bombed over four days, with the Japanese targeting the city's infrastructure. The following December, Japanese aircraft bombed Kolkata's Kidderpore dock, killing hundreds of people and causing significant damage. From January 1942, the Japanese Army swept through Southeast Asia, overrunning Myanmar and occupying Burma. The fighting in the Burma campaign, which involved over 7,00,000 Indians, was brutal, not just because of Japanese tactics, but also because of the forbidding jungle terrain. In March 1944, the Japanese Army attempted a land invasion of India from Myanmar. The Japanese calculated that once they entered, the locals could be encouraged to revolt against the British. However, Indians decided against trading British rule for the Japanese.

India was defended by Indians in some of the fiercest fighting of the war. Indians (from undivided India) made up 87% of the multinational fighting force troops in the Burma campaign. A disciplined fighting force was forged in the heat of this combat; and this force has defended India after 1947.

The first Indian to be awarded a Victoria Cross (VC) in WWII was Second-Lt (later Lt-Gen) Premindra Singh Bhagat for 'most conspicuous gallantry on active service' clearing mines in East Africa in early 1942. In late 1943, his eldest brother, Nripendra Bhagat, was taken PoW by the Japanese while fighting in Burma. While in prison, he was made to broadcast a propaganda piece, almost certainly under torture. He was handed over to the INA, rising quite high in the 'provisional government'. He subsequently disagreed with Bose and was imprisoned by him in Burma. He escaped and was captured by Indian soldiers, who handed him over to the middle brother, Brijindra, who was with the 5th Indian Division in Burma. All three were fierce nationalists and one story cannot be told without mentioning the others.

Soon after Prem Bhagat was awarded the VC, he went to see Mahatma Gandhi. How could he work for his country, he asked Gandhi. The answer was simple: stay in the army. India would need men like him to defend her. History is complicated. However, we owe it to ourselves to be honest with our past, just as we owe it to our armed forces to honour the sacrifices of those who went before them.

Keralam at 70: holding a mirror to India



Nissim Mannathukkaren

is with Dalhousie University, Canada

In 1956, Keralam was amongst the poorest States, on par with Uttar Pradesh and Madhya Pradesh. Presently, it is amongst the richest; but more importantly, it has a lower infant mortality than the U.S. If Keralam were counted as a nation, it would rank 75 on the Human Development Index, ahead of China. It would also be 55 ranks above India which is at 130. This transformation and divergence from the national path is the globally lauded 'Keralam story'. This story, which is, of course, not seamless and unblemished, is built on a central animator: a robust democracy, which is a rarity in the Global South. Its significance is enhanced further because Keralam is also among the most religiously diverse regions.

Keralam reinforces Amartya Sen's original thesis that development is about expanding human freedoms rather than mere economic growth; human development does not require high incomes. Yet even now the central thrust of the national development regime is "Viksit Bharat 2047," an income-based development measure. If India had the same infant mortality levels as that of Keralam, it would have saved over 5,00,000 infant lives annually.

This staggering reality is ignored in privileging economic growth over distribution, wellbeing and democracy. Take Gujarat, a State which is richer and growing faster than Keralam and projected as a model of economic development. Keralam's multi-dimensional poverty rates are 20 times less, and infant mortality levels four times less than Gujarat. Further, 87% women have at least 10 years of schooling in Keralam while in Gujarat, it is 38%. Similarly, there are 82% men in Keralam with 10 years of schooling compared to Gujarat's 47%. Only 2.9% of women aged 20-24 years were married before 18 in Keralam, while its 18% in Gujarat. 10.9% of children under five are wasted in Keralam while in Gujarat it is 20.2%; rural open defecation practices in Keralam are at 0%; in Gujarat, 32%. The excess deaths in Keralam were 1.5 times the official COVID-19 estimates; in Gujarat it was 33 times more.

> At a time when majoritarian nationalism encompasses large parts of India, Keralam at 70 is still offering a vision of secularism and pluralism

Besides, human development is not in a zero-sum process with economic growth. As economist K.P. Kannan shows, demographic transition added 1% in per capita growth per annum compared to national growth, and migration fuelled economic growth.

Model for all

At a time when majoritarian nationalism encompasses large parts of India, Keralam at 70 is still offering a vision of secularism and pluralism. It is built on coexistence consisting of the oldest Christian and Muslim communities of India, and millennia of global exchange and cosmopolitanism. This has led to consociational power-sharing among religious communities ensuring near proportional representation in legislatures and cabinets. The current Keralam Assembly has 51% Hindu, 25% Muslim, and 24% Christian MLAs roughly corresponding to their populations. Such consociationalism is rare, even globally.

Keralam has gone the farthest among States in empowering Muslims as equal citizens, thus seeking to fulfil the Constitution's original vision. Along with religious conviviality, robust democracies also need social capital and deep civil society activism. For instance, Kudumbashree is among the world's largest women self-help networks, and around 60% of the nation's palliative care services are in Keralam. The defining feature of Keralam's civil society is the critical mass of independent organisations and voices that have challenged and pushed the State and all political parties in more democratic directions.

But Keralam's alterity, in terms of religion, food habits, culture, politics, and development evokes angst in the Hindu nationalist imagination. Thus, Keralam at 70 is facing an unprecedented challenge: relentless hostility from the national ideological consensus. Crucially, the hostility is not just cultural, but also political and economic, as federalism is being weakened.

Keralam, nevertheless, is not a finished "model". It is an incomplete one in which there is relentless struggle to secure the promise of equality and freedoms by those who are not yet fully at the table which includes women, especially, labouring lower class/caste women, Dalits, Adivasis, migrant workers, etc. They embody the attitude theorised by philosopher Michel Foucault, of critically interrogating the present to expose its silences.

Keralam's past laurels will not solve other present challenges: the ecological crisis, an ageing population, fiscal pressures, migration-dependence and enveloping neoliberalism.

Even so, Keralam at 70 still has a mirror to show India at a critical juncture of the latter's own history.

More women work but in informal and less secure jobs

Despite the rise of women's participation in the labour force, women still carry the burden of unpaid domestic work and childcare

DATA POINT

Tanu M. Goyal
Shravani Prakash
Ketaki Gaikwad
Arjun Tandon

The rise in women's workforce participation in India is now well-documented. Yet, it conceals a less encouraging reality – men and women are experiencing India's structural transformation very differently.

Between 2017-18 and 2025, the number of working women nearly doubled, from 104 million to 201 million, and the female worker population ratio rose from 22% to 38%. But most of the increase has come from rural India, largely in agriculture and in own-account and unpaid family work on farms and in household enterprises.

The positive here is that a larger part of women's daily work is finally being counted. For decades, the labour women did on the fields and cattle sheds went mostly unrecorded, and was thereby left out of policy and budgets. Simply counting, however, has just revealed how many women work but says little about the work itself. The recent ICRIER report, 'The Participation Paradox', uses the Periodic Labour Force Survey (PLFS) and the Time Use Survey to look at these dimensions. Five data points stand out.

Most of the surge in women's employment has been absorbed by agriculture, the sector that structural transformation expects workers to move out of **(Chart 1)**. The number of rural women working in crop and animal production rose from 54 million to over 100 million. Rural men, however, did move out as their share in agriculture fell from 54.1% to 47.2%, while women's rose from 70.7% to 73.3%. Surprisingly, urban women employed in agriculture rose from 2.6 million to 6.3 million, becoming their largest single employer in 2025. Outside agriculture, women's employment gains were concentrated in garments, retail and construction, sectors where work is largely informal and dominated by micro and own-account enterprises. The shift towards self-employment is particularly pronounced in rural areas where women in own-account work quadrupled, while the share of regular salaried jobs among them slipped from 10.5% to 9.3%.

Despite the rise in women's workforce participation, average weekly working hours have fallen for every group between 2017-18 and 2025. The decline was steepest for rural women, who worked a little over six hours less per week. The combination of rising participation and falling hours suggests that much of the new employment is marginal and low in intensity **(Chart 2)**.

Manufacturing reflects this pattern most clearly. In rural textiles, the gender gap in weekly working hours widened from 11 to 21; in wearing apparel, from 19 to 21. Garments and textiles are expected to draw women into regular factory work, where their hours would gradually rise towards men's. The widening gap suggests that many women in these industries remain in home-based, piece-rate, or own-account work.

The wage gap

While women's earnings have risen, men's wages have risen faster. A rural woman now earns roughly 45% of what a rural man earns, down from 53%. The sectoral picture is equally telling. The widest hourly earnings gaps are in the sectors that employ most women. Per hour, men in rural tobacco manufacturing earn 2.1 times what women do; in education, 2 times; in textiles, 1.8; in crop production, 1.7. By contrast, women earn on par with men in about 20 urban sectors, including scientific research, publishing, advertising and management consultancy which employ a small fraction of working women.

When asked why they are not in the labour force, 60% of women cite childcare and household commitments. Among men, fewer than 1% give these reasons.

These patterns have barely changed since 2021-22. Skilling and job creation can expand women's employment only if women have the time to take up these opportunities. That time is already absorbed by unpaid work at home that remains invisible in national income accounting. The Time Use Survey Shows that in 2024, Indian women spent an average of 3.7 hours a day more than men on domestic work and nearly one hour more on care.

Concerningly, taking up paid work does little to ease this burden. Working women still spend around four hours a day on unpaid domestic work and nearly two on care, in rural and urban India alike. Working men, in contrast, spend under three hours on both type of activities combined.

These paradoxes suggest that the gains from India's structural transformation have gone largely to men. Beyond raising participation, women should be pushed towards more productive, better-paid work without adding onto the unequal burden of unpaid care.

First, reduce that care burden, the main supply-side constraint. This means affordable, good-quality childcare, paid paternity and shared parental leave financed partly through social insurance. Second, make industrial and MSME policy work for women. MSME support should reward hiring women, widen access to finance and technology, and open hostels and arrange transport in textile parks and industrial areas. Third, create paid work for rural women close to home through place-based enterprise clusters, livelihood missions, and women-led producer organisations.

India has brought women's work into the data. The next step is making that work more productive, better paid, and more secure.

Labour at what cost?

The data were sourced from the Indian Council for Research on International Economic Relations (ICRIER), 'The Participation Paradox' (2026). Authors are with the ICRIER. Views expressed are personal

Chart 1: The surge in women's employment was mostly due to the agriculture (primary) sector, from which men have moved out of between 2017 and 2025

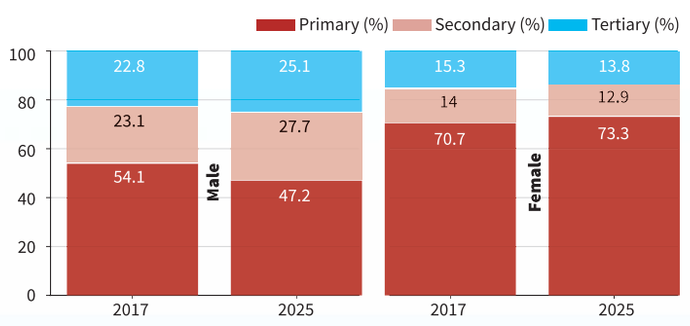


Chart 2: While more women are working, their average working hours have gone down, which suggests that much of the employment is marginal and low in intensity

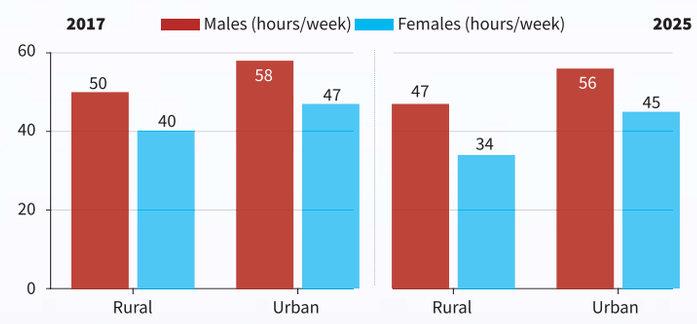
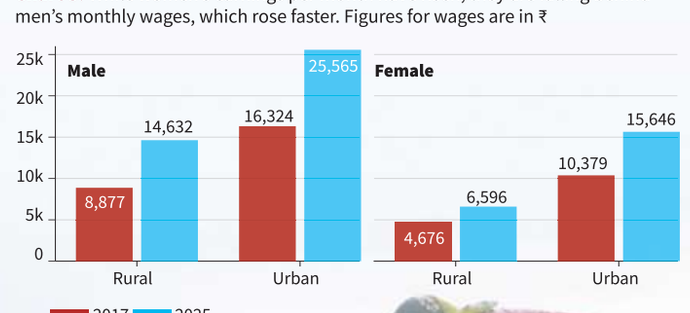


Chart 3: While women's earnings per month have risen, they are falling behind men's monthly wages, which rose faster. Figures for wages are in ₹





FROM THE ARCHIVES

The Hindu.

FIFTY YEARS AGO NOVEMBER 11, 1976

Foreign intelligence agents at work in U.S.

Washington, November 10: Either with or without the knowledge of the U.S. Government, a number of foreign intelligence organisations appear to have established a regular presence in the United States, and have been engaged in activities which are for the most part illegal.

The most publicised case to-date is that of the South Korean Intelligence Agency (KCIA), which has been accused of not only spying on South Korean and American nationals in the U.S., but also of giving huge bribes to U.S. Congressmen and others in a bid to influence U.S. defence and foreign policies – former Defence Secretary Melvin Laird has now disclosed that in 1970 the South Korean "lobby" tried to undermine the Nixon Administration's decision to withdraw 20,000 American troops from South Korea.

Another instance of foreign intelligence activity in the U.S. came to light the other day when the Shah of Iran himself admitted that agents of his country's intelligence organisation, kept track of Iranians resident in the U.S.

A HUNDRED YEARS AGO NOVEMBER 11, 1926

A case under the Companies Act

Bombay, November 10: Mr. P.D. Shamdasani, a shareholder of the Tata Iron and Steel Company and a most persistent critic of the Tata House, has for once succeeded in putting seven of the Steel Company's Directors in the wrong though he has in almost every shareholders' meeting of the company threatened them with prosecution on many allegations of mismanagement. The present case against Sri Dorab Tata, Sir Cowasji Jehangir, Narottam Morarji, Sir Phiroze Sethna, Mr. N.B. Saklatwala, Mr. F.E. Dinshaw and Sir Ibrahim Rabintulla Tata Sons Ltd and others is that they failed to comply with the provisions of the Indian Companies Act in not having convened the Company's annual general meeting within fifteen months of the preceding meeting. The accused, in pleading guilty, urged that this was a fit case for warning and discharge. The Magistrate expressed inability to do so as this was a case under the Indian Companies Act and not one under the Penal Code. He convicted and fined them to a pay a fine of Rs. 5 each.

Text&Context

THE HINDU

NEWS IN NUMBERS

Delhi's Air Quality Index reading as recorded on Tuesday

299 Delhi's air quality improved to the 'poor' category on Tuesday, with the 24-hour average Air Quality Index (AQI) settling at 299, just below the 'very poor' category threshold. The air quality is expected to improve further in the next few days, with experts attributing it to an increase in wind speed. PTI

Number of deaths caused by cholera since January

3,000 The disease killed nearly 7,900 people in 2025, making it "the deadliest year for cholera since 1999", according to Lorenzo Pezzoli, WHO lead for epidemic-prone bacterial diseases. More than 3,000 people have still died from the preventable and treatable diarrheal infection, he said AFP

India's international air passenger traffic in 2025-26

78.7 in million. India's international air passenger traffic rose a to 78.7 million even as the share of Indian carriers in the overseas traffic declined to 44.4% in the year ended March 2026, as per official data. While scheduled airlines had 985 planes, the non-scheduled operators had 425 aircraft in this period. PTI

Firecracker-related eye injury cases reported in Bengaluru

74 At least 74 firecracker-related eye injury cases have been reported at the city's Minto Ophthalmic Hospital and Narayana Nethralaya, with children and bystanders among those affected, hospital officials said on Tuesday. Forty-four patients were treated medically, while one underwent surgery for corneal tear repair. PTI

Cognizant workforce focused on delivering Claude for clients

25,000 U.S. based firm Cognizant on Tuesday announced the formation of the 'Claude Frontier Capability Group', with more than 25,000 professionals focused on delivering Claude (AI assistant by Anthropic) for clients. PTI

COMPILED BY THE HINDU DATA TEAM

Follow us facebook.com/thehindu X.com/the_hindu instagram.com/the_hindu

Is right-wing populism set to retreat?

Does the Republicans' historic defeat in the midterm elections in the United States signal a waning of right-wing populism? Does the right's emphasis on immigration and foreigners as political issues have an impact on voters? How will the anger of young protesters in India, France and other countries find political expression?

WORLD INSIGHT

Atul Mishra

Populism is the politics of what is – or can be made – popular with the people. It surfaces in democracies from time to time; its latest iteration began rising after the 2008 financial crisis, which hit ordinary people hard. Whether of the left or the right, all populism targets ruling elites and identifies a major, almost unyielding, enemy of the people. On the face of it, both target capitalism. But for the left, the system itself is the problem; for the right, the problem lies with a self-serving, globalist business elite – the capitalists. The right also identifies a second enemy in the form of immigrants and other foreigners living in their midst. In power, populists of both stripes increase executive authority and frequently game the electoral system and institutional checks to stay in office.



Supporters celebrating the Democrats' victory in the U.S. midterm elections. REUTERS

A setback for right-wing populism

Donald Trump's rise in the 2010s gave right-wing populism a global boost. Because the U.S. is powerful and other democracies often follow its lead, his success lent this politics legitimacy elsewhere. He has also backed fellow populists, from the Bolsonaros in Brazil and Nayib Bukele in El Salvador to Viktor Orbán in Hungary, and got along well with the strongmen of Russia, China and Turkiye. If Mr. Trump weakens, political equations could change well beyond the U.S. That is why the question matters.

The Republican defeat also comes against the backdrop of reversals and pressure for Mr. Trump's allies and camp mates. Mr. Orbán, after 16 years in power, lost in April. Serbian President Aleksandar Vučić lost in October, after 12 years in power. Flávio Bolsonaro lost to Brazil's Lula da Silva in late October. And Benjamin Netanyahu, a key Trump ally and regional militarist who has held office for about 19 years in all, may be next to lose power. His bloc fell short of a majority, and his rival, Gadi Eisenkot, has been asked to form the government. Furthermore, India's ruling establishment, a leading example of non-Western right-wing populism, has faced street pressure on the issues of accountability and institutional subversion.

These are major developments. But they represent a setback for right-wing populism, not its reversal.

A widening economic divide

First, the crisis that fuels this politics shows no sign of abating. A wide swathe of opinion holds that capitalism has failed the masses even as the rich get unbelievably richer and more powerful: consider America's billionaire tech bros and India's infrastructure barons. The failure has shown up in a cost-of-living crisis. In India, where it surfaces with jobs and exam leaks, it has only begun to find traction. But it is central in western democracies – driving French protests, German discontent and British Prime Minister Andy Burnham's anxieties.

Second, while this issue is common to both left- and right-wing populists, the right has an advantage: it links affordability to immigrants and those who do not share the majority's ethnicity or identity. In a word, it ties the issue to culture and security, on which the left has struggled to find a persuasive position. It claims that governments led by legacy political forces have favoured outsiders over their own people.

And this is tied to national sovereignty, that is, a country's ability to take independent decisions in its national interest. Right-wing populists claim that their country is taking decisions favouring outsiders and others, whether migrants or, for European populists, the European Union in Brussels.

Third, economic discontent means that the avenue for mass politics is open to both left and right, at the expense of the liberal centre. The absent centre means polarisation, electorally and otherwise. Flávio Bolsonaro topped Brazil's first round and lost the runoff by under four percentage points, while the Trump-endorsed candidate Abelardo de la Espriella won in Colombia in June. In Poland, Donald Tusk ousted the Law and Justice party (PiS) in 2023, but its nominee Karol Nawrocki won the presidency in 2025 and the far right is again making gains.

Then there are the big three. Economic grievance has yet to play itself out in France, Germany, and the U.K.; right-wing populism has a lot going for it in these countries. In France, Marine Le Pen's far-right National Rally (RN) leads the polls before next April's presidential election and could take office.

The Alternative for Germany (AfD) tops national polls and emerged as the largest party in the state of Saxony-Anhalt, shaking up the country's mainstream politics. A recent interview with AfD co-leader Alice Weidel in *The Economist* reveals how the party is recasting itself around economics rather than migration, as better to reach the mainstream and, eventually, federal power. In the U.K., Reform UK won May's local elections but has slipped behind Labour since Mr. Burnham replaced Keir Starmer. But there is enough fuel for its politics, especially Islamophobia and resentment against asylum seekers. If Mr. Burnham cannot address the cost-of-living crisis effectively, Reform UK may well recover.

And back in the U.S., the Democrats are split over what to read into their victory: affordability, acceptance of multiculturalism, identity politics, or socialist economics. If they emphasise an identity politics rooted in sex and gender, or play up the identity of America's first Muslim senator Abdul El-Sayed too much, they risk fuelling a right that feels betrayed by Mr. Trump. Right-wing populism may well outlast him.

The force to watch is the youth. Protesting for nearly two years, they ousted Mr. Vučić at the ballot box. In India, protests led by the Cockroach Janta Party forced out the country's Education Minister. Gen Z has filled the streets of France and Germany. And in the U.S., young voters overwhelmingly voted Democrat. This anger could turn left or right. Young Germans are splitting between the AfD and the radical left, and the unrest in France has so far helped Ms. Le Pen. Where they would settle remains to be seen.

(Atul Mishra is a professor of international relations at Shiv Nadar University, Delhi-NCR.)

THE GIST

- Donald Trump's rise in the 2010s gave right-wing populism a global boost. Because the U.S. is powerful, his success lent this politics legitimacy elsewhere
- Economic discontent means that the avenue for mass politics is open to both left and right, at the expense of the liberal centre. The absence of a strong centre leads to polarisation

Why Jamaica's reparations petition has a solid legal basis

The petition asks whether the enslavement of Africans in Jamaica violated international law

WORLD INSIGHT

Faisal C.K.

Led by Culture Minister Olivia Grange, the Jamaican government filed a petition on September 7, 2026, asking King Charles III of England – who is Jamaica's Head of State – to refer three core legal questions to the Judicial Committee of the Privy Council (JCPC) under Section 4 of the Judicial Committee Act 1833. The questions ask whether the capture, transportation, and enslavement of Africans in Jamaica were ever lawful under English common law, whether those acts violated international legal principles, and whether the U.K. holds a legal obligation to provide reparatory remedies to the Jamaican people.

While the petition is pending, U.K. Prime Minister Andy Burnham recently stated that the government is open to formally apologising for Britain's role in the transatlantic slave trade, but ruled out financial reparations, arguing that the contemporary British populace cannot be held liable for historical wrongs. However, a closer look reveals that Jamaica's petition possesses far more legal weight than a cosmetic apology.

The burden of history

In January 1778, inside Edinburgh's Court of Session, a Jamaican-born African named Joseph Knight challenged the legal basis of British domestic servitude. Brought to Perthshire as chattel by sugar baron John Wedderburn, Knight demanded his wages and liberty. Wedderburn insisted that colonial property rights were indelible across the Atlantic. The Scottish bench demurred. The court declared that a master's dominion over an enslaved person, however entrenched under Jamaican statutes, was so unjust that it could find no shelter under Scots law. Knight walked out a free man.

Yet, for two and a half centuries, the verdict carried an imperial hypocrisy. The common law proudly proclaimed the soil of the metropole too pure for slavery, while permitting the Crown to enrich itself from slavery across the Caribbean.

Jamaica's strategy of petitioning King Charles III represents a masterstroke of forensic anti-colonialism: demanding that Britain reconcile its domestic declarations of human dignity with centuries of institutionalised colonial devastation.

The filing gains added significance from its timing, deliberately marking the anniversary of the Liverpool slave ship Zong's departure in 1781. When navigational errors and dwindling water supplies threatened the voyage, the crew cast 132 enslaved Africans, bound and alive, into the sea to ensure that insurance underwriters covered jettisoned "cargo" rather than deaths from dehydration. When the resulting case – *Gregson v. Gilbert* (1783) – reached Lord Mansfield, the court treated mass homicide purely as a commercial breach of contract. By yoking its challenge to this foundational atrocity, Jamaica's petition confronts the Privy Council with the very moment English jurisprudence reduced human slaughter to an insurable business loss.

By petitioning Charles III as King of Jamaica, Kingston obligates him to act on the advice of his Caribbean ministers, not his Westminster cabinet. Relying on the 1833 statute permitting the sovereign to refer any matter to the JCPC for an opinion, Jamaica bypasses diplomatic entreaties, compelling Britain's highest sitting judges to either legitimise an imperial double standard or acknowledge that the state's foundational wealth was built upon an actionable legal wrong.

An obligation *erga omnes*

Substantively, Jamaica's plea directly challenges Britain's standard defence: the doctrine of intertemporal law. This principle dictates that past acts must be judged solely by the law of their contemporary era. Successive British governments have routinely hidden behind this positivist barricade, asserting that however abhorrent the transatlantic slave trade was, it was lawful under 18th-century imperial statutes.

Jamaica shatters this defence by invoking norms that admit no temporal limitation. As the International Court of Justice articulated in Barcelona Traction (1970), the prohibition of slavery is an obligation *erga omnes* – a peremptory duty owed to the international community as a whole. Jamaica asserts that chattel slavery was *malum in se*, fundamentally repugnant to natural justice from its inception. Because of its *erga omnes* nature, this sustained expropriation of human beings constitutes an indelible violation that the modern state cannot lawfully ignore.

Furthermore, Jamaica's petition operationalises restorative justice, as pioneered by criminologist Howard Zehr. Unlike traditional retributive justice – which focuses on rule-breaking and individual culpability – Zehr's framework addresses the harm done and affirmative obligations to make things right.

This necessity is underscored by the British Treasury's own ledger. When the Parliament passed the Slavery Abolition Act 1833, it paid £20 million– nearly 40 per cent of its national budget to compensate former slave-owners, rather than the emancipated victims. Britain only finished repaying that bailout loan in 2015. Under restorative ethics, this was an institutional inversion of justice: compensating the wrongdoers while leaving victims destitute.

(Faisal C.K. is Deputy Law Secretary to the Keralam Government. Views are personal)

CACHE

Does the Temple wearable reveal useful information about brain health?

The wearable device sold by billionaire Deepinder Goyal is said to monitor brain health and ageing by measuring changes in cerebral blood flow; critics and doctors question its medical claims, noting that the evidence is preliminary and its core metric, the Brain Flow index, remains controversial

Jacob Koshy

Billionaire entrepreneur Deepinder Goyal, co-founder of Zomato and Blinkit, has announced the commercial availability of Temple, a wearable monitoring device that he claims could become "Humanity's last personal device".

A graduate in Computer Science and Mathematics from the Indian Institute of Technology Delhi, Mr. Goyal has no academic background in medical sciences or biological research. His claims have drawn criticism from doctors, including social media influencer and physician Cyriac Abby Philips (LiverDoc), who has described the device as a "scam".

Mr. Goyal's claims span several areas. Temple, he says, is the most accurate wearable health monitor yet and can continuously track changes – not absolute values – of blood flow to the brain and heart outside laboratory settings.

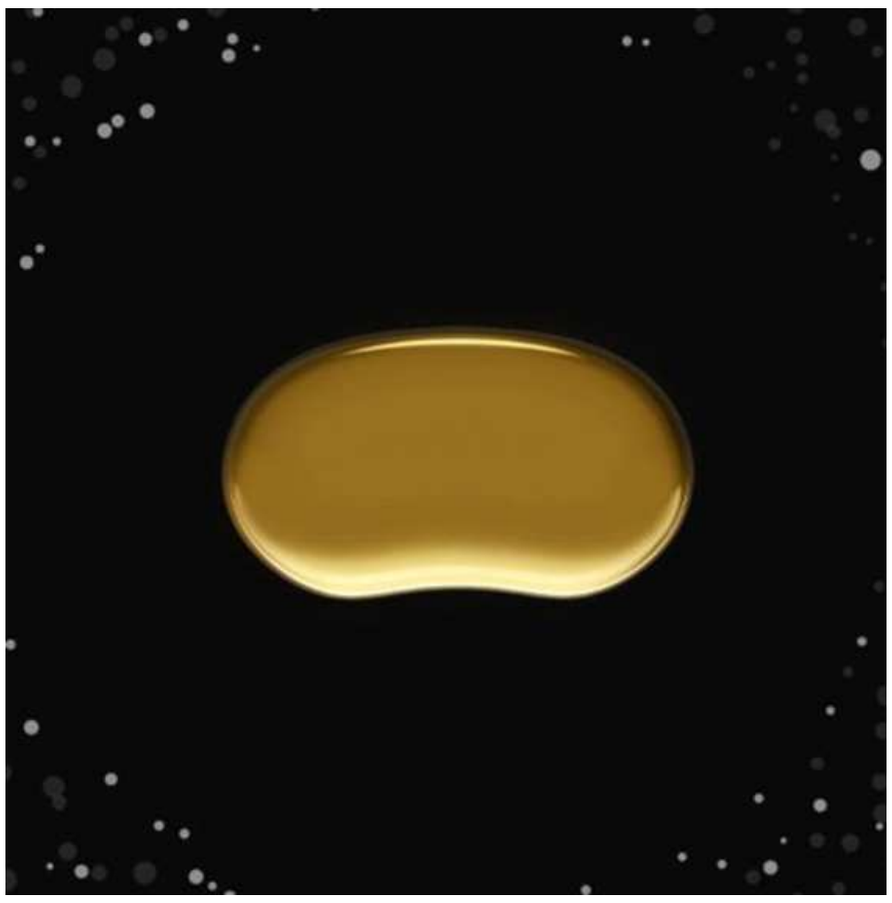
The device, a small pod attached to the temple, he controversially claims, measures changes in cerebral blood flow. From these readings, he uses a proprietary score ranging from 1 to 250 and touts it as a proxy for how relaxed the brain is, with meditation representing the lower end and elite athletes at peak performance the higher end.

The device is also part of Mr. Goyal's larger hypothesis that gravity plays a significant role in ageing and the associated decline in bodily functions. Separately, he claims that Temple can detect vibrations generated by the wearer's voice through motion sensors, convert them into text and function as an executive assistant without requiring a conventional microphone.

While entropy – a measure of disorder and one of the fundamental laws of nature – is better understood in the context of physics and information theory (involving computation), it doesn't have established metrics in biology. The 'entropy' that Mr. Goyal claims is a proprietary index that relates to health and ageing and, from what appears, only has a tenuous connection to the entropy in physical systems.

When questioned by doctors online, Goyal underlines that Temple "isn't a medical device" and that there are several studies ongoing, that haven't been made public yet regarding the device's ability to gauge 'entropy.'

However, much of the recent criticism has centred on its claims about brain blood flow. Publications available on Temple's website are not peer-reviewed, although they involve researchers affiliated with several established international institutions. Their findings provide some evidence for the device's measurement capabilities, but remain considerably narrower than the ambitions of Mr. Goyal's public claims.



Disputed device: Temple, a wearable monitoring device sold by billionaire Deepinder Goyal, is said to measure changes in cerebral blood flow. X/@TEMPLE

How does Temple measure blood flow?

The technology has some similarities to pulse oximetry, the familiar finger-mounted device used widely during the pandemic to measure blood oxygen saturation. Pulse oximetry uses photoplethysmography (PPG), exploiting the different light-absorption properties of oxygenated and deoxygenated haemoglobin.

Typically, it shines red and infrared light through the finger and measures how much light is absorbed. The pulsatile component of the signal corresponds to arterial blood and helps estimate the proportion of haemoglobin carrying oxygen.

Temple uses a related approach. It shines green, red and infrared light into the skin and measures how much is reflected. Blood absorbs light, and with every heartbeat the tiny vessels beneath the skin expand, causing the reflected light to fluctuate.

The frequency of these fluctuations provides heart rate, while their amplitude relative to the background signal offers an indication of changes in blood volume in the tissue being monitored. Different wavelengths penetrate to different depths, with green light largely confined to superficial tissue and red and infrared light reaching deeper.

Temple combines several features of these optical signals, including pulse amplitude, indicators of oxygen-carrying blood, pulse shape, heart rate, skin temperature and motion, to generate its proprietary Brain Flow index, or Temple-BF. The mathematical basis of this score remains opaque. It is also unclear whether readings can be compared meaningfully between individuals.

The central assumption is that monitoring a blood vessel supplied by the external carotid artery, which connects with vessels branching from the artery supplying the brain, can provide information about cerebral blood flow.

However, Temple researchers themselves acknowledge that the anatomical connection does not establish that the signal reflects blood flow inside the brain. Their paper's limitations section states that the sensor fundamentally detects changes in blood flow in the skin and underlying tissue.

Why does brain blood flow matter?

The brain consumes about a fifth of the body's energy and depends on a continuous supply of oxygen and glucose. Scientists usually measure this supply using Magnetic Resonance Imaging, which estimates blood flow per unit of tissue; ultrasound, which measures blood velocity in a major artery supplying the brain; and optical techniques, which track changes in haemoglobin as an indirect indicator of blood flow.

Previous research has associated ageing with declining cerebral blood flow. A 2023 study involving 185 healthy adults aged 21 to 80, published in the *Journal of Cerebral Blood Flow & Metabolism*, found that the major arteries in the neck remained similar in width with age, but blood moved through them more slowly. The authors suggested that narrowing of downstream vessels could explain the finding.

Other studies have associated lower cerebral blood flow with an approximately 30% higher risk of dementia and faster cognitive decline over 5.7 years.

These are associations, however, cannot establish whether reduced blood flow causes cognitive decline or whether brain shrinkage resulting from cognitive decline reduces the amount of tissue requiring blood.

Evidence linking blood pressure to dementia is stronger. A 2016 study in *PLOS Medicine* associated orthostatic hypotension - a fall in blood pressure on standing – with an approximately 15% higher risk of dementia. Evidence connecting cerebral blood flow to longevity is considerably weaker.

There is no trial demonstrating that increasing brain blood flow extends life or delays cognitive decline. Importantly, none of these studies has anything to do with entropy.

What do Temple's studies establish?

In one study, 44 young men wore Temple while undergoing different postural manoeuvres, including lying head-down on a tilting table, squatting and moving from standing to lying flat. Their readings were compared with time-domain near-infrared spectroscopy (NIRS), a research technique that uses the time taken by light to return to distinguish signals from the scalp and deeper brain tissue. Temple-BF correlated more strongly with the modelled brain signal than with the scalp signal in the three manoeuvres, although the difference was relatively small in one test and could have been due to chance.

Another study involving 20 participants compared Temple readings with transcranial Doppler (TCD), an ultrasound technique that measures blood velocity in a major artery supplying the brain. Participants undertook seated cycling and a stand-then-lie-down test. Temple-BF correlated approximately 0.80 with the ultrasound measurements in both tests.

The researchers also found that when participants lay down, Temple-BF rose alongside blood velocity in the brain artery rather than following the fall in heart rate. They argue that this suggests the index is not simply a repackaged heart-rate measurement.

The strongest evidence presented for Temple concerns heart-rate monitoring. In a company report involving 43 healthy adults undergoing a graded treadmill test, Temple was compared with wearables such as an Apple Watch, Fitbit, WHOOP, Garmin and Oura Ring, using a chest strap as the reference. Temple recorded the smallest average error and deviated least from consistently accurate readings. The report also found that the placement of the device mattered: the Apple Watch's error fell when it was worn higher on the forearm. Measuring closer to the heart, where blood is pumped, can improve accuracy, which is a well-known observation.

Dr. Anurag Agrawal, physiologist and dean of biomedical research at Ashoka University, Haryana, told *The Hindu* that he does not dismiss the Temple index. He considers it a legitimate mathematical analysis that can be tested for its predictive value. But he cautions that it is too early to establish whether it can predict longevity, general well-being or specific diseases. Long-term studies monitoring such parameters remain scarce.

At ₹85,000, Temple is likely to attract "self-paying enthusiasts" willing to experiment with a new technology. Dr. Agrawal points out that brain blood flow is tightly regulated and does not ordinarily need to be measured unless there is a major clinical problem.

He nevertheless sees potential in collecting large volumes of real-world data over extended periods, particularly in areas where conventional research funding is limited. "Whether Temple can translate its measurements into reliable information about brain health and ageing will depend on evidence that goes well beyond its initial laboratory studies," he noted.



FROM THE ARCHIVES

Know your English

S. Upendran

What is the difference between both an "intruder" and an "infiltrator"? (G. Mahaboob Basha, Anantapur)

An "intruder" is someone who enters another person's property illegally – without the owner's consent. The act of intrusion may be accidental or deliberate. A thief who enters your house is an example of an individual who intrudes on your property intentionally. Sometimes when you go out on long walks you may intrude on someone else's property without being aware of it. Whether you enter another person's property intentionally or accidentally, the moment you enter it, you have become an intruder.

The intruders were caught as soon as they crossed the border.

An "infiltrator" is someone who enters a country or an organisation without the others being aware of it. The individual enters secretly and uses a lot of cunning to get in. The word "infiltrator" has a negative connotation associated with it, and is normally used in politics and the military. Unlike an "intruder", one cannot become an "infiltrator" accidentally. If you wish to become an infiltrator, everything has to be carefully planned so that you can gain access to whatever it is you want without drawing attention to yourself.

According to the army the infiltrators were caught.

We caught the infiltrator with the documents.

What is the meaning of the idiom "not let the grass grow under one's feet"? (S. Balasubramnian, Thiruvidaimarudur)

When you tell an individual "not to let the grass grow under his feet", what you want him to do is to stop wasting time, to stop delaying. You want the person to get on with the job on hand, instead of trying to put things off. Here are a few examples.

The Chairman let the grass grow under his feet. As a result, the project wasn't completed on time.

You can't let the grass grow under your feet. You have millions invested in this project.

What is the origin of "Uncle Sam"? (B. Bhanu, Trichy)

It is quite common for people to refer to the American Government as "Uncle Sam". This is an expression that is generally used in informal contexts.

Uncle Sam did not take kindly to the comments made by our Government.

It is interesting to note that the "Sam" referred to is not the first name of some well-known President or some famous American General. "Sam Wilson" from whom we get "Uncle Sam" was a meat inspector who lived in the U.S. in the early 19th century. According to one explanation Sam Wilson, an elderly gentleman, was hired by the U.S Army to inspect the meat bought by them. Most of his fellow workers always addressed him as "Uncle Sam". It was Sam's job to inspect the meat and okay it. When he found that the meat was satisfactory, then he put his initials on the container. Instead of "SW", he used to write "U.S". When people asked whether the initials "U.S" stood for the "United States", they were told that it stood for "Uncle Sam"! There is however little evidence to support this story.

Published in The Hindu on July 2, 2002

THE DAILY QUIZ

Please send in your answers to dailyquiz@thehindu.co.in

A quiz on Remembrance Day, observed on November 11, to honour soldiers who died in the line of duty. It arose from the Armistice Day, marking the end of the First World War

Joan Sony Cherian

QUESTION 1

While the U.K. and other Commonwealth nations call it 'Remembrance Day', the U.S. calls it by another name. What is the name?

QUESTION 2

One European nation celebrates its independence day also on the same date. Which country?

QUESTION 3

While hostilities technically ended with the signing of the Armistice between Germany and the Allied powers on November 11, the official end of the Great War came through a peace treaty only in 1919. Name the treaty.

QUESTION 4

The first Armistice Day was, however, not celebrated on November 11. When and where was it?

QUESTION 5

In Canada, Armistice Day was changed to Remembrance Day in 1931. Why?



Visual question: The flower projected onto the sails of the Sydney Opera House is associated with Remembrance day. What flower is it? REUTERS

Questions and answers to the previous day's daily quiz:

1. The Festival of Reason held at Notre-Dame Cathedral was held on this date in the French Republican calendar. **Ans: 20 Brumaire, Year II (November 10, 1793)**

2. Pierre-Gaspard Chaumette held this position in the Paris Commune when he spearheaded the Festival of Reason. **Ans: Procureur (public prosecutor) of the Paris Commune**

3. This Parisian cathedral was transformed into a Temple of Reason during the November 1793 celebrations. **Ans: Notre-Dame Cathedral**

4. The revolutionary civic cult that succeeded the Cult of Reason as the officially promoted alternative under Maximilien Robespierre in 1794. **Ans: The Cult of the Supreme Being (Culte de l'Être suprême)**

Visual: Identify this French physician and revolutionary politician whose name became an eponym for a device associated with executions during the French Revolution. Although he did not invent the device, he advocated a more humane method of execution and opposed the death penalty. **Ans: Joseph-Ignace Guillotin**

Early birds: Mohan Lal Patel| KN Viswanathan| Parimal Das| Tamal Biswas| Saheni George

Word of the day

Demur:
to raise an objection

Synonym: oppose

Usage: *He accepted the offer without demur.*

Pronunciation: newsth.live/demur

International Phonetic Alphabet: /dɪˈmɜː/

For feedback and suggestions for Text & Context, please write to **letters@thehindu.co.in** with the subject 'Text & Context'

PSU insurers dodge questions on underuse of own TPA

A 2022 CAG report found that HITPA had adequate capacity and performance parameters comparable to leading TPAs, yet received only a fraction of the business handled by its promoter insurers; However, responses to RTI applications filed with the four insurers do not establish whether allocations have increased significantly or what action has been taken on the audit recommendation

Balasubramanyam C.P.
CHENNAI

Health Insurance TPA of India Ltd. (HITPA), a third-party administrator (TPA) promoted by four public-sector general insurers, continues to face questions over the extent of business entrusted to it, more than four years after the Comptroller and Auditor General (CAG) flagged its underutilisation and recommended higher allocations.

A 2022 CAG report found that HITPA had adequate capacity and performance parameters comparable to leading TPAs, yet received only a fraction of the business handled by its promoter insurers.

However, responses to Right to Information (RTI) applications filed with the four insurers do not establish whether allocations have increased significantly or what action has been taken on the audit recommendation.

New India Assurance and Oriental Insurance declined to disclose information sought across the questions, invoking Section 8(1)(d) of the RTI Act, which exempts commercial confidence and trade secrets where disclosure could harm competitive interests. Section 8(2), however, permits disclosure where public interest outweighs the protected interests.

United India Insurance and National Insurance provided some operational information available on their websites but withheld financial and performance-related details.

United India reported that HITPA had processed 1,18,712 claims and administered 48,525 policies covering 67.99 lakh lives as of March 31, 2026. National Insurance reported 1,55,137 policies covering 8,52,444 lives. However, neither disclosure established the premium value allocated to HITPA or its share of the insurers' overall TPA business.

Taking cover

None of the four insurers furnish clear account of action taken on CAG's recommendation to revisit business allocation to HITPA

- New India Assurance and Oriental Insurance decline information invoking Section 8(1)(d) of RTI Act
- Section 8(2), however, permits disclosure where public interest outweighs the protected interests
- United India Insurance and National Insurance withhold financial and performance-related details



According to the CAG, HITPA had paid-up capital of ₹120 crore as of March 31, 2021.

Each of the four insurers contributed ₹28.50 crore, while GIC Re held the remaining ₹6 crore.

The audit found that capacity utilisation, measured by lives serviced against available capacity, declined from 5.34% in 2017-18 to 3.68% in 2019-20. HITPA's share of the total premium allocated to TPAs by its promoter insurers, meanwhile, rose from 0.92% in 2016-17 to 6.19% in 2019-20. These were the latest allocation figures cited in the report.

HITPA had approached the General Insurance Public Sector Association (GIPSA) in March 2018, seeking at least 10-15% of health insurance claims-processing work. GIPSA's governing board agreed in September 2018 to transfer 10% of the work handled by the five largest TPAs to HITPA. The decision, however, was not implemented.

The insurers attributed the low allocation to HITPA's limited geographical presence, competition from established TPAs and reluctance among group clients. The CAG rejected these explanations, pointing out that HITPA had adequate capacity and a presence in 10 major cities, including all four metros.

Asked about follow-up action, National Insurance said, "The matter related to the cited report is under review, therefore, the information does not exist at present."

United India said, "The subject matter is under process, information sought does not exist as on date."

MRF Q2 net skids as raw material costs erode margins

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

MRF Ltd. reported a 26.6% year-on-year (YoY) decline in consolidated net profit to ₹386.99 crore for the second quarter ended September 30, 2026, as a sharp increase in raw material costs eroded margins despite robust revenue growth.

Consolidated total income rose 17.4% to ₹8,791.58 crore during the quarter. However, profit before tax (PBT) fell 25.5% YoY to ₹521.81 crore. Earnings per share declined to ₹912.46 from ₹1,243.60.

Industry seeks LTCG, STT cuts in 2027 Budget; MSME relief also on wish list

T.C.A. Sharad Raghavan
Gowri Lakshmi
NEW DELHI

Removing LTCG levy would raise post-tax returns and close the gap with Korea, Taiwan and Brazil

Several industry bodies have recommended to the Ministry of Finance that the upcoming Budget 2027 should rationalise the Long-Term Capital Gains (LTCG) tax rate on equities and reduce the rate of the Securities Transaction Tax (STT).

Officials in the Finance Ministry, including Finance Minister Nirmala Sitharaman and Revenue Secretary Arvind Shrivastava, have been conducting their pre-Budget consultative meetings, during which they met the Confederation of Indian Industry (CII), Federation of Indian Chambers of Commerce and Industry (FICCI), the PHD Chamber of Commerce and Industry (PHDCCI), and the Associated Chambers of Commerce and Industry (ASSOCHAM), among others.

One of the most-cited requests from the industry was the rationalisation of LTCG on equities.

Currently, foreign and domestic investors have to pay 12.5% tax on the sale of equities on gains exceeding ₹1.25 lakh per annum on listed shares.

"Removing the LTCG levy would raise post-tax returns and close a gap with Korea, Taiwan and Brazil," Rakesh Nangia, chairman of the task force on International Taxes at ASSOCHAM said.

The PHDCCI has requested that the government abolish LTCG tax on equity investments, reduce the short-term capital gains (STCG) tax rate from 20% to 10%, and lower STT rates "to encourage long-term investment and improve India's capital market competitiveness".

To support the MSME sector, the PHDCCI has requested the Finance Minister to extend the overdue period after which a loan is classified as a non-performing asset (NPA) from 90 to 180 days "to accommodate longer working capital cycles and delayed realisation of receivables".

Further, the chamber has called for an enhancement of PM MUDRA loan limits and a Budget announcement of direct equity support to MSMEs through the Fund of Funds Scheme, "with dedicated allocations for start-up seed capital and SME IPO participation.

NTPC leads second round of bids for coal gasification

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

Two applications, both from state-owned power producer NTPC Ltd, have been received in the second rolling round of applications for incentives to set up coal gasification projects, the Coal Ministry said on Tuesday.

The ministry also announced the launch of the third round under the government's ₹37,500-crore incentive scheme.

NTPC has sought incentives for projects to produce urea, methanol and dimethyl ether (DME).

Blackstone to acquire 16% stake in IIFL Finance for $535 mn

Reuters

Blackstone will invest ₹50 billion ($535 million) for an approximately 16% stake in India's IIFL Finance, as part of a ₹64.14 billion capital raise, the non-banking financial company said on Tuesday.

The issue will also include a ₹12.64 billion investment by existing investors Nirmal Jain and R. Venkataraman, while Anchorage Capital will invest another ₹1.5 billion.

The investment will raise IIFL Finance's capital adequacy ratio to about 30% from 17%, the company said. The additional capital will support growth in its secured lending businesses, particularly gold finance, and could help improve its credit ratings and lower borrowing costs over time.



The investment will raise IIFL Finance's capital adequacy ratio to about 30% from 17%.

NMDC, Rosatom in talks over lithium investment: sources

Reuters
NEW DELHI/MOSCOW

Indian state-run miner NMDC Ltd. is in talks with Russia's Rosatom to invest in Russian lithium projects, three people familiar with the matter said, as India steps up efforts to secure supplies of the metal for its battery and EV industries.

NMDC officials visited Russia last month for a conference and held talks with state nuclear firm Rosatom, two of the people said. The third person, who also confirmed company officials met with Rosatom, said NMDC was keen to explore lithium-mining and processing opportunities in Russia and had also held discussions with other Russian firms.

All three people, who asked not to be named as the talks were confidential, said discussions between NMDC and Rosatom remain preliminary. A Rosatom spokesperson did not address *Reuters* queries about the meetings last month but said the Russian company was not currently engaged in talks with NMDC. NMDC did not respond to a *Reuters* request for comment. NMDC said last year it was exploring acquisition opportunities for critical minerals in Africa, Australia and South America as part of its global mineral diversification strategy. It has formed a 12-member team to carry out due diligence on potential critical mineral assets, one of the people said.

Incentive policy

Last week, Indian Prime Minister Narendra Modi's cabinet approved an incentive policy worth ₹28.14 billion ($297 million) to boost domestic processing of lithium and nickel. India's domestic processing capacity for critical minerals, including lithium, remains at a nascent stage, the government has said, leaving it heavily dependent on imports. It currently meets lithium demand primarily through imports from China, Vietnam and Ecuador. Despite possessing large lithium reserves, Russia currently has no commercial production.

Rosatom and Russian miner Nornickel, however, are developing the country's largest lithium deposit through their Polar Lithium joint venture, with commercial production expected to begin by 2030.



Back up plan: A man stands in front of exhibition stand of Russia's State Atomic Energy Corporation Rosatom in Russia. REUTERS

Catching up in AI



Keeping with times: An operator at Verlet Robotics adjusts a data-capture device in the workshop at the Verlet Robotics office in Kigali, Rwanda. Verlet Robotics is a robotics and physical AI company that records and annotates human movements and tasks to create datasets used for training future robots to perform real-world work autonomously. AFP

Aurobindo arm Eugia U.S. recalling antibacterial drug

N. Ravi Kumar
HYDERABAD

Aurobindo Pharma subsidiary Eugia U.S. LLC is voluntarily recalling a lot of Vancomycin Hydrochloride for Injection USP 1.25g/Vial-30mL (single dose vial) due to the presence of particulate matter identified as a glass particle inside the vial.

Eugia shipped the lot to wholesalers in the U.S. from September 2-15. It notified distributors and customers via recall letters and is arranging for return/replacement of all the recalled products, U.S. Food and Drug Administration (U.S. FDA) said, as per a company announcement.

Vancomycin hydrochloride for injection is a glycopeptide antibacterial indicated in adult and paediatric patients (neonates and older) for the treatment of septicaemia, infective endocarditis, skin and skin structure infections, bone infections and lower respiratory tract infections, the regulator said in a communication.

Eugia U.S. LLC was formerly known as Auro Medics Pharma LLC.



Vancomycin hydrochloride is a glycopeptide antibacterial.

Sugar mills sustain margin hit as ethanol earnings plummet

Press Trust of India
NEW DELHI

Indian sugar mills are staring at a 140-160 basis-point contraction in operating margins in FY27 as curbs on ethanol output from sugar-based feedstock erode a key source of higher-margin earnings, while rising sugarcane costs and funding needs add to pressure, as per Crisil Ratings.

Operating margins are expected to dip to about 6% this fiscal despite an anticipated 4-5% growth in operating income as firm sugar prices and steady demand prove insufficient to offset the adverse product mix, higher input costs and interest burden. The analysis covered 55 sugar mills accounting for almost a fourth of India's sugar output in the last season.

The sector's outlook for FY28 will depend on trajectory of sugar prices relative to cane costs, changes in ethanol pricing and monsoon performance.

Last minute buying lights up Diwali UPI transactions by 32% to 916.9mn

Press Trust of India
NEW DELHI

Transactions through the popular Unified Payments Interface (UPI) saw a 32% surge in volume terms on Diwali driven by last-minute festival buying.

UPI volume increased to 916.9 million on November 8 from 695.7 million transactions on the same day last year, according to data released by the National Payments Corporation of India (NPCI).

In value terms, UPI transactions rose to ₹90,029.43 crore on November 8 against ₹88,350.79 crore last year. A day prior to Diwali, the transaction volume was 975.8 million resulting in transfer of ₹1,36,118 crore.

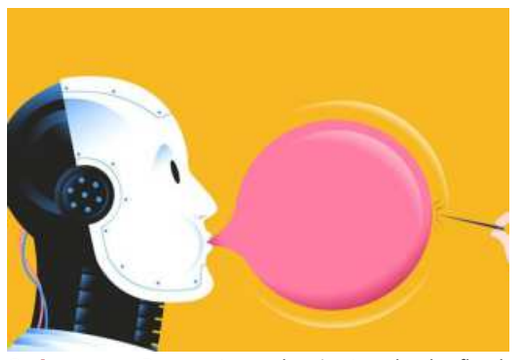
UPI is an instant payment system developed by the NPCI. NPCI, an initiative of the Reserve Bank of India (RBI) and the Indian Banks' Association (IBA), is an umbrella organisation for operating retail payments and settlement systems in India.

Last month, UPI transactions touched 25.47 billion while in value terms it was ₹31.53 lakh crore in entire October supported by festival buying. As far as overseas presence is concerned, UPI is accepted in 11 countries, with Uzbekistan being the latest entry.



Growing popularity: UPI is accepted in 11 countries, with Uzbekistan being the latest entry.

AI debt faces pressure as Democrats prepare to take over Congress



Curbs on way: Democrats are planning to unleash a flood of new legislation targeting AI systems. GETTYIMAGES/ISTOCK

NEWS ANALYSIS

Reuters
NEW YORK

Bond investors are growing more cautious on debt tied to the artificial intelligence boom, highlighting concerns over the expected efforts of a Democrat-controlled Congress to slow the pace of AI investment and data centre expansion.

U.S. high-yield credit spreads widened to 348 basis points in last Thursday's stock-market swoon, ICE BofA U.S. Corporate Index data showed. That was the highest since May 2025, a month after President Trump imposed global tariffs. Spreads narrowed on Friday to 342 basis points. "The markets are definitely anxious right now. I wouldn't be surprised to see some continued volatility in both high yield and loans," said Larry Holzenthaler, senior portfolio manager at Catalyst Funds in New York.

Deeper reassessment

While healthy corporate fundamentals continue to support the market, a deeper reassessment of AI-related risk could push credit spreads wider in both high-yield and investment-grade debt in anticipation of stricter regulations on this technology, analysts and portfolio managers said. Investment-grade spread swere at 93 basis points last Thursday, against 91 the previous session.

Democrats are already planning to unleash a flood of new legislation targeting AI systems and data centre development when they take control of Congress in January. Republican President Donald Trump has repeatedly dismissed calls to write mandatory rules for AI technology, but over the weekend, following a historic midterm loss for his party, he signalled openness to safeguards. "Appetite is more cautious and more discriminating," said Ali Hassan, portfolio manager at Thornburg Investment Management. "Political and regulatory scrutiny is prompting a review of credits up and down the chain, from developers to contractors to suppliers."

More cautious

Data centre bonds, many of them concentrated in the BB and single-B tiers of the junk bond market, have come under fresh pressure in recent weeks, especially during the technology selloff. Single-B spreads widened 35 basis points to 367 basis points, leading the deterioration in the high-yield market, analysts said.

Galaxy Helios Data Center bonds fell to 89.25 cents on the dollar on November 5, for instance, lifting yields to 13% from the 9.875% offered when Galaxy Digital's wholly owned unit sold the B+ rated debt in late July. "A slowdown in AI buildout that hits the supply chain, power producers, electrical contractors, equipment and machinery, data center developers, all of these are going to have a second-order effect," said Peter Yanulis, multi-asset portfolio manager at Loomis Sayles.

MSCARO, ICAI set guardrails for multi state cooperatives eyeing bank status

While banking regulator is laying down financial, governance norms for cooperative credit societies aspiring to turn into banks, MSCARO seeks to ensure transparency, financial discipline and accountability necessary to meet those conditions, new framework can detect financial stress early

NEWS ANALYSIS

Santosh V. Perumal

Once bitten, twice shy. India's urban cooperative banks (UCBs) have had their share of troubled episodes, regulatory lapses and governance failures, which neither the Government nor the Reserve Bank of India (RBI) could afford to overlook.

After keeping UCB licensing on hold for 22 years, the RBI's decision to revive the process marks a significant shift. But this time, the Government seems determined to put the guardrails in place before allowing the sector to gather momentum.

The Ministry of Commerce's Multi-State Co-operative Societies (Auditor's Report) Order or MSCARO 2026, with the proposed guidance note from the Institute of Chartered Accountants of India (ICAI), is an attempt to make the journey smoother and safer. The objective is not merely to reopen the doors but to ensure that those entering do so on a sound institutional footing.

The two developments are connected. While the RBI is laying down the financial and governance conditions for cooperative credit societies aspiring to become banks, MSCARO seeks to ensure transparency, financial discipline and accountability needed to meet those conditions.



New beginning: A man stands in front of the RBI logo inside its headquarters in Mumbai. REUTERS

The new framework helps in early detection of financial stress, safeguards members' funds and strengthens statutory and regulatory compliance.

A key aspect of the stringent order is that audit observations will feed into the Central Registrar of Cooperative Societies (CRCS) portal, which facilitates risk-based supervision, automated scrutiny and potential AI-based risk assessment in the sector, which once reeked of scams like Madhavpura Mercantile Cooperative Bank and Punjab and Maharashtra Cooperative Bank.

Poor governance, political interference, dual regulation, concentrated lending, weak capital structure and technology deficiency summed up for the failure of several UCBs.

> As per an RBI Report, India had 1,457 UCBs at end March 2025 with a combined balance sheet of ₹7.38 lakh cr. (deposits of ₹5.84 lakh crore and ₹3.70 lakh cr. advances

MSCARO 2026 – modelled on the Companies (Auditor's Report) Order (CARO) that prescribes additional reporting requirements for company auditors – stems from concerns about inconsistent audit practices, inadequate financial disclosures, governance deficiencies and the possibility of financial irregularities going undetected. Unlike commercial banks, many cooperative credit societies have had relatively limited institutional oversight.

Clear parameters

As part of efforts to address the shortcomings, MSCARO outlined a standardised audit format, wherein auditors must provide clear Yes/No responses, accompanied by explanations, on financial, administrative, governance and statutory compliance parameters.

The scope is vast and includes examination of non-performing assets, overdue loans, funds utilisation, cybersecurity safeguards and anti-money laundering compliance, and board composition.

The initial phase covers societies crossing the ₹1,000-crore threshold, with the long-term goal of extending the framework to societies crossing ₹50 crore in relevant financial parameters. This gives smaller institutions time to upgrade their accounting and reporting systems.

ICAI notification

The Institute of Chartered Accountants of India (ICAI) plays a pivotal role in translating the new audit norms into professional practice.

The ICAI had in October said its Cooperation and NPO Committee reviewed the draft MSCARO and submitted a comprehensive audit checklist to the Ministry of Cooperation.

Working on a Guidance Note on MSCARO 2026, ICAI said its proposed guidance is intended to provide auditors with a structured reference for examining key audit considerations, improving consistency and ensuring compliance with statutory requirements.

It is undertaking capacity-building programmes for cooperative societies and departmental auditors.

The ICAI initiative could help bridge the gap between regulatory expectations and the actual auditing capabilities available across cooperative sector.

India has a substantial cooperative ecosystem, especially in rural credit, agriculture, dairy, housing and community-based financial services. Hence, failures in governance or financial management can have consequences extending beyond the institutions themselves as seen from the historical records.

One of India's earliest major UCB failures was MMCB, which had excessive exposure to stock market operator Ketan Parekh-linked entities and another prominent one was PMC, which hid large stressed loans, particularly exposure to HDIL, via fraudulent accounting practices.

Timing matters

The advent of MSCARO is particularly relevant as RBI is reopening the doors for fresh UCB licences after a gap of nearly 22 years.

As per proposed RBI framework, an eligible cooperative credit society must have minimum deposits of ₹10,000 crore, net worth of at least ₹300 crore, capital-to-risk-weighted assets ratio of at least 12%, net NPA ratio not crossing 3% and at least 10 years of operational existence.

According to an RBI Report, India had 1,457 UCBs at the end of March 2025 with a combined balance sheet of ₹7.38 lakh crore (deposits of ₹5.84 lakh crore and advances of ₹3.70 lakh crore).

Nvidia's clubby board faces sticky 'honey pot' test

NEWS ANALYSIS

Reuters

Revelations that Nvidia CEO Jensen Huang had an affair with a businesswoman suspected of being a Chinese spy have forced the chipmaker's board to confront more than ordinary executive misconduct, raising existential questions for the company and concerns about the board's ability to investigate its CEO independently.

Among corporate leaders, "There have definitely been affair scandals and sexual-harassment scandals. But honey-pot scandals? No," said Ann Lipton, a University of Colorado law professor who follows boardroom issues.

She was using a term for an espionage ploy in which an operative entraps a target by feigning romantic interest. Historical examples include the Profumo Affair in the early 1960s and tend to involve diplomatic or political consequences.



Under a cloud: Nvidia CEO Jensen Huang gestures on the day of the Invest in Germany Summit in Berlin, Germany. REUTERS FILE

U.S. President Donald Trump said on Monday the FBI was probing Huang's relationship, a day after Nvidia's board launched an internal investigation "regarding the national security concerns raised in news reports," according to an email Huang sent to Nvidia employees and released by the company.

The company's advanced semiconductors are at the heart of a global race for AI superiority. China's Foreign Ministry said the spying claim was "a groundless accusation, slander, and a smear."

Close ties to Trump

Nvidia co-founder Huang, 63, has no obvious successor and close ties to Trump. He owns 3.6% of its stock and has dozens of direct reports, suggesting a tight grip on the company.

Shares in Nvidia fell Monday as Huang's future came under scrutiny. But the stock later trimmed its decline to close 4% lower.

Board's credibility

Unusually among its peers, Nvidia operates without a board chair among its 11 directors. While the company considers all but Huang independent, three independent directors have served since the 1990s and a fourth, Mark Stevens, for most of that time. Only two have joined the board since 2021. The clubby roster may not be so unusual by standards of charismatic Silicon Valley company founders like Apple's Steve Jobs, who died in 2011.

But the U.S. probe has heightened scrutiny of whether directors who have worked alongside Huang for decades are sufficiently independent to investigate his conduct.

"If you have a figure like Steve Jobs, I think people on Wall Street as well as in Silicon Valley would say they're entitled to some leeway or deference," said Marc Goldstein, head of U.S. research for proxy adviser Institutional Shareholder Services.

Such deference could now raise questions about whether the board provided sufficient oversight of a CEO whose own judgment has come under scrutiny.

Nvidia said on Sunday that while its board had no reason to believe that either U.S. national security or Nvidia secrets were compromised, its inquiry would examine all available information.

Goldstein said board members running that investigation should be given the latitude to hire their own legal advisers to bolster their credibility.

The firm also might consider keeping long-serving directors away from the probe, he added, to avoid legal challenges from shareholders claiming it wasn't sufficiently independent.

China wants tech upper hand in sector with 80% global trade

NEWS ANALYSIS

Reuters
BEIJING/TOKYO

When world leaders fly in to the Chinese city of Shenzhen next week, they may catch a glimpse of China's vision for the future of global trade: a high-tech port humming with next-generation hardware and software.

The Mawan Terminal – complete with its driver less trucks, remote-controlled cranes and AI-powered systems – is among dozens of automated port operations across China that Beijing hopes will give it an edge in an industry that moves more than 80% of goods traded worldwide by volume.

Western officials and analysts, however, already wary of Beijing's sizeable stakes in ports around the world, fear its push to export its shipping technology could give it new leverage.

Strategic downside

"It's a very uncomfortable dependence, and it's one that could have major strategic downsides," said Isaac Kardon, an expert on China's maritime strategy with Institute for Defense Analyses, a U.S. government-funded think tank.

Those downsides range from Beijing gaining monopolistic positions in emerging technologies that could be used for economic coercion to exploiting back doors to spy on rivals or cripple trade networks in a crisis, Kardon said.



Tech power: A cargo ship moves through the Yantian port in Shenzhen, China. REUTERS

China's advance has not been smooth sailing. Reuters last month revealed the quiet collapse of LOGINK, a China-backed shipping data platform that some in Washington feared could become a trade super weapon.

But ahead of the Asia-Pacific Economic Cooperation summit in Shenzhen on November 18-19, Beijing is signalling that its ambitions to modernise maritime trade remain undimmed.

During preparatory meetings, China has proposed leading working groups on electronic bills of lading, digital versions of documents traditionally used as receipts for seaborne cargo and on customs databases powered by AI and big data.

"Whoever completes the digital transformation first will gain the upper hand in the next round of global port and shipping competition," China's transport ministry said in a May editorial published on its website. Beijing has cast its smart-port push as a way for countries to boost trade. China's transport ministry did not respond to a request for comment.

Leading edge

When it comes to automating ports, China says it's ahead. It is home to 60 automated terminals, more than any other nation, as per transport ministry.

Automated terminal

The jewel in the crown is the New Qianwan Container Terminal in the eastern city of Qingdao, which the ministry describes as the world's first fully automated terminal. China aims to have 90 automated terminals by 2030. The technology is already accelerating the flow of Chinese goods to global markets. Qianwan says each crane can handle 61 containers an hour, more than double the rate at conventional docks.

The United States, by comparison, has been slow to automate in ports, partly due to opposition from labour unions worried about job losses. A 2024 Government Accountability Office report to Congress found that the 10 biggest U.S. ports were less automated than their foreign peers.

"One key variable for China's speed of automation is the lack of pushback from independent unions who can slow or stop certain kinds of automation in other countries, like the U.S.," said Kyle Chan, a fellow in Chinese technology at the Brookings Institution think tank. China's network of high-tech ports also provides a vast testing ground for technologies its companies can sell abroad.

Chinese firms such as self-driving truck maker Westwell and telecoms equipment giant Huawei are packaging smart-port technology for overseas markets.

RAMALLAH

Israeli forces shoot dead teen in West Bank, say Palestinian officials



AP

Israeli forces shot dead a 14-year-old in the occupied West Bank, Palestinian officials said, with Israel saying it had acted to "thwart stone-hurling and terrorist attacks" in the area. Moutaz Eyad Daghlas was killed in Burqa, northwest of Nablus, late on Monday, the Palestinian Health Ministry said. AFP

DUBAI

Gulf Arab states approve military command headquarters in Kuwait



REUTERS

The six Gulf Cooperation Council (GCC) states have approved the establishment of an advanced headquarters for their Unified Military Command in Kuwait and the deployment of "appropriate" forces to it, the bloc's secretary-general said. The GCC comprises of Bahrain, Kuwait, Oman, Qatar, Saudi Arabia and the UAE. REUTERS

BANGKOK

Myanmar Army seizes resistance headquarters, 10 opposition bases



AP

Myanmar's military has seized a key resistance military command headquarters and 10 other bases along the border between Mon state and the Bago region, in the south of the country, state media reported on Tuesday, marking a new gain by the Army in the civil war as it seeks control of regions long held by resistance forces. AP

WASHINGTON

Pentagon chief Hegseth calls move to impeach him a farce, sabotage



AFP

U.S. Secretary of War Pete Hegseth on Tuesday called an effort to impeach him over abuse of power in the Iran war a farce and sabotage that plays into the hands of adversaries. Mr. Hegseth made the comments a day after U.S. Representative Thomas Massie introduced eight articles of impeachment against him. REUTERS

FBI probing Jensen Huang's affair with alleged Chinese agent: Trump

U.S. President says he spoke to the Nvidia CEO who told him that 'he had absolutely no idea that the person in question was a spy'; Huang earlier acknowledged he had an affair, issuing an apology to his wife and to the company in an open letter

Associated Press
WASHINGTON



Donald Trump stands with Jensen Huang after presenting him with the National Medal of Science in Washington on October 8. REUTERS

U.S. President Donald Trump said on Monday the FBI is investigating Nvidia CEO Jensen Huang's affair with an alleged Chinese government agent, but said he doesn't think the executive who has helped to develop artificial intelligence has a reason to worry.

"I know the FBI is looking into it in terms of something else, and I think that he'll be in good shape," Mr. Trump said at a White House briefing.

The sudden emergence of Huang's infidelity has rocked the political class and America's tech sector, creating new concerns about whether China has been able to access the cutting-edge chips designed by Nvidia that are powering the development of artificial intelligence.

Mr. Trump suggested the extraordinary step of directly involving himself in a counterintelligence investigation, a sign of his friendly relationship with Mr. Huang and the possible geopolitical stakes.

"I did speak to him today just to see if he's feeling all right, how you're doing," Mr. Trump said. "He said he had absolutely no idea that the person in question was a spy."

Mr. Huang – a singular figure in the technology landscape and one of the world's wealthiest people – has acknowledged he had an affair, issuing an apology to his wife and to the company in an open letter posted on Nvidia's website. The *New York Times* reported that U.S. intelligence determined that the woman was gathering information for Beijing.

"I support the investigation and will cooperate fully. I love our country and our company. I am committed to protecting NVIDIA and supporting America's national security," Mr. Huang said in his letter.

Nvidia announced Sunday it was conducting an independent investigation into reports that Mr. Huang was the "target of a foreign intelligence effort." The episode also is attracting congressional scrutiny, with top Democrats Sen. Mark Warner and Rep. Hakeem Jeffries saying they are interested in investigating it further.

Hasina will be executed if she returns: prosecutor

Agence France-Presse
DHAKA



Sheikh Hasina

The Bangladeshi prosecutor who secured the death sentence against ousted leader Sheikh Hasina said on Tuesday she will be executed if she returns home.

Ms. Hasina, whose 15-year rule was ended by a mass uprising she tried to crush, has vowed to return in December to Bangladesh, where she was convicted of crimes against humanity over the 2024 crackdown on protesters.

"Sheikh Hasina has no option but to face the execution of the verdict," Md Aminul Islam told pressmen, responding to reports she planned to return from self-imposed exile in neighbouring India.

He added that the 79-year-old fugitive had missed the deadline to appeal against her conviction, leaving her with no further legal recourse.

"The statutory appeal period has expired, and no appeal can now be filed," he said.

The daughter of a revolutionary who led Bangladesh to independence in 1971, Ms. Hasina presided over breakneck economic growth, helping transform the South Asian nation of 170 million people from a largely agricultural economy into a global manufacturing hub.

Critics have accused Ms. Hasina of jailing political rivals, enacting harsh anti-press laws and overseeing widespread human rights abuses, including the killing of Opposition activists.

She left to neighbouring India by helicopter in August 2024 as angry crowds stormed her palace. She has remained there ever since, hidden from public view. Only occasionally has she addressed news conferences by telephone, her voice sounding frail.

Ms. Hasina has repeatedly said she intends to return to Bangladesh in December, saying she is "fully aware" she faces being hanged if she returns.

Explosions heard in Riyadh; coalition says missile intercepted

Agence France-Presse
RIYADH

Multiple explosions rang out over the Saudi capital Riyadh early on Tuesday, as the coalition fighting Yemen's Houthis said it shot down a missile targeting the city, which has suffered weeks of disruptive attacks.

Residents received a mobile-phone alert urging them to shelter from an "aerial threat". The Saudi-led coalition said it intercepted a ballistic missile.

"Air defences intercepted and destroyed a ballistic missile launched by the terrorist Houthi militia towards Riyadh," the coalition posted on X.

The incident came two days after the Houthis (Ansar Allah) struck a psychological blow by hitting a skyscraper belonging to oil giant Aramco in Riyadh's gleaming financial district. Saudi authorities had earlier said the building was hit by falling shrapnel after an "attempted attack".

Saudi Arabia, the world's biggest oil exporter, has faced near-daily Houthi strikes since early October, including deadly attacks that closed Riyadh airport for two weeks.

Riyadh's schoolchildren, after two days back in the classroom, resumed online learning on Tuesday "as part of the ongoing precautionary measures".

Traffic snarl



The wreckage of vehicles following a multiple-vehicle collision in thick fog on the Trakia motorway near Zinnitsa, southeastern Bulgaria on Tuesday. Eleven people died and at least 51 were injured in the accident which occured on both sides of the expressway. AFP

Israel's Parliament sworn in as Eisenkot tries to forge a govt.

Reuters
JERUSALEM



Gadi Eisenkot

Israel's Parliament was sworn in on Tuesday without a new government, after a deadlocked general election stripped Prime Minister Benjamin Netanyahu of his parliamentary majority but left his main rivals with no clear path to power.

Lawmakers elected in the October 27 vote took their oaths of office as Gadi Eisenkot, a former general, sought to forge a coalition after Israel's President tasked him on Sunday with forming a government.

Mr. Eisenkot and his allies also lack a majority and he has yet to strike deals with parties that could bring him to power. If both Mr. Eisenkot and Mr. Netanyahu fail to form coalitions, another election could follow. Presiding over the swearing-in ceremony, President Isaac Herzog told lawmakers: "You must do everything to avoid a repeat election."

'U.S. Air Force relocates aircraft from base in eastern England due to threat'

Associated Press
LONDON



Members of the U.S. military work by an aircraft at RAF Mildenhall airbase in the U.K. on Tuesday. REUTERS

The U.S. Air Force has relocated aircraft from a base in eastern England because of a threat, U.S. officials told The Associated Press.

The Military Air Tracking Alliance, a team of about 30 open-source analysts that routinely analyses military and government flight activity, said that it spotted 13 U.S. aircraft stationed at RAF Mildenhall departing for bases in Scotland, Spain, and Germany. The *Wall Street Journal*, which first reported the evacuation, said that the threat related to Iran citing "people familiar with the matter".

The relocation of the aircraft came less than two months after the U.S. Air Force withdrew its bombers from another U.S.-run base in Britain, RAF Fairford, as police investigated a suspected terror plot linked to Iran.

Bombers flying out of RAF Fairford had been used to strike Iran during the West Asia conflict.

U.S. Secretary of State Marco Rubio said that the country is "constantly repositioning forces around the world for a variety of reasons," and referred questions to the Pentagon, which did not provide immediate confirmation.

Some of the aircraft that were relocated were permanently based at RAF Mildenhall, while others were there on rotation and included a combination of Osprey aircraft and mid-air refuelling tankers, the Military Air Tracking Alliance said.

The base has also raised its alert level to FPCON Charlie – the second highest level – the organisation said. That applies when an incident occurs or intelligence is received indicating that some form of terrorist action targeting personnel or facilities is likely.

David Walliams, British comedian and author, accused of sexual misconduct

Associated Press
LONDON



David Walliams

British children's author and comedian David Walliams used his fame to groom girls and young women for sex, two British news outlets reported on Tuesday.

ITV News and the *Guardian* newspaper said their joint investigation featured interviews with multiple women who gave first-hand accounts of Mr. Walliams' conduct. One woman alleged she was sexually assaulted by Mr. Walliams at his London home when she was 15, while others accused him of grooming them when they were teens.

Mr. Walliams, 55, denied the allegations. He unsuccessfully sought a court injunction to bar the news outlets from identifying him, claiming that publication of sexual misconduct allegations would lead him to take his own life.

The court fight delayed publication for months, but a judge rejected his injunction request last week and the protection of his identity expired late Monday.

"I am not a sexual predator," Mr. Walliams said in a letter to the news organisations. "I have not broken the law, but I am devastated that some of the women I met 10 to 20 years ago have now expressed hurt or anger towards me."

The Metropolitan Police in London contacted the news organisations on Tuesday to make sure any possible victims knew how to report criminal allegations.

Attorney Gavin Millar, representing the media companies, has said that the allegations were gathered after "a wide-ranging and rigorous investigation" and that there was a strong public interest in publishing them.

Mr. Millar told the court that the investigation involved speaking to more than 100 people, and alleged that over a period of years Mr. Walliams "used his status and influence as a well-known public figure to establish contact with young women, some considerably younger than him, and that he engaged or sought to engage in seriously inappropriate conduct," according to a summary of the court judgment.

Some of the alleged conduct could amount to criminal offenses if proven, the summary of the court judgment said.



Smog rider: A man drives a motorised tricycle amid air pollution in Lahore, Pakistan, on Monday. REUTERS

Pakistan blames Deepavali fireworks in India for toxic air

Reuters
ISLAMABAD/NEW DELHI

Pakistan blamed poor air quality this week on pollution drifting from neighbouring India, where firecrackers set off during the Deepavali festival over the weekend blanketed much of the north in toxic smog.

The northern Pakistani city of Lahore topped Swiss group IQAir's ranking of the world's most polluted major cities for a second day on Tuesday, with an air quality index (AQI) of 263, categorised as "very unhealthy".

The city's concentration of PM2.5, harmful airborne particles small enough to penetrate deep into the lungs, was 37.2 times above the World Health Organization's guidelines, IQAir said.

Pakistani Punjab's Environment Protection Minister Marriyum Aurangzeb said pollutants had been carried into the region by light winds and air drifting from India in the aftermath of Deepavali.

"However, air pollution is expected to gradually decrease from early afternoon as weather conditions improve and winds shift direction," she said.

The External Affairs Ministry did not immediately respond to a request for comment.

IQAir ranked Delhi the world's second-most polluted major city on Tuesday, with an AQI of 188. The Government data showed that firecrackers were responsible for nearly 55% of the PM2.5 in the capital a day earlier.

Vehicle emissions, construction dust and smoke from crop-waste burning are also major contributors to winter pollution on both sides of the border.

After midterm maelstrom, U.S. House Republicans to choose new leadership

Steve Scalise and Jim Jordan campaign for party leadership in the new Congress as the Republican Party looks to rebuild from recent midterm loss; GOP prepares for a minority role as Democrats take over the Senate and House of Representatives; Democrats to hold leadership polls next week

Associated Press
WASHINGTON

U.S. House Republicans will move on Tuesday to select their leader in the minority after a brutal drubbing at the polls, with the two candidates being House Majority Leader Steve Scalise of Louisiana and Judiciary Committee Chairman Jim Jordan of Ohio.

Mr. Scalise and Mr. Jordan have faced off before, both running to serve as House Speaker after Kevin McCarthy was ousted from the job a little more than three years ago. Neither was able to rally the support necessary to secure the position, which eventually went to Mike Johnson.

Now Republicans are headed into the minority, changing the nature of the job. The winner of the leadership race will inherit a historically small House Republican conference that is only beginning to grapple with its loss of power as President Donald Trump serves out his final two years in office. Leading the party back to the House majority in 2028 is sure to be a stiff climb, given the scope of Democratic victories in the midterms.

Mr. Scalise, 61, has held key GOP leadership positions going back to 2014, serving as party whip and then as majority leader. In 2017, he was critically wounded when a gunman opened fire at a baseball practice where several Republican lawmakers were preparing for an annual charity game against Democrats. In 2023, he was stricken with blood cancer that was successfully treated.

"Overcoming adversity is nothing new to me," Mr. Scalise said.

Mr. Jordan, 62, is a co-founder of the ultraconservative House Freedom Caucus and served as its first chairman. He has been the chairman of the House Judiciary Committee for the last four years.

"Our job cannot be merely to spotlight how radical this new Democratic Party is – offence, not defence, wins elections," Mr. Jordan said.

Both men have been here before. Mr. Scalise ended up withdrawing from the Speaker's race three years ago after some of the more conservative members declined to back him following Mr. Trump's endorsement of Mr. Jordan. Mr. Trump was not President at the time, but his voice still carried the most weight for many.

Mr. Jordan then became the nominee, but others within the conference were adamant they would not reward the hard-ball tactics used to topple Mr. McCarthy and then Mr. Scalise, so he fell short in multiple rounds of votes. Eventually, Republicans turned to a new face who was not part of their internal skirmish – Mr. Johnson.



Face-off: Jim Jordan, party House representative for Ohio, (left) and Steve Scalise (Louisiana) have emerged as contenders for the top Republican post in the U.S. House of Representatives. AP

Political pitches

In a letter to colleagues, Mr. Scalise emphasised that he was ready to lead on Day One of the next Congress. He cited his work in helping deliver legislative wins, such as Mr. Trump's big tax and spending cut bill.

He also emphasised his fundraising prowess, noting he raised $67.9 million for this year's midterms, with about a third of that going directly to individual House campaigns and the National Republican Congressional Committee. He said his grassroots fundraising operation is the most prolific among House Republicans.

"In competitive districts, every dollar counts and those resources are critical to winning back the majority," Mr. Scalise said.

Mr. Jordan warned of the coming Democratic efforts on oversight, with numerous investigations of the Trump administration expected.

"I am battle-tested on the oversight front and I know the Democrats' playbook," Mr. Jordan said.

Rep. Andy Harris of Maryland said he would be supporting Mr. Jordan.

"I think you need to change the team and I think you need an excellent communicator, and he fits both those bills," Mr. Harris said.

Rep. Mike Kelly of Pennsylvania said he believes Mr. Scalise is better suited for the job.

"I like people who do legislation and appropriations. I think that's important," Mr. Kelly said. "I know other people have maybe had more time on Fox, but I like guys that work more on facts."

Rep. Steve Womack of Arkansas called it a "really, really close race."

"There's a school of thought a lot of members have that a new broom sweeps clean after going through what we just went through last Tuesday," Mr. Womack said.

"There's also a school of thought of people that believe Mr. Scalise, who has led us back before, can do it again."

House Speaker Johnson said he was close to both men and would not try to dictate the outcome.

"I want the body, I want the members to make those decisions themselves," Mr. Johnson said. "I'm not weighing in here on the leadership elections."

Other positions

In addition to the race for minority leader, Reps. Tom Emmer of Minnesota and August Pfluger of Texas are vying to serve as Republican whip, the No. 2 position in the leadership hierarchy. Three candidates are seeking to serve as conference chair: Reps. Lisa McClain of Michigan, Erin Houchin of Indiana and Greg Steube of Florida.

Democrats will hold their leadership elections next week.

Rep. Hakeem Jeffries of New York is expected to become the next House speaker, the first African-American to hold the job, and Rep. Katherine Clark of Massachusetts is expected to become the next majority leader. She would be the first woman to hold that position.

U.S. draws criticism as it boycotts UN Human Rights Council review, again

Agence France-Presse
GENEVA

The United States boycotted on Tuesday a United Nations review of its human rights record for a second time, in an unprecedented snub of a process that all countries traditionally submit to.

U.S. seats were left empty at the world body's European headquarters in Geneva for the so-called Universal Periodic Review (UPR), which all 193 UN member states undergo every four to five years.

As the review was set to begin, UN Human Rights Council president Sidharto Reza Suryodipuro, of Indonesia, looked at the empty seats behind the U.S. nameplate and noted that "the delegation of the U.S. is not present in the room".



Empty seat of the U.S. delegation during the 60th session of the council, at the UN European base in Geneva, in 2025. AP

President Donald Trump's administration decided shortly after his return to power in 2025 to halt cooperation with the rights council, and had already boycotted the UPR process last November.

In response, the council at the time had postponed the U.S. review for a year, in the hope that Washington would return to the fold, but to no avail.

But the U.S. State Department told AFP that the administration considers the council an "irredeemable body" that "makes a mockery of human rights", suggesting that it would not participate in any of its mechanisms, including the UPR.

Washington's complete non-compliance with the process is unprecedented.

Critics of the U.S. snub warn that the walkout could encourage other countries – many of which bristle about intense scrutiny from human rights monitors – to follow suit.

Jamil Dakwar, director of the American Civil Liberties Union's human rights program, said: "The administration is saying to the world, 'we don't care about whether you would review us or not, we're going to continue to violate human rights unabashed'." *(With inputs from AP)*

Sacred glow



Cultural mosaic: Hindu devotees offer prayers to Lokenath Brahmachari, a Hindu saint and philosopher, as they observe the Rakher Upobash festival at a temple in Dhaka, Bangladesh, on Tuesday. REUTERS

Residents of Turkish province despair at being Europe's plastic dumpyard

Agence France-Presse
ADANA

At first glance, the canal near which Ibrahim Yildiz grazes his sheep in the southern Adana province appears idyllic, framed by rows of clementine trees – until the mountains of plastic shavings come into view.

"It's been like this for a decade. Around here, we call it the 'canal of filth'. My animals no longer produce milk," sighed the 65-year-old shepherd.

As the leading destination for plastic waste from the European Union, with 510,000 tonnes imported in 2025, alongside another 140,000 tonnes from Britain, Turkiye has become "Europe's dumping ground," environmental campaigners say as the two-week UN COP31 climate conference starts in Antalya.

Valued at $105 million in 2025 by the European Commission, this trade is polluting both the Mediterranean and the Turkish agricultural landscape – largely through non-recyclable plastics.

Abandoned in nature or burnt in the open air, the waste is transformed into mountains of filthy plastic shavings. Poorly shredded, the remains often reveal their origins: a plastic pack of French ham, an empty crisp bag from Austria, a used sachet of tomato sauce from Britain.

Nearly 60 percent of this waste is transported to Adana, where around 170 recycling companies are located in the heart of this fertile farmland that produces more a third of Turkiye's citrus fruits.

According to marine biologist Sedat Gundogdu of the Microplastics Research Group (GRM), the particles are carried by rivers and floods from Adana to the Mediterranean, where they could be seen building up along the Turkish coast this summer.

"We measured microplastic concentrations in the Mediterranean up to 65 times higher than levels previously seen. Up to 93 percent come from waste shredded at recycling centres," he said.

"It's an ecological disaster because it's permanent. Once it reaches the sea, the entire Mediterranean is polluted."

'A form of colonialism'

But Environment Minister Murat Kurum denied rubbish was being imported, instead saying what did come in was recyclable matter in a form that could be used as raw material.



A recycling facility in Adana, Turkiye. Experts say EU plastic waste exports pollute the Mediterranean and local agricultural land. AFP

"We absolutely do not allow waste imports. What does come in? Ground granule material which is used as raw material in production," he told journalists in October..

Where illegal waste imports had been identified in Adana, "we have closed down the businesses we identified and we have imposed penalties," he said.

But Mr. Gundogdu said fines and inspections were not enough. "We need to end the waste trade once and for all, it's a new form of colonialism," he said.

"Only nine percent of plastics are recyclable. Trying to recycle a material designed to be thrown away is expensive. That's why Europe sends them to other countries. In this case, recycling is an illusion."

'Can't breathe'

In Kucukdikili, a deprived suburb of Adana, residents say enough is enough, accusing the recycling firms of routinely burning waste in the open air which they portray as the result of accidental fires.

Nearly 200 fires are recorded every year at recycling plants across Turkiye, a GRM count shows.

"Adana is not Europe's dumping ground!" protesters chanted at a demonstration in August.

Murat Esin, who lives next to a recycling site, has taken his complaints to the highest level of the Turkish government, but says nothing has been done.

"We can't breathe because of the smell and the ash that covers everything. Cancer cases are multiplying here, but nobody listens to us," he said.

Environmental activist Yasar Gokoglu says burning the waste is the cheapest way of getting rid of it.

"Incineration is the only way for these companies to get rid of non-recyclable waste for free. Europeans might be easing their consciences by sorting their waste. But they need to know their waste ends up poisoning us."

At COP31, First Lady Emine Erdogan's "Zero Waste" campaign will be a key element of Turkiye's agenda, the Environment Ministry says.

"Plastic waste imported for recycling must be processed without harming the environment, and waste management systems must be effectively monitored and traceable," said Samed Agirbas, president of the Zero Waste Foundation.

Yet an EU ban on exporting plastic waste to non-OECD countries, which comes into force on November 21, looks set to further increase the waste sent to member country Turkiye.

"COP31 offers an opportunity," Mr. Gundogdu said.

"A call to end the waste trade would put Turkiye in a leadership position. The goal of zero waste can only be achieved by ending these imports."

FAMILIAR CONDITIONS

Weather and wickets in NZ remind Kamboj of home base



CREIMAS/BCCI

India pacer Anshul Kamboj feels quite at ease with the cold weather and seamer-friendly pitches in New Zealand that remind him of the peak winter season at his base in Lahli. “It’s a similar kind of, what can I say, weather and wickets as well in Haryana (during winter at Lahli),” Kamboj said.

SHOT IN THE ARM

Fit-again Pant likely to depart for New Zealand tomorrow



ANI

India’s Test team is set to get a big boost as Rishabh Pant, in all likelihood, will leave for New Zealand on Thursday. “Pant is fit and he is undergoing the match simulation drills at the CoE (Centre of Excellence). Upon successful completion of both rounds, he will leave for Wellington on Thursday,” said a BCCI source.

INJURY WOES

Jamieson laments Kiwis’ inability to field the same set of bowlers



AP

Kiwi pacer Kyle Jamieson has rued the host’s inability to field a consistent bowling unit in the white-ball series against India. “It’s a wee bit of frustration, right? You’re trying to always put a similar attack out and you sort of can build that camaraderie and cohesion. We haven’t had the reps (repetitions) that we’d like,” he said.

TOP OF THE PODIUM

Indian women clinch the gold medal in the 25m pistol team event



SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

India clinched the women’s 25m pistol team gold after Manu Bhaker, Esha Singh and Divya Thadigol Subbaraju (1,761 points) finished ahead of Korea (1,748) and Vietnam (1,745) at the ISSF World championships in Doha on Tuesday. Manu missed out on an LA Olympics quota as she came fourth in individual 25m pistol.



Playing spoilsport: Rain had the last word at Seddon Park. AP

Team India takes an unassailable lead after rain mars play

Gill elects to bowl but persistent downpour forces the umpires to call off the game; both teams to field depleted squads in the last two matches

INDIA IN NZ

Press Trust of India
HAMILTON

Rain played spoilsport as the third One-Day International (ODI) between New Zealand and India at Seddon Park was abandoned here on Tuesday.

India leads the five-match series 2-0 as the two teams head to Tauranga for the final two games scheduled for Friday and Sunday. The Men in Blue have thus taken an unassailable lead in the rubber.

India skipper Shubman Gill won the toss for the third time in a row and opted to bowl, fielding an unchanged side from the previous two games. New Zealand made one change to its line-up, with pacer Matt Fisher coming in for Blair Tickner.

However, just as the covers were coming off for a 40-overs-a-side contest, the heavens opened up again. With 70 minutes remaining before the local cut-off time of 7.50 p.m. for a 20-overs-a-side game, the two umpires decided to call off the match.

The weather forecast for this match had been gloomy, with a 90% chance of rain predicted throughout the day.

This was the last game of the series for Gill and senior wicketkeeper K.L. Rahul before they link up with the Test squad in Wellington. They will be accompanied by Kuldeep Yadav, Anshul Kamboj and Mohammed Siraj.

Shreyas Iyer will lead the side in the last two ODIs, with Ruturaj Gaikwad and Ishan Kishan expected to be drafted into the playing XI.

The Black Caps will be without Daryl Mitchell, Glenn Phillips, Henry Nicholls, Tom Latham and Nathan Smith as they attempt to level the series. The five players are set to join the Test squad.

Things have been a little difficult after the T20 WC: Suryakumar

Shayan Acharya
MUMBAI

For someone who led India to the T20 World Cup title earlier this year, the months that followed have not been easy.

Suryakumar Yadav has found himself away from the national team reckoning, a difficult phase for a cricketer who had scaled the highest peak in the shortest format.

But he is not shying away from acknowledging the challenge. “Things have been a little difficult after the T20 World Cup. I don’t want to run away from that fact. If you are not honest with yourself, it is very difficult to lead a happy life. So, it has been very difficult,” Suryakumar said at the T20 Mumbai ‘Celebrating the Champions’ event on Tuesday, where a new team from Navi Mumbai was launched.



Suryakumar.
FILE PHOTO: EMMANUAL YOGINI

> If you are not honest with yourself, it is very difficult to lead a happy life. So, it has been very difficult

Welcome change

The birth of his daughter in May, during the IPL, brought a welcome change. “The last few months, since she was born, have been very beautiful,” he said.

A conversation with his wife also helped Suryakumar rediscover the love and passion he had as a 15-year-old aspiring to represent Mumbai. “She felt I needed to bring back the love and passion for the game that I had when I was a kid who wanted to represent Mumbai in the under-15 cricket team,” Suryakumar said.

As he gears up to lead Mumbai in the Syed Mushtaq Ali Trophy, beginning on Saturday, Suryakumar has a clear aim. “The main goal is what I used to think about earlier: win games for Mumbai and win the championship for Mumbai,” he said.

He also had a message for youngsters increasingly drawn towards the IPL.

“I feel the end goal, or even the first goal, should never be to think about playing in the IPL. Everyone dreams of playing for India,” he said, emphasising the importance of progressing through age-group and domestic cricket.

Aaryavir’s stroke-filled knock powers India into semifinals

UNDER-19 ASIA CUP

Press Trust of India
AL AMERAT

Aaryavir Sehwag smashed 160 off 168 balls (17x4, 7x6) for his maiden hundred in youth ODIs as India entered the semifinals of the ACC under-19 Asia Cup with a comfortable 70-run win over the UAE here on Tuesday.

India will face Afghanistan in the semifinal on Thursday.

Having lost to Pakistan on Sunday, India found itself in a must-win situation against the UAE.

Aaryavir, son of Virender Sehwag, helped India post 309 for seven, a total which was beyond the opposition. The UAE was bowled out for 239 in 50 overs.



Aaryavir, right. X@BCCI

Aaryavir took his time early before producing a barrage of boundaries.

He took 14 balls to get off the mark, opening his account with a boundary towards the mid-wicket region off Hadayatullah Khan. In fact he played out 97 dot balls in his innings.

Aaryavir had made an unbeaten 70 in the win over Nepal before tallying 22 against Pakistan.

After getting to the landmark Aaryavir bossed the bowlers.

His next 60 runs came off just 37 deliveries.

The other major contribution came from V.K. Vineeth (67, 69b, 3x4, 3x6).

In response, the UAE was never in contention despite Ahmed Khudabad’s run-a-ball 74 (6x4, 3x6).

The scores: India 309/7 in 50 overs (Aaryavir Sehwag 160, V.K. Vineeth 67, Naseem Khan 4/48) bt UAE 239 in 50 overs (Ahmed Khudabad 74, Ishan Sood 4/37). **Toss:** UAE; **PoM:** Aaryavir.

Nominations open for Best PSU/ Educational Institutions/ Corporate for Promotion of Sport

Sports Bureau

The nominations for the *Sportstar* ACES Awards 2027, presented by *The Hindu* Group, for the coveted “Best PSU/Educational Institutions/Corporate for Promotion of Sport” honour are open.

Behind every sporting triumph lies a community of silent supporters, without whom success would remain out of reach. It is built on the sustained support of coaches, administrators, institutions, and countless silent contributors who work behind the scenes.

At *Sportstar*, we believe these quiet enablers of Indian sport are as important as the champions on the podium.

It is this spirit that we celebrate every year at our flagship *Sportstar* Aces Awards. Past winners include corporates like JSW and GMR Sports, PSUs like IndianOil and NTPC Limited, and educational institutions like SRM University and Kalinga Institute of Industrial Technology, among others.

Eligible contenders can submit their entries and success stories on *Sportstar*’s official awards portal. Scan the QR code to apply.

Delhi HC disposes of contempt plea against AITA office-bearers

N. Sudarshan
BENGALURU

The Delhi High Court, on Friday, disposed of the contempt petition filed by players Somdev Devvarman and Purav Raja against the All India Tennis Association’s (AITA) interim office-bearers after the AITA gave an undertaking that all information sought by administrator Justice (retd.) Gita Mittal has been provided, and that it would continue to do so until the end of the administrator’s tenure (November 27).

To Justice Mittal’s request to implead the AITA Trust and the Delhi Lawn Tennis Association for corruption, the HC is learnt to have said that the allegations could be probed by the new AITA body that will take charge after elections, and it could re-engage Justice Mittal if required.

The administrator, in a report dated September 14, had submitted to the Court that looking into the matters of the AITA Trust was a necessary step under her Court-mandated “obligation to supervise the financial affairs of AITA” because the AITA had “assigned and abdicated all its functions, properties and income to the AITA Trust”.

Polls under the amended AITA Constitution are scheduled to be held on November 27, with the filing of nominations for the Executive Committee and Athletes Committee elections beginning on Saturday.

Next hearing on Jan. 22

The HC is scheduled to hear the matter again on January 22, 2027, and all actions pertaining to amending the Constitution in line with the National Sports Governance Act and elections will be subject to the final outcome of the case.

Carlsen heads the field as Total Chess World Championship Tour pilot begins

Jayantho Sengupta
BUDAPEST

Magnus Carlsen is in Budapest this week for a new tournament in which knockout-round action will take the players from blitz to rapid to a shortened form of classical chess in a single day.

The world No. 1 heads a 24-player field at the Total Chess World Championship Tour pilot, which carries a prize fund of $650,000.

R. Praggnanandhaa, Arjun Erigaisi and R. Vaishali are the three Indians in the field. For Vaishali, the event comes between her victory at the Women’s Candidates in April and her World title match against Ju Wenjun. She and Kazakhstan’s Bibisara Assaubayeva are the two women in a field that also includes Fabiano Caruana, Wesley So, Nodirbek Abdusattorov and Hungary’s Richard Rapport.

Tuesday’s opening programme featured nine rounds of blitz, with the standings used to break ties in the group stage. From Wednesday, the players will compete in four groups of six, facing each opponent in their group twice over five days.



Praggnanandhaa.



Carlsen.



Vaishali.



Arjun.

Each game will be played at the Fast Classic time control, with 45 minutes per player and 30 seconds added after every move.

A win earns three points and a draw one. Only the four group winners will contest for the title. The rest will play for the lower places.

Two-day affair

Each knockout match runs over two days, with four blitz games, two rapid games and one Fast Classic game each day. Wins carry more weight at longer time controls, so an early lead in blitz can disappear in the evening. An Armageddon game will settle any match still tied.

The pilot runs at the Anantara New York Palace Hotel until November 20.

The full tour is due to begin in 2027, with the top four in the standings qualifying for the Grand Final to play for the FIDE World Combined Championship.

(*The writer is in Budapest at the invitation of Total Chess*).

‘No plans to switch federations as of now’

Jayantho Sengupta
BUDAPEST

American Grandmaster Abhimanyu Mishra said he has no current plans to switch federations, explaining that his earlier comments referred to a hypothetical situation.

“Actually, this was a huge miscommunication. Essentially, as of now, I don’t want to switch federations at all,” Abhimanyu told *The Hindu* on the sidelines of the Total Chess World Championship Tour pilot here.

He said his response to that hypothetical question was that he might consider a switch. “But the thing is, this does not mean that I’m searching to change federation at all currently,” he said.

Abhimanyu also spoke about playing simultaneous exhibitions to help cover expenses. The sessions, which involved taking on several opponents and could last hours, provided some income but were tiring.



Abhimanyu. FIDE

In Budapest, Abhimanyu has been drawn in Group C alongside Magnus Carlsen, Anish Giri, Ian Nepomniachtchi, Haik M. Martirosyan and Shakhriyar Mamedyarov. He will face each opponent twice in the Fast Classic group stage.

The chance to play Carlsen twice was particularly appealing, with Abhimanyu describing it as a source of joy and a learning experience. The strength of the field had convinced him to accept the invitation. “I mean, saying no to a tournament like this is a bit ridiculous, honestly,” he said.

INBRIEF



Coach Kompany returns to Bayern's training ground

Bayern Munich coach Vincent Kompany returned to the club's training ground on Tuesday for the first time since he collapsed during practice last month. The 40-year-old Kompany had medical appointments at the Sabener Street complex, *Kicker* magazine reported, as he took another step toward his planned return.

NZ-A-India-A 'Test' series ends with honours even

The thee-match 'Test' series between New Zealand-A and India-A ended in a draw as the final game finished in a stalemate after the fourth day was washed out in Lincoln on Tuesday. No play was possible on the third day too. All three 'Tests' were drawn.

The scores: India-A 464/5 decl. drew with New Zealand-A 36/2 in 14 overs.

Gayatri-Treesa pair advances into pre-quarterfinals

The Indian women's doubles pair of Gayatri Gopichand and Treesa Jolly progressed to the pre-quarterfinals with a straight-game win over home favourites Hinata Suzuki and Nao Yamakita in the opening round of the Kumamoto Masters Japan Super 500 badminton tournament in Kumamoto on Tuesday. The Indian combination, which won a bronze at this year's BWF World Championships, prevailed 21-17, 21-14 in a round-of-32 clash. It was, however, curtains for the mixed doubles pair of Dhruv Kapila and Radhika Sharma, who went down 16-21, 15-21 to the second-seeded American pair of Chen Zhi Yi and Francesca Corbett in the opening round of qualifying. The men's doubles pair of A. Hariharan and M.R. Arjun made it to the next round after their round-of-32 opponents, Malaysia's Aaron Chia and Soh Wooi Yik, retired hurt just six minutes into the match. The Indians were leading 11-6 in the opening game.

Richa to lead 15-member East Zone squad

Richa Ghosh will lead a 15-member East Zone side in the senior women's inter-zonal T20 Trophy matches to be held in Guwahati from November 24 to December 4.

The squad: Richa Ghosh (Capt. & wk), Titas Sadhu, Tanusree Sarkar, Mita Paul, Payel Vakharia (all Bengal), Jinti Moni Kalita, Khushi Sharma, Uma Chettri (wk) (all Assam), Aishwarya Singh, Shanti Kumari (both Jharkhand), Tanmayee Behera, Sushree Divya Darshini, Subhra Swain (all Odisha), Mouchaity Debnath (Tripura), and Apurva Kumari (Bihar).
Standbys: Arya Seth (Bihar), Amantika Munda (Assam), Khushbu (Jharkhand), Indra Rani Jamatia (Tripura), and Ananya Mishra (Odisha).

FIA chief says Qatar and Abu Dhabi GPs to go ahead

The final races of the Formula One season in Qatar and Abu Dhabi will go ahead as planned, FIA president Mohammed Ben Sulayem said on Tuesday. The last two Grands Prix of the year are scheduled for November 29 in Qatar and December 6 in Abu Dhabi. The Saudi Arabia Grand Prix earlier this year was scrapped while the Bahrain race was delayed and moved to Malaysia. "We are ready for Qatar and Abu Dhabi," Ben Sulayem said on social media. "We are fully prepared and committed to delivering two outstanding GPs and a spectacular conclusion to the Formula One World Championship. We look forward to welcoming drivers, teams and fans to two iconic circuits for an unforgettable finish to the season. See you on the grid."

Messi makes it back-to-back MLS Golden Boot awards

Lionel Messi has been awarded the 2026 MLS Golden Boot, becoming the first player in the league's history to win the award in consecutive seasons. The Inter Miami forward scored a league-high 26 goals this season. He also notched up 17 assists and led the league with 43 goal contributions.

LIVE TELECAST

Pakistan vs. Sri Lanka: First Test, Day 3, VETO App, 9.30 a.m.

SAFF Championships: India vs. Maldives, VETO App, 3 & 7.30 p.m.

Sabalenka digs deep to beat Muchova; Andreeva on song

The Belarusian, who is out of contention for the year-end No. 1 ranking despite Rybakina's absence, wins in two tight sets; the Russian sweeps past Svitolina on her tournament debut

WTA FINALS

Associated Press
INDIAN WELLS

Aryna Sabalenka defeated Karolina Muchova 7-6(2), 7-5 for her first win at the 2026 WTA Finals on Monday.

The former World No. 1, who will next face No. 3 seed Mirra Andreeva, got through two close sets to beat Muchova in 1 hour, 53 minutes.

Staying calm

"I was just trying to stay calm," said Sabalenka, who won the BNP Paribas Open at Indian Wells in March. "She can come back at any time and you have to be focused from the beginning."

The No. 2-ranked Sabalenka will end the season without a Grand Slam title for the first time since 2022, and she is out of contention for the WTA year-end No. 1 ranking despite rival Elena Rybakina's withdrawal from the WTA Finals due to a viral illness.

But the 28-year-old can claim a first season-ending title after two runner-up finishes (2022, 2025).



On the ball: Andreeva was in command throughout against Svitolina. REUTERS

Sabalenka opened Group 2 round-robin play against Muchova, the only player in the eight-woman field with a winning head-to-head against the four-time Grand Slam champion.

Muchova, who is making her WTA Finals debut, twice led by a break in the opening set, but Sabalenka broke in response each time.

A tight second set featured five service breaks and Muchova battling from 5-3 down to 5-5. Sabalenka responded with a forehand winner to break for 6-5.

Andreeva followed Sabalenka into the winner's circle with a 6-4, 6-0 victory over Ukraine's Elina Svitolina in her WTA Finals debut. The 19-year-old French Open champion avenged an Australian Open loss to Svitolina, the 2018 WTA Finals champion, saving all six break points she faced over two sets.

"I was so tight, I felt I was moving like a turtle. I'm happy to get through the match and control my emotions," Andreeva said.

Carrick set to be sacked by Manchester United, say reports

Agence France-Presse
LONDON

Michael Carrick is set to be sacked by Manchester United after his side's dismal start to the season, according to reports on Tuesday.

United's hierarchy has been conducting an internal review of the club's miserable form and it is believed that Carrick will shortly be relieved of his duties.

The team is in the midst of its worst opening to a campaign in 40 years, leaving it languishing in the Premier League relegation zone after an eight-match winless run.

Although it is believed that no final decision has been made, chief executive Omar Berrada and director of football Jason Wilcox are reportedly leaning towards dismissing Carrick.

United owners, the Glazer family, and influential shareholder, Jim Ratcliffe, would then decide whether to act on that recommendation.

The 45-year-old, hired on a permanent basis in the close season after a successful interim spell last term, had been granted a stay of execution after he was widely expected to be axed in late October following a 0-3 home defeat by Bournemouth.



Carrick. REUTERS

United's surprise decision to let Carrick continue did not witness a significant improvement in performance, particularly in defence. United was beaten 0-2 at Chelsea before scrambling to a 3-2 win against Roma in the Champions League after trailing by two goals.

United has the rest of the two-week international break to secure a replacement for Carrick. It will meet Liverpool on November 22.

CA chief rules out reopening the Sandpapergate probe

Agencies
SYDNEY

Cricket Australia chief Todd Greenberg on Tuesday ruled out reopening the investigation into the Sandpapergate ball-tampering scandal, saying he did not see "any compelling reason" for a new probe.

Former opening batter Usman Khawaja said in his autobiography that the 2018 plot had been common knowledge throughout the team and not limited to a small number of players.

The book, released on Tuesday, has reignited the debate over the cheating controversy, in which Australian players were caught using sandpaper to make the ball swing against South Africa.

Greenberg said he would consider Khawaja's revelations – which were on Monday backed as "100% accurate" by David Warner – but said there was no need for further action. "We don't see any compelling reason to open the investigation or revisit this again," he told radio station *SEN*.

Starc denies assertions

"My recollection hasn't changed," said Mitchell Starc as he rejected Khawaja's assertions that the entire Australian team was a part of the 2018 Sandpapergate conspiracy even though only three players ended up being punished for the scandal.

Bansari picked as Savita rested for women's Asian Champions Trophy

HOCKEY

Press Trust of India
NEW DELHI

Veteran goalkeeper Savita Punia has been rested from the women's Asian Champions Trophy in Bhopal and will be replaced by Bansari Solanki in the Indian hockey squad named on Tuesday, with head coach Sjoerd Marijne also announcing changes to the roles of some players during the event.

The tournament is scheduled from November 19 to 28 at the newly-built International Sports Complex, Nathu Barkheda, and India will enter as the defending champion. The team will begin its campaign against Malaysia on the opening day.



Bansari.

Midfielder Salima Tete will continue to lead the team, which will be playing its first international tournament after the historic gold medal at the Asian Games in Japan last month.

India won the ACT in 2016, 2023 and 2024.

The six-team competition will feature India, China, Japan, Malaysia, Thailand and South Korea.

The 25-year-old Bansari has been part of the squad that won the Asia Cup last year. Bichu Devi Kharibam retained her place as the other custodian in the squad.

As part of the role shuffling, Rutuja Dadaso Pisal, who played as a forward in the Asian Games, has been named in the midfield for ACT. Similarly, midfielder Nikki Pradhan is part of the defensive line-up, while Ishika Chaudhary has been moved from defence to midfield.

The ACT will follow a round-robin format, with each team playing the other five outfits once. The top four at the end of the league stage will qualify for the semifinals. The first day will see China take on Thailand in the tournament-opener before the India-Malaysia clash following an opening ceremony.

The semifinals will be played on November 27 and the medal matches on November 28.

The squad: Goalkeepers: Bansari Solanki, Bichu Devi Kharibam; **Defenders:** Nikki Pradhan, Jyoti, Jyoti Singh, Sushila Chanu, Lalthantluangi, Pooja Sahoo; **Midfielders:** Rutuja Dadaso Pisal, Sunelita Toppo, Salima Tete (capt.), Neha, Sakshi Rana, Baljeeet Kaur, Ishika; **Forwards:** Navneet Kaur, Deepika, Beauty Dungdung, Lalremsiami, Mumtaz Khan.
India's matches: Nov. 19: Vs. Malaysia; **Nov. 21:** Vs. South Korea; **Nov. 22:** Vs. Malaysia; **Nov. 24:** Vs. China; **Nov. 25:** Vs. Japan.
Semifinals: Nov. 27; **Medal matches:** Nov. 28.

India begins AFC u-17 Asian Cup Qualifiers against Singapore

Press Trust of India
KUALA LUMPUR

India will begin its AFC under-17 Asian Cup Qualifiers' Group E campaign against Singapore on Wednesday, aiming to secure back-to-back appearances in the continental football tournament. Hosts Malaysia, Palestine and Guam are the other teams in the fray. India will next face Guam on November 14, Palestine on Nov. 17 and Malaysia on Nov. 20.

Only the group winner will progress to the AFC u-17 Asian Cup, scheduled to be held in Uzbekistan from May 12 to 29, 2027.

The Blue Colts head into the Qualifiers following an extensive preparation under the newly-appointed head coach Mehrajuddin Wadoo. Among the five teams in Group E, India are the only side to have qualified for the AFC U17 Asian Cup in 2026.

'Chennai likely to host 2029 Asian athletics c'ships'

Sports Bureau
CHENNAI

Chennai is likely to host the Asian athletics (men & women) championships in 2029 at the Nehru Stadium, possibly in August, according to C. Latha, chairman of the Tamil Nadu Athletics Association (TNAA).

Speaking from Tokyo after attending the Asian Athletics Federation Council meeting on Tuesday, Latha, who represented the TNAA and the State government, said: "We made our presentation (the online presentation was made by J. Meghanatha Reddy, Member Secretary, SDAT) and highlighted the legacy of the Nehru Stadium in hosting international meets and the availability of the practice facility at the Nehru 'B' ground.

"We also stressed that Chennai has an international airport and good hotels close to the venue. The State government will, in any case, relay the main athletics track soon."

C.K. Valson, a member of the Competition Commission for Asian Athletics, inspected the Nehru Stadium last week and was reportedly happy with the track and the practice ground

C.K. Valson, a member of the Competition Commission for Asian Athletics, inspected the Nehru Stadium last week and was reportedly happy with the track and the practice ground.

"Valson was happy with the infrastructure.

"He told us to make arrangements for VIP lounges, modify the seating arrangements and install LED screens. All that remains is for the State government to send a letter to the president of the Asia Athletics Federation confirming that it will bear the entire cost of hosting the meet," Latha added.

A draw will put India in the semifinals

SAFF CHAMPIONSHIP

Press Trust of India
DHAKA

A draw is all it would take to make the semifinals, but defending champion India will eye a comprehensive win when it takes on Maldives in their second and final group match of the South Asian Football Federation (SAFF) Championship here on Wednesday.

India beat Pakistan 3-2 in the Group B match on Thursday, with Suhail Bhatt scoring a first-half brace.

A draw on Wednesday would be enough to not just make the last four but also top the group.

India is competing with a second string squad as the first team is playing two away international friendlies against New Zealand later this week.

Even a 0-1 loss to Maldives can take India to the semifinals as it currently has a goal difference of +1 as opposed to -3 of Maldives.

Endrick considers leaving Real Madrid to play more

FOOTBALL

Agence France-Presse
SINGAPORE

Brazil International forward Endrick said on Tuesday that he wants to play regularly, whether at Real Madrid or elsewhere, as was the case when he joined Lyon on loan last January.

The 20-year-old is set to play a role with the Selecao in a friendly against Japan in Singapore on Saturday.

He spent the second half of last season on loan in the French Ligue 1, where he scored eight goals and provided eight assists in 21 matches for Lyon.

At Real he has been a bit-part player this season, as he was in the first half of the last campaign.

It has left him eyeing another potential January move when the transfer window reopens.

"I don't know what will happen in January, all I ask for is that it is the best thing for my career," he said from Singapore. "I'm very young... I'm still 20 and I'll see what happens. I just want to play, to be happy, to help my teammates, score goals, provide assists, as I was able to do at Lyon, which was one of the best things that happened to me in my life."



Endrick. AFP

That move helped Endrick make coach Carlo Ancelotti's World Cup squad.

But in Madrid, he faces tough competition to make Jose Mourinho's team.

Prolific goal-scorer and a bona fide match-winner

The 41-year-old's bitter fallout with Portugal coach Jorge Jesus pushed him into retirement from international football last week after a 23-year career. The manner of his exit and his dwindling impact in recent years shouldn't detract from his status as the Iberian nation's greatest footballer – he finishes with a record 234 appearances and 146 goals



In July, in the aftermath of Portugal's exit in North America, Ronaldo had sought to put the Euro title on the same pedestal as a World Cup triumph.

GETTY IMAGES



Vivek Krishnan

In the end, there was no fairy-tale farewell under the floodlights. No rousing ovation from the crowd. No tearful goodbyes from his colleagues.

Instead, a five-minute pre-recorded video in the confines of a warmly-lit room, released on social media, marked the closing of the curtains. The words, spoken in Portuguese, appeared rehearsed rather than spontaneous, read out as they were from an A4-size sheet of paper. Interspersing the speech was a montage of cherished memories that offered a whiff of nostalgia at best.

It was a rather sad but predictable way for Cristiano Ronaldo to bow out of international football last week after 23 years with Portugal. Sad, because the 41-year-old forward, given all the goals and records he had chalked up for the Iberian nation, ought to have bid adieu in style with his teammates and adoring fans bearing witness. At the same time, it was predictable, for Ronaldo had wrapped himself in an unsavoury tangle by walking out of Portugal's squad in September ahead of a UEFA Nations League clash against Denmark in Copenhagen after a bitter feud with new coach Jorge Jesus.

Acrimonious exit

As fate would have it, Ronaldo's last appearance in a Portugal jersey came in a 1-0 win over Wales on September 24. The subsequent developments were chaotic, and not commensurate with his status as Portugal's biggest icon. In his final moments with the national team, he suffered the ignominy of being an unused substitute in a 2-1 win over Norway in Oslo, and stormed straight down the tunnel at the final whistle without acknowledging the applause of the travelling supporters. He left the camp a few days later, alleging that Jesus, who had also served as his manager at Saudi club Al-Nassr previously, had breached his trust. He was slapped with a one-month suspension and a fine of £215 by the Portuguese Football Federation.

The final chapter of a storied international career was in sharp contrast to Lionel Messi's last tango for Argentina. Just as Ronaldo was rapped on his knuckles for his fallout with the Portugal manager, the left-footed genius brought Buenos Aires to a standstill in a 3-0 exhibition-game win over Benin. The wizard from Rosario played the entire 90 minutes, assisted two goals, and scored one. Before, during and after the game, tears and tributes overflowed as the reality of Messi donning the sky blue and white stripes for one final time dawned.

If Ronaldo's exit wasn't as grand, he has nobody else to blame. The signs of the veteran forward staying on for much longer than his waning skill warranted were as clear as day for some time. His last two World Cups, in North America in 2026 and in Qatar in 2022, fell substantially short of expectations. He scored a total of four goals in 10 matches across the two editions. Worse, he created zero chances for his teammates in this year's show-piece as Portugal was eliminated by Spain in the round of 16, appearing to be a faint caricature of the twinkle-toed talisman who could make defenders shudder at his sight.

The explosive pace to go past opponents had deserted the Portuguese superstar. So had the trickery to dribble his way through a cluster of bodies. What was left was merely the instinct of a poacher to find the back of the net from close range. Despite the limitations in his twilight, his enormous self-belief, a boon in his younger years that drove him towards the highest of highs, came in the way of the realisation that he could no longer change games at the elite level.

For all of his shortcomings in the final stretch, it would be grossly disingenuous to determine Ronaldo's legacy through the prism of the last few years. When he made his debut for Portugal in 2003 as a spunky 18-year-old inclined to a step-over on the flanks, smartphones and social media were non-entities. Cut to 2026, it is hard to imagine a world without either. It encapsulates just how long Ronaldo has spent in Portugal's crimson red, often taking up the mantle of the vocalist, percussionist and conductor of the symphony all by himself.

Portugal's greatest

The stratospheric numbers stand testimony to Ronaldo's colossal contribution. The man from Madeira, an autonomous archipelago in the North Atlantic Ocean, finishes up with 234 appearances and 146 goals in international football. On both counts, nobody has a higher tally in the history of the *beautiful game*. He led Portugal to the Euro 2016 title, and also won the UEFA Nations League in 2019 and 2025. Add all his illustrious feats at the club level to the mix and there is no contesting Ronaldo's standing as the greatest footballer from his country.

The only men meriting a discussion in the same breath are Eusebio and Luis Figo. The former was a pioneer at a time when Portugal was just beginning to make strides as a footballing nation, famously guiding it to a third-placed finish in the 1966 FIFA World Cup in England. Figo, meanwhile, paved the way by being the first from his country to sparkle in the highest echelons of club football in Europe – he played for both Barcelona and Real Madrid in Spain as well as for Inter Milan in Italy with distinction.

Ronaldo's superstardom straddled both worlds. His initial rise to prominence was a consequence of signing for English club giant Manchester United in 2003 under the watch of Sir Alex Ferguson. He set up a strong base in an ecosystem armed with a global audience, winning three Premier League titles and one Champions League crown with the Red Devils. The inevitable big-money move to Real Madrid in 2009 cemented his elevation to a 'Galactico', a label that Ronaldo embraced with open arms.

Simultaneously, he enjoyed an organic rise in the Portugal ranks. As the likes of Figo and Rui Costa grew older, they passed on the baton to the mercurial youngster. In his formative years, Ronaldo was a winger following convention. Positioned on the right flank, he would look to use his box of tricks to beat the fullback on the outside and float crosses into the 18-yard box. As tactics in the modern game evolved, the trend of inverted wide men became more prevalent. The switch made Ronaldo more of a goal-scoring threat, for he could cut in from the left wing and take aim at goal with his thunderous right foot.

Evolution in playing style

Once Ronaldo took centre-stage at Real Madrid, he imbibed the qualities of a traditional centre-forward too. A heated individual battle with Messi, then wowing the world in Barcelona's blue and garnet, seemed to spur him towards amassing extraordinary numbers in front of goal. The shift is exemplified even by his returns for the national team: after 25 goals in a seven-year period from 2003 to 2010, he found the net on 74 occasions from 2011 to 2019.

If there was a missing piece in Ronaldo's trophy cabinet, it was the conspicuous absence of a World Cup. He participated in six editions, but the closest he came to hoisting the greatest prize was a fourth-placed finish on debut in Germany 2006. He would never say so publicly, but the fact that his celebrated rival, Messi, conquered the global stage at Qatar 2022 is bound to rankle at some level.

For Ronaldo, the high point as a crucial cog in the collective was Portugal's march to silverware at Euro 2016. It wouldn't have come about without his spectacular brace in a 3-3 draw against Hungary in the group stage. After a tepid start to the tournament that saw Portugal share the spoils against Iceland and Austria, it was on the precipice of elimination during the course of a humdinger where Hungary took the lead thrice. Ronaldo equalised twice to save Portugal by the skin of its teeth, with a stalemate ensuring its progress to the knockouts as one of the four best third-placed teams.

Portugal's jittery run culminated in a final showdown against host France. The summit clash aroused mixed emotions for the Portugal skipper – he left the turf in tears after a knee injury forced his substitution in the 25th minute, but his brooding disappointment was ultimately superseded by boundless joy when Eder's strike in extra time helped Portugal scrape a 1-0 victory.

On the same pedestal

In July, in the aftermath of Portugal's exit in North America, Ronaldo had sought to put the Euro title on the same pedestal as a World Cup triumph.

"I have won three titles for Portugal; before Cristiano Ronaldo, Portugal hadn't won a single title," Ronaldo said. "The biggest title the national team has ever won was in 2016, the European Championship, which, to be honest, is just as significant to me as a World Cup."

The remarks were symbolic of his polarising nature, further highlighted by the drama that unfolded at the very end of his Portugal stint. But when weighing up his career, he was a prolific goal-scorer and a bona fide match-winner above all else. In his retirement speech, he signed off by saying, "Portugal will always be a part of me."

The reverse, with a slight alteration, is equally true. He will always be a prominent part of Portugal's footballing history.

THE GIST

For all of his shortcomings in the final stretch, it would be grossly disingenuous to determine Ronaldo's legacy through the prism of the last few years. When he made his debut for Portugal in 2003 as a spunky 18-year-old inclined to a step-over on the flanks, smartphones and social media were non-entities. Cut to 2026, it is hard to imagine a world without either

The man from Madeira, an autonomous archipelago in the North Atlantic Ocean, finishes up with 234 appearances and 146 goals in international football. On both counts, nobody has a higher tally in the history of the beautiful game

He led Portugal to the Euro 2016 title, and also won the UEFA Nations League in 2019 and 2025. Add all his illustrious feats at the club level to the mix and there is no contesting Ronaldo's standing as the greatest footballer from his country

If there was a missing piece in Ronaldo's trophy cabinet, it was the conspicuous absence of a World Cup. He participated in six editions, but the closest he came to hoisting the greatest prize was a fourth place finish on debut in Germany 2006

Ronaldo's superstardom straddled both worlds. His initial rise to prominence was a consequence of signing for English giant Manchester United in 2003 under the watch of Sir Alex Ferguson

